

LG Sandhu, CM Rekha flag off 200 EV buses

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday flagged off 200 electric buses, taking the total Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) bus fleet to nearly 6,800. Of the 200 buses, 56 are Ladies Special buses, which will cater to university areas and other high-demand routes for women.

The Delhi-Karnal interstate e-bus service was also launched on the occasion. A public EV charging station at DTC's Rajghat Depot-1 was inaugurated on the occasion.

"Among all the initiatives being launched today, ladies special buses are the most important for me personally and the government. During my student days, I remember using university special buses



Delhi LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu, CM Rekha Gupta and others during the flagging-off ceremony of 200 new EV buses in New Delhi

to travel to college and home, but for the last 28 years, these buses were not available," the chief minister said, addressing a gathering.

With the latest addition, Delhi's overall bus fleet will comprise 4,938 electric buses and 1,750 CNG buses, she

said, adding that the city has the highest number of electric buses in the country.

Sandhu said the Ladies Special buses were not just a mode of transportation but also a safe means of mobility. He said 'Gati Shakti' was an important pillar of this vision,

under which better mobility, stronger connectivity and a green economy needed to be promoted.

The launch of 200 new electric buses in Delhi and the public EV charging station at Rajghat Depot were important steps in this direction.

Under the plan, the DTC will introduce 30 Ladies Special trips on 15 high-demand routes and 26 University Ladies Special (U-SPL) trips on 13 routes. These bus services will improve connectivity to major employment, educational and institutional centres such as Nehru Place, AIIMS, South Extension, R.K. Puram, Connaught Place, ITO, Delhi Secretariat, Karol Bagh, Kashmere Gate and Shivaji Stadium. The University Ladies Special services will strengthen connectivity for female students to several

prominent Delhi University institutions, including Hindu College, Ramjas College, Daulat Ram College, Shri Ram College, LSR, Gargi College, ARSD and Hansraj College.

The chief minister described the Ladies Special bus service as an important step towards ensuring safe, dignified and convenient travel for women and female students. The Chief Minister said security arrangements had been ensured on these dedicated services along with women conductors.

The new fleet of 200 electric buses comprises 88 12-metre EV buses and 112 DEVI 9-metre EV buses. With their induction, Delhi's electric bus fleet has crossed 5,000.

The launch of the Delhi-Karnal interstate e-bus service is an important step towards connecting Delhi with major cities in Haryana

through clean and convenient public transport. Five electric, air-conditioned buses will operate on the route, with a total of 10 trips scheduled daily in each direction. The fare from Kashmere Gate to Karnal has been fixed at around ₹212.

As part of efforts to strengthen the city's electric mobility ecosystem, the chief minister also launched a public EV charging station at Rajghat Depot-1.

"We are not only making EV charging infrastructure but also offering subsidies under EV policy," she said.

The Government also launched five fully electric, air-conditioned inter-state buses on the Delhi-Karnal route. The service will operate 10 daily trips in each direction on the approximately 133-km one-way corridor.

Govt promotes, gives new postings to 111 officials to improve service delivery



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has ordered the promotion and new postings of 111 officials under the subordinate services cadre to strengthen administration and improve service delivery in key departments, including health, education and revenue.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, in a statement issued on Wednesday, said making the administrative system efficient and accountable is her government's priority. "The administrative decision will accelerate public service delivery in key departments such as health, education and revenue," she said.

The Services Department of the Delhi government has issued orders for the promotion and new postings of 111 officials.

The chief minister said most of the officials have been posted as deputy directors in the Education Department, which will help ensure the smooth functioning of the school education system.

Other officials have been promoted and posted as deputy medical superintendents in major Delhi hospitals like Lok Nayak Hospital, GB Pant Hospital, GTB Hospital, Baba Saheb Ambedkar Hospital and Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital and as

deputy directors in the Directorate of Health Services.

Some other officials have been promoted and appointed as sub-divisional magistrates (headquarters) in various sub-divisions of the revenue department and as assistant commissioners in the Trade and Taxes Department.

Promoted officials have also been posted as deputy secretaries at the Lt Governor's office, the Law and Justice Department and the Directorate of Vigilance, the statement said.

The chief minister said the promotions reflect the government's commitment to advancing the careers of its employees. The decision is an important step towards addressing the long-standing stagnation in the Delhi administrative Subordinate Services (DASS) cadre, she added.

Grade-I officers of DASS had been facing career stagnation for a long time. The promotions have been made possible under the directions of the Delhi High Court and the process of cadre restructuring. Under the order, officers in various departments, including education, health, revenue and the LG Secretariat, have been posted to their new positions, including those of Deputy Director, Deputy Secretary and Deputy Medical Superintendent.

DELHI COURT GRANTS BAIL TO ACCUSED IN ₹10 CRORE THREAT CASE

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Patiala House Court has granted regular bail to Gurbinder Singh, an accused in a case involving alleged threats and a demand for ₹10 crore from defence entrepreneur Sahil Luthra.

Singh was granted bail on August 17 by Judicial Magistrate First Class Animesh Kumar. He had been in custody since June 13, when he was arrested along with Jaswant Singh and Shamsher Singh in connection with the case.

According to the complaint and prosecution's case, Luthra, founder of Vijyan Trishul Defence Solution Private Limited and a resident of Chanakyapuri, allegedly received threatening WhatsApp messages and calls from international numbers. The messages purportedly demanded ₹10 crore and threatened harm to Luthra and his family if the money was not paid.

The alleged threats were received during August-September 2025 and again in June this year.

An FIR was initially registered at Chanakyapuri Police Station before the investigation was transferred to the Crime Branch of the Delhi Police. The prosecution has alleged that the three accused were part of a conspiracy connected with the threats.

Delhi on alert over lumpy skin disease: Kapil Mishra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Development Minister Kapil Mishra said on Wednesday that the government is fully alert to the situation around Lumpy Skin Disease (LSD) among livestock in the capital, with only sporadic cases reported so far this year.

Mishra made the statement after chairing a review meeting with the Development Commissioner and the Director of Animal Husbandry. He said the Animal Husbandry Unit under the Development Department is continuously monitoring the disease situation across the National Capital Territory.

The minister said the Delhi government is taking all necessary measures to protect livestock and prevent the spread of the disease, with preventive and

control steps being implemented in line with guidelines issued by the central Department of Animal Husbandry and Dairying. Mishra said a vaccination campaign against LSD is currently underway in Delhi. He said the government is working to ensure adequate availability of LSD vaccines at all veterinary hospitals and dispensaries across the city so that livestock can be vaccinated without delay.

Appealing to livestock owners, Mishra urged them to get their animals vaccinated against the disease and extend full cooperation to veterinary teams carrying out vaccination and disease control activities. He also advised owners to closely monitor their animals' health and contact the nearest government veterinary hospital or dispensary immediately if any suspected symptoms are noticed.



Mishra said that if an animal shows signs of infection or is suspected to have contracted the disease, it should be immediately separated from other animals and kept in an isolated location. He said owners should then consult a qualified veterinary professional without delay to prevent further spread among the herd.

The minister reiterated the Delhi government's commitment to safeguard

ing livestock health and controlling any potential outbreak of the disease. He said the situation is being monitored continuously and that all necessary measures will be taken as required going forward.

Lumpy Skin Disease is a viral infection affecting cattle and buffaloes, typically spread through insect vectors and characterised by skin nodules, fever and reduced milk production in

affected animals.

Outbreaks in previous years have caused significant losses to livestock owners in several states, prompting closer monitoring by animal husbandry departments across the country. Officials in the Development Department said the current caseload in Delhi remains limited to isolated instances rather than a widespread outbreak, though the government is maintaining heightened surveillance given the disease's history of rapid spread in livestock populations elsewhere in the country.

The ongoing vaccination drive is expected to cover livestock across Delhi in a phased manner, with veterinary teams working to reach animals in both urban and semi-urban pockets of the city where cattle and buffalo rearing continues on a smaller scale.

Couple held for selling ₹1.10 crore flat using forged documents

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

A Delhi couple has been arrested for allegedly selling a ₹1.10-crore flat in Gurugram using fake documents, police said on Wednesday.

The accused, identified as Bhanu Priya Narang (33) and her husband Dhruv Sharma (35), allegedly used a fake bank statement, foreclosure-related screenshots and documents purportedly showing a bank no-objection certificate (NOC) to convince the buyer that there were no dues on the property, police said.

According to police, a man lodged a complaint on April 4 alleging that the couple had agreed to sell him a



flat in Sushant Lok Phase-2 for ₹1.10 crore.

The accused had informed him that a bank loan was outstanding on the flat and assured him that the loan would be cleared and the bank NOC and original documents would sub-

sequently be handed over, police said. The complainant paid the entire ₹1.10 crore to the accused in instalments on different dates.

To convince him that the loan had been repaid, the accused allegedly showed him a bank statement and screenshots related to the foreclosure of the loan. Relying on these documents, the complainant was allegedly taken into confidence, police said.

On January 23, 2025, the sale deed of the flat was executed in the name of the complainant and his wife.

However, subsequent verification with the bank revealed that a loan of ₹35.70 lakh was still outstanding against the property. The bank statement shown by the accused was also

allegedly found to be fake, police said.

Following the complaint, a case was registered under relevant sections at the Sector 56 police station.

The police team arrested both accused on Tuesday. The husband and wife are residents of Delhi, police said.

"During police interrogation, it emerged that the accused had sold the said flat to the complainant. Despite not clearing the outstanding bank loan of ₹35.70 lakh on the flat, the accused showed fake photographs/documents relating to the bank statement/NOC to convince the complainant that the loan had been cleared," a senior investigating officer said.

Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Ltd. (Arcil)
Acting in its capacity as Trustee of various Arcil Trusts
Arcil office: The Ruby, 10th floor, 29, Senapati Bapat Marg, Dadar (West) Mumbai-400 028
Website: <https://XpertAuction.com>; CIN-U65999MH2002PLC134884

PUBLIC NOTICE FOR SALE THROUGH ONLINE E-AUCTION IN EXERCISE OF THE POWERS UNDER THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 (SARFAESI ACT) READ WITH RULES 6, 8 & 9 OF SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002
Notice is hereby given to the public in general and to the Borrower (s) / Guarantor (s) / Mortgagee (s), in particular, that the below described immovable properties mortgaged/charged to the Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Limited, acting in its capacity as Trustee of various Arcil Trusts ("ARCIL") (pursuant to the assignment of financial asset vide registered Assignment Agreements), will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is", "Whatever there is" and "Without recourse basis" by way of online e-auction, for recovery of outstanding dues of together with further interest, charges and costs etc., as detailed below in terms of the provisions of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 ("Act") read with Rules 6, 8 and 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 ("Rules").

Name of the Borrower / Co-Borrowers / Guarantors / Mortgagees	LAN No. & Selling Bank	Trust Name	Outstanding amount as per SARFAESI Notice dated 1/Sep/2025	Possession type and date	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)
				Date of Inspection	Reserve Price
				Type of Property and Area	Date & Time of E-Auction
Borrower: Munni Devi Co-Borrower: Ajay Chauhan Guarantor: Kiran Raghav	MHL000000180763 Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Limited (VHFC)	Arcil-Trust-2026-019	Rs.1,02,39,60/- as on 11/Aug/2025 + further Interest thereon + Legal Expenses.	Physical on 9/Dec/2025 Will be arranged on request Area 120 Sq yds	Rs. 133700/- (Rupees One Lakh Thirty Three Thousand Seven Hundred only) Rs. 1337000/- (Rupees Thirteen Lakh Thirty Seven Thousand only) 28-09-2026 at 11:00 AM

Description of the Secured Asset being auctioned: Property At, Plot measuring area 120 sqyd. Kharsa no. 323 Mauza Dhorera Bangar Thesil Dist. Mathura. Bounded As follows - North- Road South- Others East- Plot of Shivam Dixit West- Plot of Shery Dixit

Pending Litigations known to ARCIL	Encumbrances/Dues known to Nil ARCIL
Last Date for submission of Bid	Same day 2 hours before Auction
Bid Increment amount:	As mentioned in the BID document

Demand Draft to be made in name of:	Arcil-Trust-2026-019	Payable at Par
RTGS details	Arcil-Trust-2026-019, Trust Account No: 57500001878336, HDFC Bank Limited, Branch: Kamla Mill Extn Ctr, Mumbai, IFSC Code: HDFC0000542	
Name of Contact person & number	Arpit Choudhary arpit.choudhary@vastuhfc.com; 73573 75589, Santosh Tiwari - 99204 90126, Shekhar Sharma - 86557 96116, Navneet Singh - 99991 05933	

Terms and Conditions:

- The Auction Sale is being conducted through e-auction through the website <https://XpertAuction.com> and as per the Terms and Conditions of the Bid Document, and as per the procedure set out therein.
- The Authorised Officer ("AO") ARCIL shall not be held responsible for internet connectivity, network problems, system crash down, power failure etc.
- At any stage of the auction, the AO may accept/reject/modify/cancel the bid/offer or post-poned the Auction without assigning any reason thereof and without any prior notice.
- The successful purchaser/bidder shall bear any statutory dues, taxes, fees payable, applicable GST on the purchase consideration, stamp duty, registration fees, etc. that is required to be paid in order to get the secured asset conveyed/delivered in his/her/its favour as per the applicable law.
- The intending bidders should make their own independent enquiries/ due diligence regarding encumbrances, title of secured asset and claims/rights/dues affecting the secured assets, including statutory dues, etc., prior to submitting their bid. The auction advertisement does not constitute and will not constitute any commitment or any representation of ARCIL. The Authorized Officer of ARCIL shall not be responsible in any way for any third-party claims/rights/dues.
- The particulars specified in the auction notice published in the newspaper have been stated to the best of the information of the undersigned; however undersigned shall not be responsible / liable for any error, misstatement or omission.
- The Borrower/ Guarantors/ Mortgagees, who are liable for the said outstanding dues, shall treat this Sale Notice as a notice under Rules 8 and 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, about the holding of the above mentioned auction sale.
- In the event, the auction scheduled hereinabove fails for any reason whatsoever, ARCIL has the right to sell the secured asset by any other methods under the provisions of Rule 6(5) of the Rules and the Act.

Place: Mathura
Date: 20.08.2026

Sd/-
Authorized Officer
Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Ltd.

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Name of the Borrower / Co-Borrowers / Guarantors / Mortgagees	LAN No. & Selling Bank	Trust Name	Outstanding amount as per SARFAESI Notice dated 22/May/2025	Possession type and date	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)
				Date of Inspection	Reserve Price
				Type of Property and Area	Date & Time of E-Auction
Borrower: Manju Jha Co-Borrower: Kishan Chandra Jha, Sanju Sharma	MHL000000126012 Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Limited (VHFC)	Arcil-Trust-2026-019	Rs.4,07,08,8/- as on 13/May/2025 + further Interest thereon + Legal Expenses.	Physical on 25/Feb/2026 Will be arranged on request Area 594 sq ft	Rs. 26000/- (Rupees Twenty Six Thousand only) Rs. 260000/- (Rupees Two Lakh Sixty Thousand only) 28-09-2026 at 11:00 AM

Description of the Secured Asset being auctioned: Plot situated at Kharsa No 546 Purani Abadi, Mauja Dhanauli Tehsil and District Agra 282001 Area 594 sq. ft. On East Side. * Plot of Ram Kanhaiya On West Side. * Plot of Banti On North Side. * 5ft 2inch wide Road On South Side. * Plot of Shyam Sundar

Pending Litigations known to Nil ARCIL	Encumbrances/Dues known to Nil ARCIL
Last Date for submission of Bid	Same day 2 hours before Auction
Bid Increment amount:	As mentioned in the BID document

Demand Draft to be made in name of:	Arcil-Trust-2026-019	Payable at Par
RTGS details	Arcil-Trust-2026-019, Trust Account No: 57500001878336, HDFC Bank Limited, Branch: Kamla Mill Extn Ctr, Mumbai, IFSC Code: HDFC0000542	
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- The particulars specified in the auction notice published in the newspaper have been stated to the best of the information of the undersigned; however undersigned shall not be responsible / liable for any error, misstatement or omission.
- The Borrower/ Guarantors/ Mortgagees, who are liable for the said outstanding dues, shall treat this Sale Notice as a notice under Rules 8 and 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, about the holding of the above mentioned auction sale.
- In the event, the auction scheduled hereinabove fails for any reason whatsoever, ARCIL has the right to sell the secured asset by any other methods under the provisions of Rule 6(5) of the Rules and the Act.

Place: Agra
Date: 20.08.2026

Sd/-
Authorized Officer
Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Ltd.

COSCO (INDIA) LIMITED
CIN : L25199DL1980PLC010173
Regd. Office : 2/8, Roop Nagar, Delhi-110 007
Website : www.cosco.in Email : mail@cosco.in Tel. : 91-11-23843000 Fax : 91-11-23846000
BSE Trading Symbol: COSCO

NOTICE
SPECIAL WINDOW FOR SHAREHOLDERS' TRANSFER AND DEMATERIALISATION OF PHYSICAL SECURITIES
Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) vide Circular No. H0/38/13/11(2)2026-MIRSD-POD/1/3750/2026 dated January 30, 2026, has decided to open another special window for transfer and dematerialisation ("demat") of physical securities which were sold/purchased prior to April 01, 2019. This special window shall be open up to February 04, 2027. The special window shall also be available for such transfer requests which were submitted earlier and were rejected/returned/not attended to due to deficiency in the documents/process/ or otherwise. The securities so transferred shall be mandatorily credited to the transferee only in demat mode and shall be in under lock-in period for a period of one year from the date of registration of transfer. Such securities shall not be transferred/lien marked/pledge during the lock-in period. Cases involving disputes between transferor and transferee will not be considered in this window and may be settled through court/NCLT process. Further Securities which have been transferred to Investor Education and protection Fund (IEPF) shall not be considered under this window for processing. For Clarity with regard to applicability of this window, the matrix below may be referred to:

Execution date of Transfer Deed	Lodge before 01-04-2019?	Original Share Certificate available?	Allowed in the specified window
Before 01-04-2019	No (it is fresh Lodgement)	Yes	✓
Before 01-04-2019	Yes (It was rejected/ returned earlier)	Yes	✓
Before 01-04-2019	Yes	No	X
Before 01-04-2019	No	No	X

Shareholders wishing to take advantage of this special window may contact Company's Registrar and Transfer Agents Skyline Financial Services Pvt. Ltd. Office Add. D-153 A/1st Floor | Okhla Industrial Area, Phase - I New Delhi-110 020. Email-id : admin@skylinertn.com , Tel no. 011-26812682-83, 40450193 to 97. For any clarification, e-mail may be sent to: sudha@cosco.in. This is for your kind information.

For Cosco (India) Limited,
Sd/-
Sudha Singh
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

Place: Delhi
Date : 19th August, 2026

Delhi SIR schedule revised, final voter list to be out on November 4

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Election Commission on Wednesday revised the schedule of the Special Intensive Revision exercise in Delhi, fixing November 4 for the publication of the final voter list. According to the earlier schedule, the final electoral roll was to be published on October 27.

Under the revised schedule, the draft electoral rolls will be published on August 31 instead of August 24, said a statement from the office of Delhi Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) citing an EC letter.

The period of filing claims and objections by the voters

whose names are excluded from the draft rolls has also been changed. Earlier, the claims and objections filing was to be done from August 24 to September 23. Now, the voters can file their claims and objections from August 31 to September 30. The poll officials will dispose of the claims and objections from August 31 to October 29. The door-to-door voter verification exercise under SIR concluded on August 17.

The extension in SIR dates has been necessitated by the rationalisation of polling stations, with the Election Commission mandating that each polling station should have a maximum of 1,200

electors, the poll officials said. The process will take a few more days as the proposals have to be approved and voters subsequently tagged to the new polling stations in the IT system.

"The Commission will take about four to five days to give approval, and the IT process will take another four to five days. That is why the deadline has been extended," the officer said.

In the door-to-door voter verification exercise in Delhi, over 47 lakh voters (33 per cent of the total 1.45 crore) were marked as "uncollectable" as their enumeration forms were not digitised. These voters will be removed



from the electoral rolls to be published on August 31.

As per data shared by the chief electoral office, more than 30 per cent of voters in 47 of Delhi's 70 Assembly constituencies are likely to be

left out of the draft electoral rolls. The data shows significant variation across constituencies, with the proportion of voters facing exclusion ranging from around 20 per cent to nearly 50 per cent.

In several minority-dominated constituencies, between 20 and 40 per cent of voters are likely to be left out of the draft rolls.

Overall, more than 47 lakh of Delhi's 1.45 crore voters, roughly one in three, are set to be excluded from the draft rolls after being classified as "uncollectable" under the exercise. This includes voters whose enumeration forms were not submitted, as well as those marked absent, shifted, dead or duplicate.

Constituencies with upscale areas such as Greater Kailash (35 per cent), Malviya Nagar (38.64 per cent), New Delhi (41.76 per cent) and RK Puram (44.46 per cent) show

higher percentage of voters to be excluded from the draft rolls. In minority-dominated constituencies, voters accounting for 20 to 40 per cent of the electorate will be excluded from the draft electoral rolls.

Another mixed pattern was the economically upward Rajouri Garden constituency, having one of the highest percentages (79.14) of digitised voter forms, whereas Tughlaqabad, having a rural setting, showed the lowest percentage (52.15) of digitised voter forms. In Tughlaqabad, around 48 per cent voters will be excluded from draft rolls of the constituency. Kirari has recorded

68.98 per cent digitisation, Sultan Pur Majra 68.93 per cent and Karawal Nagar 67.19 per cent.

Constituencies such as Mangol Puri, Uttam Nagar and Seelampur also showed digitisation above 76 per cent, while Bawana, Madipur, Narela and Matiala are in the 75-76 per cent range, implying relatively

lesser percentage of voters to be excluded in the draft rolls. Several constituencies in south and southeast Delhi remain below 60 per cent, including Kasturba Nagar (55.97), RK Puram (55.54) and Okhla (54.67), meaning a higher percentage of voters are facing exclusion.

Court sends Satyendar Jain, 4 others to judicial custody in corruption case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Wednesday sent former minister Satyendar Jain, ex-Delhi Jal Board CEO Udit Prakash Rai and three others in the alleged corruption case involving the tendering process for sewage treatment plant projects of the DJB to 14-day judicial custody.

Special Judge Dig Vinay Singh also sent Ankit Srivastava, a former contractual consultant with the DJB, to two days of police custody.



AAP leader Satyendar Jain, centre, being produced before the court in New Delhi

over alleged large-scale irregularities, manipulation of tender conditions and criminal conspiracy in the tendering process related to augmentation and upgradation of sewage treatment plants of the DJB.

Meanwhile AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal on Wednesday questioned the arrest of former Delhi minister Satyendar Jain, claiming that it was directly ordered by

Union home minister Amit Shah, while Delhi chief minister Rekha Gupta alleged that the previous government's scams were getting exposed.

Kejriwal made the remarks in a post on X, a day after Jain and five others were arrested in connection with an alleged corruption case involving the tendering process for sewage treatment plant projects of the DJB. "An ACB official revealed that there was no plan for ACB

to arrest Satyendra Jain until morning. Then in the afternoon, a direct call came from Amit Shah saying, 'Arrest him'. That's when the arrest was made," Kejriwal claimed.

Asked about Jain's arrest, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta alleged the "scams" under the previous Kejriwal government are now coming to light.

She told reporters on the sidelines of an event that 19 reports of the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) of India tabled in the Delhi Assembly revealed the corruption under the AAP government, and the investigative agencies are taking action on them. "The seeds sown by them are now coming to light. Jain has gone to jail because of the scam committed by him in the Delhi Jal Board (DJB). Action is underway and the agencies are doing their work," she said.

Jain and former DJB CEO Udit Prakash Rai were among six persons arrested by the Anti-Corruption Branch in connection with the case.

Pakistani national detained in Old Delhi for illegal stay

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

On August 15, the Delhi Police Crime Branch detained a Pakistani national in Old Delhi for allegedly living in the city without valid documents. Some reports named him as Mohammad Adnan. He is said to have entered India through the Nepal border and worked as a cook at a local restaurant.

Police sources said the detention took place during routine checks for illegal stays by foreign nationals, which were stepped up around Independence Day. The man had been living quietly in Old Delhi and working among locals to avoid attention. Authorities said he entered India without a valid visa or documents, using the open India-Nepal border. This border allows free movement for Indian and Nepalese citizens under the 1950 Treaty of Peace and Friendship, but not for people from other countries.

Investigators looked closely at the man's family background. Sources said his

mother was originally from Delhi. She married a Pakistani national years ago, moved to Pakistan, and became a Pakistani citizen. This family connection may have influenced his decision to come to India. However, officials emphasised that it did not give him any legal right to live or work in the country.

After his arrest, the man was questioned thoroughly by the Delhi Police Crime Branch and central intelligence agencies. They verified his identity, tracked his movements in India, and reviewed his activities in Delhi to ensure there were no security threats. Officials said they found no links to terrorism or anti-India activities. Background checks and digital searches also found no evidence that he was involved in extremist groups or other crimes besides the immigration offence.

After questioning ended and security agencies found no national security concerns, the Crime Branch handed him over to the Foreigners Regional Registration Officer (FRRO).



The FRRO has begun the process to deport him to Pakistan. Authorities are also working to determine exactly how he entered India and whether anyone helped him.

This case comes at a time when Delhi Police and central agencies are paying more attention to undocumented foreign nationals in the city. Old Delhi, with its crowded streets and busy markets, has seen similar cases before.

In recent weeks, similar operations have targeted people from other neighbouring countries who overstayed their visas as part of broader efforts to enforce immigration rules. Legal experts say that under the Foreigners Act, 1946, unauthorised entry and stay can lead

to detention and deportation. Since there was no evidence of terrorism in this case, authorities focused on administrative action rather than lengthy criminal proceedings.

After the FRRO completes the required steps, the man is expected to be returned to Pakistan through official channels in coordination with Pakistani authorities. Police sources said they are still investigating how he entered India and are looking for any patterns or people who may have helped him. This could help improve border management in the future.

As of Wednesday evening, the deportation process was still ongoing, and no further details were given about when the man would be sent out of India. Officials said they remain committed to protecting India's immigration system and carefully checking each case. This incident highlights the ongoing challenges of open land borders and the need for continued cooperation among agencies to address illegal stays effectively.

He lay there bleeding for half an hour: Families recount moments after CNG blast

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Families of workers caught in a CNG station blast in Delhi on Wednesday said they struggled to get their loved ones to hospital, with one family claiming a critically injured worker lay bleeding for nearly half an hour before being taken away.

Family members of 25-year-old Manish found him bleeding at the fuel pump where the blast occurred.

"He lay there for half an hour. He had lost so much blood. How could anyone survive?" his uncle Vijay Prasad said.

Manish had been working at the station for around three years and had reported for his shift at about 2 pm. The blast occurred later in the afternoon while CNG was being refilled in a truck. Prasad said the family received a call informing them that Manish was seriously injured.

"I got a call saying that a cylinder had exploded and Manish was serious. I called my brother, and he, my nephew and several other people came here," he said.

"There was no one to take him. All gas station staff ran away," Prasad said.

Manish was eventually taken to Safdarjung Hospital but had lost a significant amount of blood by then, his uncle said.

Manish was among three workers killed in the blast, police said. The other two victims were identified as Brahmjeet, 34, and Sunny,



30, both residents of Nizampur and employees at the station.

Aditya, a relative of Brahmjeet and Akshay, an injured worker, said the two brothers had been working at the CNG station for around two years. Brahmjeet died on the spot.

"Akshay has severe injuries on his back and internal and blunt trauma. He is in critical condition. Brahmjeet passed away on the spot," Aditya said. Both men were married and had two children each, he said.

The family, which is from Nizampur, rushed to the spot after learning about the blast. "When we arrived, there was no police or ambulance. We had to carry them to Jeevan Jyoti Hospital in Bahadurgarh ourselves," he alleged.

Meanwhile, the CNG blast in a truck has once again brought to the fore the question of how safe such vehicles are and lapses in their certification.

Govt withdraws rule linking third language to class 10 board eligibility

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has withdrawn a provision in its revised class 9 examination and promotion policy that made students ineligible to appear for the class 10 board papers if they failed to qualify in the third language (R3) opted for in the previous class.

Earlier, the Directorate of Education had said that class 9 students who failed to qualify in R3 could still be promoted to the next class if they met the other promotion criteria but must clear the subject while studying in class 10 to be eligible for the board exams.

The provision has now been withdrawn, with the CBSE's guidelines on R3 set to prevail, according to a corrigendum issued on Tuesday.

An official said the provision was withdrawn because of confusion over the interpretation of the earlier order.



The CBSE had introduced a three-language policy in May under the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and the National Curriculum Framework for School Education (NCF-SE) 2023.

The policy that requires class 9 and 10 students to study three languages, at least two of which must be Indian languages, came into effect on July 1. Under the CBSE guidelines, R3 is assessed entirely through school-based internal evaluation with no need for a separate class 10 board exam for the third language.

While R3 marks will appear on the final CBSE certificate, its score will have no bearing on a student's eligibility to appear in the class 10 board. The Delhi Education Department's revised class 9 examination and promotion policy, issued earlier this week, had made the third language compulsory and provided for school-level assessment of the subject.

The revised system also introduced vocational education as a compulsory subject for class 9 students and optional advanced-level exams in mathematics and science.

Under the new scheme, the six main subjects are Language-1, Language-2, Mathematics, Science, Social Science, and Vocational Education (Kaushal Vikas), which will form the basis for academic progression and promotion to class 10.

The directorate also discontinued the Mathematics Basic and Mathematics Standard exam structure for class 9 from the 2026-27 academic session. The existing system will continue for class 10 students in 2026-27.

Eight STPs failed prescribed discharge standards: DPCC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

At least eight sewage treatment plants have failed the prescribed discharge standards for total suspended solids, biochemical oxygen demand and faecal coliform levels in July, the latest DPCC report said.

Testing standards across more than 30 sewage treatment plants (STPs) in the national capital, the report provides data for samples collected from both inlet and outlet points. Flagging the Yamuna Vihar Ph-III STP for non-compliance, the Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) report said the outlet sample from the facility exceeded the set limits for total suspended solids (TSS), biological oxygen demand (BOD) and faecal coliform.

According to the report, the treated discharge from the plant recorded TSS at 32 mg/l against the prescribed limit of 10 mg/l and BOD at 20.4 mg/l against the permissible level of 10 mg/l.



The faecal coliform count at the facility was 7,600 MPN/100 ml, significantly above the prescribed standard of 230 MPN/100 ml, it added. Most Probable Number (MPN) is a statistical unit and method used in microbiology to estimate the concentration of viable microorganisms (such as coliform bacteria) in a liquid sample.

Meanwhile, the sample collected from the STP at Yamuna Vihar showed a faecal coliform level of 1,500 MPN/100 ml, along with high TSS and BOD.

The other STPs that have not met the prescribed limits included those at Mehrauli, Ghitorni, two in Vasant Kunj, Keshopur and Kapashera.

DUSU polls: DU deploys over 500 CCTV cameras, tightens security

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi University administration has stepped up security measures ahead of the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) elections, deploying more than 500 CCTV cameras to monitor key routes across the North and South campuses, a senior official said on Wednesday.

Delhi University Proctor Manoj Kumar Singh said the administration was strictly implementing the recommendations of the Lyngdoh Committee and warned candidates and student groups that violations could lead to cancellation of nominations and, in serious cases, even the election.

"We will strictly follow the Lyngdoh Committee," Singh said during an interaction on election-related law and order arrangements.

The university has been



coordinating with Delhi Police to monitor vehicles on campus routes, and efforts over the past month have helped curb clustering of vehicles, he said.

The administration has also banned printed pamphlets and posters for election campaigning. Candidates have been asked to use handwritten posters only at designated "Wall of Democracy" spaces.

Singh said there had been

no reports of wall defacement or spray painting so far, with university and police teams conducting regular rounds across the campuses.

The proctor has also urged principals of all 54 colleges to set up two "Walls of Democracy", each measuring 10x10 feet — one for DUSU election campaigning and the other for college-level committees.

Singh said only five students would be allowed to

campaign at a time. In women's colleges, only female students would be permitted to campaign.

Vehicles being used for campaigning are also under strict monitoring, with candidates advised to minimise their use. If alcohol or narcotics are found in a candidate's vehicle, the nomination would be cancelled immediately, he said.

The administration has warned candidates against bringing outsiders to the campus and said vehicles found violating election rules could lead to immediate cancellation of nominations.

Delhi Police ACP Rajendra Prasad, who was present at the interaction, said police personnel were keeping a close watch on vehicles, including those with tinted windows, and cases would be registered against violators.

Police are also monitoring improper parking and

other traffic violations around the university, he said, adding that the Cyber Crime Cell was keeping a watch on social media activity related to the elections.

Police personnel will be deployed both in uniform and plainclothes, with the deployment tailored to the situation, Prasad said.

Singh said unruly elements in paying guest accommodations near the North and South campuses would also be monitored, with NCC and NSS cadets being involved in the security arrangements.

On violations, the proctor said candidates could initially be issued memos and may also face fines, besides cancellation of nominations in serious cases. "Our purpose is to conduct a peaceful election. We don't want to punish any student," Singh said, adding that students were being repeatedly advised to comply with the rules.

Kirori Mal College hosts talent hunt for persons with disabilities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Kirori Mal College, University of Delhi, hosted a first-of-its-kind talent hunt and signing competition exclusively for persons with disabilities on Tuesday. The event drew over 60 participants from colleges across the university and the wider National Capital Region.

The event, titled "Tarang: Talent Beyond Boundaries," was held at the Swami Vivekananda Auditorium and featured performances in music, both singing and instrumental, dance, poetry, stand-up comedy and visual arts. Participants with visual, locomotor and speech impairments performed before a packed audience of students, faculty and guests, drawing



multiple standing ovations through the event.

Delivering the inaugural address, Principal Dinesh Khattar said the event was aimed at redefining how society perceives ability rather than simply providing entertainment. He said talent had no disability, describing what is often labelled as limitation as merely a different way of experiencing and expressing the world. He said the college wanted to celebrate and invest in this talent

rather than treat it as something requiring accommodation.

Guest of Honour Dr Vandana Saxena spoke about the transformative power of equal opportunity, saying persons with disabilities did not need sympathy when given a fair platform, but recognition and respect along with the chance to demonstrate their abilities.

Dr Swati Pal said visibility was the first step, but viability remained the ultimate goal. She said Kirori Mal College had set a benchmark for inclusivity through the event, adding that such initiatives directly challenged the stereotype of persons with disabilities as passive recipients of care rather than active contributors to culture.

IN FOCUS



A vegetable vendor wades through a waterlogged road following heavy rainfall in Guwahati, Assam on Wednesday

PTI

ED raids Azam Khan-linked Jauhar University

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has intensified its investigation into Azam Khan, a Samajwadi Party leader who is imprisoned, by conducting searches at about 10 sites associated with him, his trust, and the Mohammad Ali Jauhar University in Uttar Pradesh and Delhi on Wednesday.

Mohammad Ali Jauhar University, a private university founded by Azam Khan in Rampur in 2006, has faced many controversies over its land, construction, and finances. Several ED teams, supported by local police and security, are conducting searches as part of a money-laundering investigation led by the Lucknow office under Section 17 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002.

The searches started early in the morning and took place at buildings in Rampur,

Saharanpur, and Delhi. Among the locations were the Jauhar University campus in Rampur and the Maulana Mohammad Ali Jauhar Trust, both of which were connected to Khan.

The operation targets properties and organisations linked to the senior Samajwadi Party leader, who remains in custody. The university, founded almost twenty years ago in Rampur, Khan's political stronghold, has often faced criticism over its land, construction, and finances.

The ED's latest action is taking place against this background. Officers arrived at the listed locations early in the morning, secured the sites, and then carefully checked the files.

In Rampur, attention remained entirely focused on the university campus, with the academic buildings, administrative offices, and other associated facilities under review. At the same



time, other teams entered Saharanpur to search for additional premises linked to Khan and the trust. In Delhi as well, other locations linked to the same network of organisations were included in the coordinated operation.

The Maulana Mohammad Ali Jauhar Trust, which is closely tied to Azam Khan and helps run the university, is a main focus of the investigation. Investigators are reviewing financial records, land documents, and construction papers related to both the trust and the university.

These searches are being conducted under Section 17 of the PMLA, which authorises the agency to act in money-laundering cases. The day, ensuring the process remained orderly across the multiple sites. The presence of security arrangements reflected the scale of the operation, which spans two sites.

Azam Khan, who has been a leading figure in Uttar Pradesh politics for many years, has faced several legal proceedings in recent years. The current inquiry into money laundering is once

again part of the agency's focus on the financial matters connected to the institutions Azam Khan, a long-time political leader in Uttar Pradesh, has faced several legal cases in recent years. The current money-laundering inquiry is part of the agency's ongoing focus on his financial connections to various institutions and trusts. Because the university has a history of controversies over land, buildings, and finances, it is a key focus for investigators.

During the searches, ED officials collected documents and materials from different locations, which will now be reviewed at the Lucknow office as the investigation continues. The simultaneous searches enabled the teams to cover the widely dispersed locations efficiently. Starting at the university in Rampur and including sites in Saharanpur and several places in Delhi, the simultaneous searches showed the

thorough manner in which the Enforcement Directorate was proceeding.

The exact details of what was seized have not yet been shared, as the materials are still being examined. However, the fact that both the Jauhar University campus and the Maulana Mohammad Ali Jauhar Trust were searched shows how important these organisations are to the money-laundering case. The university's long history of controversies since 2006 remains the backdrop for this investigation.

The ED's Lucknow office is in charge of operations, with several teams working across multiple locations simultaneously. The searches went smoothly with support from local police and security, starting early in the morning and continuing throughout the day. This step further highlights the financial and institutional issues linked to Azam Khan.

Man in dog mask protests stray dog sterilisation in Khandwa

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

A man wearing a dog mask was brought to a public hearing in Khandwa on Tuesday in an unusual protest against alleged irregularities in the Municipal Corporation's stray dog sterilisation programme.

Municipal Corporation Leader of Opposition Deepak Rathore arrived at the weekly Jan Sunwai with a person dressed as a dog to draw attention to what he alleged were discrepancies in the civic body's sterilisation drive.

A police officer posted at the entrance initially tried to stop the two from entering, leading to a brief exchange. Officials later intervened and allowed them to attend the hearing.

Rathore said he had first approached Municipal Corporation officials over the issue but was not satisfied with the explanation provided. He subsequently submitted a complaint citing what he described as a rise in the stray dog population and increasing cases of dog bites.



According to Rathore, 13,225 dog-bite cases were reported in Khandwa over the past four years. He alleged that the civic body had spent more than Rs 40 lakh on sterilisation drives, yet the stray dog population continued to increase.

Using the masked person to make his point, Rathore claimed that the 'dog' had undergone sterilisation but later fathered six puppies. He questioned the effectiveness of the programme and the manner in which the steril-

isation work was being carried out.

"If lakhs of rupees were truly spent on neutering dogs, why has the stray population not dropped, and why are bite cases rising?" Rathore asked, stressing that the issue was linked directly to public safety.

Rathore submitted a memorandum to ADM Kashiram Badole seeking a comprehensive inquiry into the financial and technical aspects of the sterilisation programme. He demanded

scrutiny of the tender process, the eligibility of the agency engaged for the work, payment records and verification of dogs claimed to have been sterilised.

He also sought registration of an FIR against officials or contractors if an investigation establishes fraudulent billing or violations of rules.

Badole assured Rathore that the allegations would be investigated and appropriate action taken based on the findings.

The unusual protest attracted attention on social media, with users reacting to the use of a dog costume to highlight the issue.

While several users described the protest as creative and effective, others responded with humour, saying the unusual appearance ensured that the complaint received attention.

The protest has also brought renewed focus on the effectiveness, transparency and monitoring of municipal sterilisation programmes and their role in controlling the stray dog population and reducing dog-bite incidents.

Delhi-Islamabad tit-for-tat returns as India acts outside Pakistan mission

The Pioneer
Exclusive

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Authorities in New Delhi have removed unauthorised structures and encroachments outside the Pakistan High Commission, in what is being seen as a reciprocal move following the dismantling of parking poles outside the Indian High Commission in Islamabad.

The structures cleared in New Delhi were located near the visa section of the Pakistani mission and stood outside its designated perimeter. The action was carried out by the concerned agencies, according to people familiar with the matter.

The move comes days after Pakistani authorities removed parking poles installed outside the Indian High Commission in Islamabad. In the past, similar tit-for-tat measures have featured prominently during



Pakistan High Commission in Delhi

FILE PHOTO

periods of strained India-Pakistan relations, including reciprocal staff reductions, tighter access controls and administrative restrictions.

The latest action comes against the backdrop of deeply strained bilateral ties, with India continuing to accuse Pakistan of supporting cross-border terrorism. Relations between the two countries remain at one of their lowest points in decades, more than a year after a four-day military confrontation that followed the deadly terror attack in Pahalagam.

In April 2025, terrorists

trained and backed by Pakistan killed 26 people in Pahalagam in Jammu and Kashmir. India subsequently launched Operation Sindoor, targeting terror infrastructure in Pakistan and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir. The military confrontation, the most serious escalation between the two countries since the 1999 Kargil conflict, ended after Pakistan reached out for a ceasefire.

Since then, formal diplomatic engagement between the two countries has remained largely frozen. Bilateral trade remains sus-

pended, the main land border crossing is closed and visa arrangements have been sharply restricted. The Indian and Pakistani high commissions in New Delhi and Islamabad are also functioning with reduced staff.

India has also placed the Indus Waters Treaty, signed in 1960, in abeyance. New Delhi has said the treaty will remain in abeyance until Pakistan "credibly and irrevocably" ends its support for cross-border terrorism. The Indian government has maintained that normal and neighbourly relations with Pakistan can resume only in an environment free from violence and terrorism.

Despite the diplomatic freeze, some military-to-military communication channels remain operational. Weekly telephone conversations between the Directors General of Military Operations (DGMO) of the two countries continue, while the ceasefire along the Line of Control has largely held, with only limited reported violations.

Army, Delhi Police destroy arms seized...

The overall situation remains worrying. A senior Delhi Police official said that as the controlled explosions and destruction ended in Narela, this event shows that fighting terrorism is not just about making arrests. It is also about permanently removing the tools of violence.

Govt sharpens Gen-Z outreach on social media

According to sources, overall social media traction of political leaders was also considered as a comparison. The methodology also considered the traction generated by political leaders across the spectrum, from senior national leaders to grassroots-level figures, across major social media platforms.

PM Modi himself has reached out to students through social media on multiple occasions in the wake of protests against alleged NEET paper leaks in different parts of the country. In his Independence Day address, the prime minister also announced a slew of youth-centric initiatives, including free online coaching, an AI skilling programme, a sports talent hunt and an expansion of the civil defence network. He also highlighted opportunities for young people in sectors ranging from manufacturing, space and nuclear energy to semiconductors.

Further, in a bid to reach out Gen Z, it was decided to launch a nationwide outreach programme aimed at engaging with young people and understanding the concerns of students. Under the proposed "One Day, One University" initiative, Union ministers will visit universities across the country and interact directly with students. During these visits, ministers are expected to discuss issues affecting young people and explain Government schemes related to education, employment and other areas of youth development.

The scale of the proposed outreach is significant. Data from the University Grants Commission shows that India has around 1,300 universities. These include 57 central universities and 522 state universities, while the remaining institutions are either deemed-to-be universities or private universities.

Protests and criticism surrounding the NEET examination, along with allegations related to question-paper leaks, have added to concerns among students and their families. Against this backdrop, the Government's outreach effort is expected to give ministers an opportunity to hear students' views directly. The protests have also become a political issue, with opposition parties raising the matter in Parliament.

Sources said Education Minister Pralhad Joshi and Union Youth Affairs and Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya have been tasked with

coordinating the programme with universities and other Union ministers. The initiative was also discussed at the Union Cabinet meeting chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday, the sources said. The initiative could therefore become a platform for dialogue between the Government and young people.

For the outreach to have a lasting impact, however, students' concerns will need to be heard and addressed alongside the Government's efforts to communicate its policies. The proposed programme is intended to combine direct engagement with students and an explanation of Government measures on issues linked to youth development.

JeM operative held by UP ATS before escape

Various young men were drawn into the network, including Umar, Azad Rajput, and Tushar Chauhan, who are said to have come under the handlers' influence and began carrying out tasks for the network, investigators say.

His arrest gave authorities valuable information about the larger ISI-backed network known as Shahzad Bhatti. Union Home Minister Amit Shah said that this network, long suspected of handling ISI funding, radicalisation, and logistics, has been significantly weakened by these operations. Disrupting the Bhatti network is a major setback for the ISI's efforts to rebuild its operations in India after earlier failures.

The recent arrests serve as a warning. Pakistani gangs and terrorists continue to see western Uttar Pradesh as a key area. The fact that several groups are linked to a single region shows that radicalisation channels remain active, even if some operatives have been caught. For now, the network has taken a major hit. The challenge ahead is to make sure western Uttar Pradesh does not become the starting point for future plots, intelligence sources said.

US ambassador backs India on J&K

Abdullah earlier clarified that internal issues of the region would be addressed with the Union Government in New Delhi rather than raised with the US envoy. The meeting was significant as it marked the first interaction between a serving US ambassador and a sitting Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister in more than 15 years. The last such meeting took place in 2011, when then US envoy Timothy Roemer met Abdullah.

Earlier, former J&K CM Mehboota Mufti had also urged Gor to review and withdraw the highest-level travel advisory issued by his country against visiting Kashmir.

FROM PAGE - 1

Congress sticks to 1937 Vande Mataram stand...

The meeting was chaired by party president Mallikarjun Kharge in the presence of CWC members former party chiefs Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi, AICC general secretaries Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, Jairam Ramesh and KC Venugopal, senior leaders Ambika Sonia, Mukul Wasnik, P Chidambaram, among others in attendance.

The 1937 decision came after a debate over the complete version of Vande Mataram and its suitability for national gatherings involving people from different religious and cultural backgrounds. The song, written by Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay in 1875 and later published in *Anandamath*, contains several stanzas beyond the opening two. While the first two stanzas praise the motherland, the later portions contain religious and mythological imagery connected to Hindu goddess Durga.

Congress decision comes after the BJP criticised Congress president Kharge for singing what it called an incomplete version of Vande Mataram during his public meeting in South Goa on Monday. "I sang the Vande Mataram which Mahatma Gandhi, Jawaharlal Nehru sang... the same song which Vallabhbhai Patel and Atal Bihari Vajpayee sang. If that is the crime, then file a case against Gandhiji, Nehru and Vallabhbhai Patel," Kharge said. He also accused the BJP of being unaware of the historical decisions taken by the Congress on the national song and the national anthem.

Kharge further asked chief ministers from the party to work with education experts to come up with a roadmap to overhaul the education and examination system and submit a report to him. The CWC also resolved to corner the Government on the issues of paper leaks, the overall education system, as well as *chanda chori* at the Ram temple at the grassroots level. The Opposition party also alleged that the Government was following a policy of surrendering in the face of Chinese incursions taking place in Arunachal Pradesh.

Addressing a press conference, Venugopal said a detailed discussion was held at the CWC meeting with 88 leaders attending and 33 speaking on the occasion. "We are focused on three-four issues. Number one is paper leaks. The agitation done by the people of the country and the way the Government dealt with that agitation was discussed. The CWC noted that the Monsoon Session of Parliament was successful for the Opposition and the Government was on the back foot," he said.

Rahul Gandhi's *Chhatron ki Goonj* will continue with more such gatherings in 800 cities, some of which will be headed by the former Congress president.

Jharkhand students suspend stir

Before leaving the stadium, protesters sang the national anthem as the administration subsequently removed the tents from the site. The students later took out a thanksgiving procession to Albert Ekka Chowk, where they paid floral tributes to tribal icon Jaipal Singh Munda and martyr Albert Ekka. The mood turned celebratory, with students raising slogans, playing with abirgula and bursting firecrackers.

The JPSC-JSSC Reform Forum and JPSC-JSSC Candidates' Justice Forum claimed that their agitation had forced action in 45 examinations. According to the student groups, 22 examinations have been cancelled, investigations ordered into 17 and six postponed.

But the truce comes with a clear warning. Student leader Kunal Pratap said the agitation had been suspended in view of the Government's recent decisions, but would be revived if concrete action was not visible within 60 days. "We have not withdrawn the movement permanently," student leaders said, making it clear that implementation of the Government's commitments would determine their next step. The protesters also demanded withdrawal of cases registered against students during the August 10 Assembly gherao, arguing that such cases could affect their future.

JPSC-JSSC Reform spokesperson Ravindra Paswan said fulfilling all assurances was essential and warned that failure to do so would amount to a breach of the Government's commitment. For now, the tents are gone. The students, however, have left behind a 60-day deadline—and the possibility of another confrontation if the Government fails to meet it.

Second hotel fire in Bengal kills nine

"Most of the apartments were residential in nature ... but the occupants have left and the apartments have been converted into guest houses apparently with no fire regulations followed ... besides they have also added extra floors and even encroached open spaces which may have contributed to the rescue work," a local said. Initial reports suggested that the fire — that broke out on the third floor — could have been caused by an air-conditioner explosion.

"What made it all the more difficult was the iron staircases that heated up making fire fighters to reach the source of fire," officials said adding there was no fire-fighting system in the building. "Though there were some fire extinguishers they had no dates," one official said adding the escape was made difficult because the exit doors were locked ... one of the victims, an employee and a resident of Jharkhand liter-

ally choked to death as he could not escape because gates were locked, sources said.

The owners of the hotel were at large when reports last came in.

State Urban Development Minister Agnimitra Paul blamed former Kolkata Mayor Firhad Hakim for the "mess that has been created by unplanned construction." She said, "the former Mayor is responsible for all these ... for allowing these unplanned constructions ... there was no supervision ... only illegal acts," adding strict action would be taken for lapses.

Three killed in Delhi CNG pump blast

The identity of the sixth person, who sustained minor injuries and left the scene, remains unknown. Manish's uncle, Vijay Prasad, said his nephew had been working at the fuel pump for around three years and had reported for his shift at about 2 pm on Wednesday. The explosion occurred around 2.30pm or 2.45pm, he said.

Prasad said he received a phone call informing him that a cylinder had exploded and that Manish was seriously injured. He said he immediately called his brother, and along with his nephew and several others, rushed to the spot. "He lay there for half an hour. He had lost so much blood. How could anyone survive?" Prasad said, alleging that Manish remained on the ground at the fuel pump for close to 30 minutes before an ambulance could be arranged and he was taken to Safdarjung Hospital.

Prasad alleged that no one from the fuel station staff was present to assist Manish in the immediate aftermath, saying all gas station employees had fled the scene following the blast. By the time an ambulance arrived and Manish could be moved, he had already lost a significant amount of blood, his uncle said. Sunny, another employee at the fuel pump, died during treatment at the hospital, according to police. cThe Delhi Fire Service said it received a call about the incident at 3.37 pm, following which six fire tenders were dispatched to the location. An officer said the six people standing near the truck at the time of the explosion were rushed to hospital for treatment.

Large teams of police and fire personnel were deployed to the area following the blast, working to secure the site and manage the aftermath. A fire service official said the explosion triggered panic among people in the vicinity of the fuel station, and precautionary measures were carried out to bring the situation under control. Police said the exact cause of the explosion was not immediately known, and an investigation into the incident remains underway. Officials said the probe would examine whether equipment failure, procedural lapses or other factors contributed to the blast during the refuelling process.

App-based driver’s stir turns violent in Odisha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

The ongoing strike by drivers of app-based ride-hailing services turned violent on Wednesday as they allegedly threw stones at police personnel and vandalised their vans, as well as Government-run Ama buses, police said.

Police officials said that at least 13 police personnel were injured while 80 protesters were arrested.

Drivers and bike riders registered with online vehicle aggregators began a cease-work protest on August 17, pressing for their seven-point charter of demands, including a fare hike, reduction in application fees, social security and other benefits.

On Wednesday, hundreds of them took out a rally from Raj Mahal Square and blocked the Mahatma Gandhi Marg, disrupting traffic in Master Canteen Square and areas near the railway station.

When police personnel tried to persuade the protesters to clear the road, the agitators allegedly turned violent and suddenly pelted stones at the force deployed on the spot, a police officer said. Protesters also vandalised three police vans



and several Ama buses, he said.

At least 13 police personnel, including the inspector in charge of the Capital Police Station, sustained injuries, said Narasingha Bhol, the Additional Commissioner of Police (Cuttack-Bhubaneswar). “We are

examining the CCTV footage. Strict legal action will be taken against all those who indulged in the violence,” he said.

Bhubaneswar DCP Jagmohan Meena said about 80 protesters were arrested and all vehicles parked at the protest site were seized.

Police had permitted the protesters to stage a demonstration at Mahatma Gandhi Marg on August 17, but they continued the agitation, he said. “They blocked the major thoroughfare, causing inconvenience to the public.”

Terming the stir “illogical”, the DCP said, “They staged a

protest against private companies. The government has no role in this.”

The situation has returned to normal and vehicular movement has resumed, he added. “We have deployed adequate force at the Lower PMG, and they will be camping there on Thursday too.”

With a large number of cabs, bikes, and auto-rickshaws remaining off the roads, commuters dependent on these services were greatly inconvenienced.

The transport authority has initiated the process to cancel the registration certificate of the seized vehicles, an officer said.

“We are examining the details of the seized vehicles. We will cancel the registration certificate of vehicles that don’t have valid documents,” said Additional Transport Commissioner Sangram Patnaik.

Commenting on the protest, Transport Minister Bibhuti Bhusan Jena said the Government is in the process of preparing a rate chart for the online cab and bike ride operators. “We are planning to further improve the Odisha Yatri app so that the drivers can get maximum benefit from the rides,” said Housing and Urban Development Minister KC Mahapatra.

CBI nets key trafficker feeding Indians into Southeast Asia’s cyber slavery camps

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has arrested a key member of a large network that tricks Indian job seekers into working in scam compounds in Myanmar and Cambodia. The accused, from the Hisar area of Haryana, is said to have trafficked at least four people in 2025 by promising them high-paying jobs abroad. These victims were offered appealing jobs in Southeast Asian countries.

Instead, they were sent to guarded compounds and forced to run online fraud schemes, which investigators call “cyber slavery.” People who managed to escape described harsh conditions, such as being locked up, watched all the time, and exploited. Some had to pay large sums to buy their freedom, while others were only released if they found someone else to replace them. Digital evidence from the accused’s seized mobile phones shows direct links to recruiters in Myanmar and Cambodia. Investigators are also examining cryptocurrency payments believed to be commissions from the compound operators. The phones



show that the network posted job ads on Instagram and coordinated with foreign handlers and recruits through encrypted Telegram chats.

The CBI began investigating this organised group of agents and facilitators in December 2025. After conducting searches at eight locations across four states and arresting three more members of the same network in May and June 2026, authorities see this latest arrest as a breakthrough in dismantling the Indian part of the supply chain behind these overseas scam operations.

This pattern repeats in every case. Young people, whether desperate or ambitious, respond to polished online ads and pay intermediaries for ‘processing fees’ or travel costs. They end up trapped far from home, without legal help and with

little contact with their families. Those who have returned have suffered serious psychological and physical harm.

The CBI has issued a new public warning, urging people to be careful. Any job offer received through social media, messaging apps, or personal contacts should be treated with suspicion unless it has been checked with official government sources or accredited employment agencies. This kind of fraud not only causes financial loss but also puts Indian citizens at risk of modern slavery, physical harm, legal trouble abroad, and long-term psychological trauma. The investigation is still focused on tracking financial transactions, finding other agents who are still at large, and identifying foreign operators who profit from the forced labour of trafficked Indians. Authorities say the network is large and not limited to one area. As long as social media is used for job ads and cryptocurrency hides payments, the supply chain will continue.

Investigators warn that the promise of easy money abroad can quickly lead to cyber slavery. Checking job offers before travelling is now essential. It is the only reliable way to stay safe.

Ahmedabad Cyber Police bust ‘Boss Scam’ ring, exposing 4,500 SIM cards and 21,000 OTPs

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ Ahmedabad

One WhatsApp “Boss Scam” involving ₹1.5 crore in Ahmedabad led Gujarat Police to discover a large international cybercrime network operating in India, China, Pakistan and Hong Kong. As a result, the officers arrested two of the main suppliers from West Bengal, seized almost 4,500 dummy SIM cards, traced the sale of more than 21,000 OTPs, and obtained over 10,000 infected devices throughout the country.

The case started in June when an employee was tricked into transferring ₹1.5 crore after scammers impersonated a senior company executive, or “boss.” The scammers used malicious ZIP files and malware sent through WhatsApp or email to take over the executive’s digital identity, change contact numbers, and request urgent money transfers. The Ahmedabad Cyber Crime Branch recovered ₹1.3 crore and returned it to the victim before continuing the investigation.

Investigators traced the scam to Imran Ali Piyada from North/South 24 Parganas and Injammul (Injamul Mujibbar) Molla from Kolkata, both BA graduates. They were brought to Gujarat on transit warrants. Imran, who worked as a point-of-



sale agent for telecom companies such as Airtel, Jio, Vi, and BSNL, is accused of misusing customers’ biometric data to obtain SIMs in their real names and then activating dummy numbers without their knowledge. He provided these numbers and the OTPs needed to activate WhatsApp accounts to cyber-criminals.

Over about five years, police say Piyada sold around 21,000 OTPs for e-commerce platforms like Amazon and Flipkart, as well as online gaming apps, earning more than ₹21 lakh at about ₹100 each. He also sold about 900 WhatsApp activation OTPs for around ₹250 each, making another ₹2.25 lakh. Injammul managed the supply of mobile numbers, dummy SIMs, and WhatsApp accounts. They used devices capable of handling four SIM cards at once and ran WhatsApp groups that openly offered these services. This

setup was a clear example of “Cybercrime as a Service.” They used Telegram before switching to WhatsApp to avoid detection.

Analysis of the 4,500 SIM cards linked the operation to 251 complaints on the National Cybercrime Reporting Portal from 26 states. These included 194 cases of online financial fraud and at least three Boss Scam complaints. Soon after, investigators found international links. They discovered Chinese-developed malware running on systems in Hong Kong and traced a related call centre to Islamabad. Bank accounts used in the fraud were accessed through China-based VPNs. The money was reportedly moved through several countries and converted into cryptocurrency to hide its origin. Ahmedabad Police Commissioner Anupam Singh Gehlot said the group gave important local telecom and

OTP support to operators in Pakistan and China.

“This group was essentially providing service, offering infrastructure to Pakistan and China to facilitate cyberattacks,” Gehlot said. “They procured SIM cards and provided them to people sitting in other countries. They used Chinese malware and linked these to call centres operated from Islamabad.” More than 10,000 devices, including mobiles, laptops, and desktops connected to the network, have been secured or deactivated, which may have prevented losses of crores of rupees.

The investigation, backed by the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), has found that local partners are helping with international fraud schemes. More arrests and inquiries are still happening.

People and companies have been advised to be on the lookout for unexpected files, WhatsApp messages coming from ‘bosses’, or urgent requests for money transfers. Authorities advise that people verify such requests with reliable contacts and report any suspicious activity to the cyber-crime helplines. This instance of corporate fraud has revealed a professional criminal network that rented out Indian SIM cards, OTPs, and malware, viewing them as ordinary services.

Punjab Police nets three key Bambiha Gang operatives in major deportation in Malaysia

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ Chandigarh/New Delhi

On Wednesday, the Punjab Police deported three wanted members of the Davinder Bambiha gang from Malaysia. This marks another step forward in their ongoing efforts to tackle gangsters operating from outside the country. The Overseas Fugitive Tracking and Extradition Cell (OFTEC) of the Counter Intelligence Wing, along with central agencies, monitored the suspects and arranged for their return.

Jaspreet Singh, also known as Jas Behbal and from Faridkot, along with Ajay Singh and Pawandeep Singh from Sri Ganganagar in Rajasthan, were arrested by the Punjab Police as soon as they arrived at Indira Gandhi International Airport in New Delhi and were subsequently taken to Punjab for questioning. Director General of Police (DGP) Gaurav Yadav called the operation a breakthrough. “Punjab Police achieves a breakthrough against transnational organised crime as OFTEC of the Counter Intelligence Wing, with assistance from Central Agencies, secures the deportation of three wanted operatives linked to the Davinder Bambiha Gang from Malaysia,” Yadav posted on X. He said the three men are wanted for several crimes, including murder, extortion, use of explosives, and a



Punjab DGP Gaurav Yadav

planned hand-grenade attack in Ludhiana, with suspected links to Pakistan’s Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI). Additional DGP Amit Prasad said the deportation followed months of intelligence work. Police tracked the fugitives’ movements and activities before arranging for their arrest in Malaysia and return to India. Inspector General of Police Ashish Choudhary shared more about the accused. Jaspreet Singh, also known as Jas Behbal, went to Malaysia in June 2019. There, he met a fugitive gangster and joined the Davinder Bambiha group, eventually becoming a key member.

He has been officially arrested for the 2025 murder of Yadwinder Singh and the driver of Jeewanjot Singh Chahal, also known as Jugnu, who was a former student leader at Panjab University,

Chandigarh. Ajay Singh and Pawandeep Singh, who were also important members of the gang in Malaysia, are accused of directing others to carry out a hand grenade attack in Ludhiana in 2025. The Ludhiana Police stopped the attack.

On October 27, 2025, police arrested two associates and found a P86 Chinese hand grenade with them. According to police sources, the three men face charges for targeted killings, extortion, and illegal use of explosives. Investigators are also looking into possible ISI links that may have helped the gang operate across borders. Punjab Police’s ongoing “Gangstran Te Vaar” campaign was launched under the directions of Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann. The drive aims to dismantle organised crime networks that have increasingly shifted

their bases to countries such as Malaysia, Indonesia and others to evade Indian law enforcement.

Last month, Punjab Police also deported another fugitive gangster, Jobanjit Singh, also known as Joban Billa, from Jakarta. DGP Yadav stressed the police’s determination: “Punjab Police remains relentless in dismantling transnational organised crime networks. No matter where the fugitives hide, we will track them down and bring them to justice.”

These arrests are expected to provide important information about the Bambiha gang’s structure, funding, and members still abroad. Investigators will question the three men to learn more about their networks, find evidence from past crimes, and stop future attacks.

For Punjab, which has struggled with gangs, drug cartels, and outside influences, these actions show a tougher approach. By going after overseas safe havens, the police are making it harder for these groups to operate. The latest deportations show that distance and foreign borders cannot protect criminals from the law. With the three accused facing serious charges, the next step is to build strong cases that can lead to convictions and further weaken the Davinder Bambiha gang’s activities in India and abroad.

CCPA fines Amazon ₹1 lakh for selling fake Ayodhya Prasad

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Amazon, one of the world’s largest service providers, could never have imagined that selling sweets carrying the name of a religious place can land them in serious trouble.

It was fined Rs one lakh for selling “Shri Ram Mandir Ayodhya Prasad” without taking permission from the Ram Mandir Trust. Imposing the penalty, the Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) said it was not just a misleading practice but an affront to the religious sentiments of crores of consumers.

The CCPA observed that the phrase “Shri Ram Mandir Ayodhya Prasad” carries a specific and well-understood meaning for Hindu devotees where it denotes “sacred food offered to and blessed by the deity at the Ram Mandir, Ayodhya”. Chief Commissioner Nidhi Khare and Commissioner Anupam Mishra passed the order on August 4, noting that the sweets company earned over ₹25 lakh by selling these sweets. “The commercial

appropriation of this phrase for ordinary confectionery products, without any authorisation from the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, constitutes not just a misleading trade practice under the CP Act but an affront to the religious sentiments of crores of consumers,” the order stated.

“The opposite party (Amazon) shall ensure that no product falsely claiming to be ‘prasad’, ‘prasadam’, ‘mahaprasad’, ‘bhog’ or any similar religious offering associated with the religious institutions and shrines named in Para 27 (v) of the order, is listed, hosted, advertised, exhibited, or offered for sale on its platform without verifiable documentary proof of authorisation from the concerned institution.

The opposite party shall prominently display complete seller details including the name, address, customer care number, and grievance officer information on its platform in compliance with Rule 5(3)(a) and Rule 5(3)(e) of the E-Commerce Rules, 2020,” the CCPA said in its order. “The commercial appropriation of this phrase



for ordinary confectionery products, without any authorisation from the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, constitutes not just a misleading trade practice under the CP Act but an affront to the religious sentiments of crores of consumers. The Opposite Party’s platform, by reason of its scale and reach, lent an inherent imprimatur of legitimacy to such listings in the eyes of an average consumer, amplifying the harm caused manifold.

The Authority notes with particular concern the timing of the impugned listings. The products falsely claiming

to be ‘Shri Ram Mandir Ayodhya Prasad’ were listed on the Opposite Party’s platform prior to the Pran Pratishtha (consecration) ceremony of the Shri Ram Mandir, Ayodhya, which took place on January 22, 2024, one of the most significant and widely anticipated religious events in contemporary Indian history,” the CCPA said. It alleged that the products under scrutiny were being marketed as exclusive offerings from the temple. The misleading products included Raghupati Ghee Ladoo, Khoya Khobi Ladoo, Ghee Bundi Ladoo and Desi Cow Milk Peda. It was also

highlighted that the products used religious imagery and slogans referring to the deity. Even the ingredient column on all the products declared it as just “Ram Mandir Prasad.”

The CCPA’s order came in response to a complaint filed by the Confederation of All India Traders (CAIT) with the CCPA in January 2024. The complaint mentioned dishonest trade practices by listing commercially produced sweets on its website under the misleading label. The traders’ body claimed that customers were being exploited for monetary gain.

The authority said that Amazon, by hosting, displaying, and facilitating the sale of the impugned listings on its platform, was unquestionably a party to the publication of misleading advertisements within the meaning of Section 21(4) of the Consumer Protection Act, 2019. The CCPA further noted that the listings were available for nationwide delivery on one of India’s largest e-commerce platforms, accessible to hundreds of millions of consumers across the country.

Arrest warrant against Mohua Moitra

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

A Nadia district court issued an arrest warrant against Trinamool Congress MP Mohua Moitra for failing to appear before it in a hate speech-related case. The Court also directed submission of an action taken report on the execution of the warrant by 28 August. The erring MP, however, has time to correct her judicial procedure by appearing before the court.

The case relates to alleged hate speech. Third District and Sessions Court Judge Dibyendu Das, while passing the order, held that the MP had failed to respond to earlier pre-cognisance summons. ARP Shirshendu Das said that summons were issued to Moitra in a case filed for making some derogatory statements against the Indian Army and Home Minister Amit Shah. She also allegedly made some derogatory remarks against women, the lawyer said. “She would not appear three times despite summons being issued ... so this time the learned court has issued the warrant,” the advocate said. The Judge had earlier on



Tuesday asked Moitra to remain present personally. As she did not appear on Wednesday, the Court took cognizance of her “series of disobediences” and “lackadaisical approach” to comply with the court order. The Judge held, “the court is left with no other option but to issue an arrest warrant against her.” Moitra had earlier filed a petition before the Supreme Court seeking permission to appear before an investigating officer virtually, as she feared eggs could be thrown at her like in many previous cases where other TMC leaders were attacked with eggs. The Apex Court had, however, turned down the petition. Meanwhile, in a parallel development, former union minister and TMC MP from Dum Dum Saugato Roy has written to Lok

Sabha Speaker Om Birla alleging breach of privilege against two BJP MLAs from Dum Dum for provoking people to gherao and “attack” his car near Netaji Subhas International Airport, where he was going to attend a meeting in the capacity of Chairman, Kolkata Airport Advisory Authority. The incident took place on Tuesday afternoon. The protesters who surrounded his car and thumped on its bonnet and windows raised slogans like “thief go back,” Roy alleged, adding that the driver of his vehicle was also heckled. “It is an absolute breach of privilege, and two BJP MLAs are behind this ... I have written to the Speaker seeking action ... strict action should be taken,” Roy said.

The two MLAs are Arijit Bakshi and Sourav Sikdar, both from Dum Dum.

Sikdar subsequently denied his involvement in the incident, saying it could be a product of public discontent. “The way his (Roy) men have indulged in extortion and loot ... the locals who were victims of such torture showed their anger through a protest,” Sikdar said.

States Focus



JP NADDA DISCHARGED FROM AIIMS AFTER ANGIOPLASTY

Union health minister JP Nadda who underwent angioplasty at AIIMS, Delhi, was discharged on Wednesday, hospital authorities said. "Nadda was discharged today after undergoing angioplasty. He had a comfortable stay in hospital and thanked all doctors, nurses and staff for the care provided," the AIIMS statement said. He underwent angioplasty on August 17, following which he was under observation in the Department of Cardiology, an official statement said on Tuesday. The Union minister was admitted to the hospital on August 13 after experiencing uneasiness and had undergone tests including a coronary angiography on the same evening. (PTI)



KARNATAKA HOUSE DISRUPTED OVER MINISTER'S EXIT DEMAND

Karnataka Assembly proceedings witnessed disruptions for the third consecutive day on Wednesday, with the Opposition staging a protest in the House demanding the removal of minister B Nagendra, who faces charges in connection with the alleged embezzlement of crores of rupees in the State-run Karnataka Maharshi Valmiki ST Development Corporation. Soon after the obituary reference to senior BJP leader and former minister BC Nagesh, who died on Tuesday, the opposition BJP and JD(S) raised the issue and demanded that Nagendra be dropped from the Cabinet immediately. Nagendra was inducted into the DK Shivakumar-led Council of Ministers on August 3. (PTI)

Govt ruined youth's future: Kharge

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Wednesday accused the Modi Government of "destroying" the future of students and asserted that the time has come for the Congress to formulate a comprehensive 'Education-to-Employment Roadmap' for the youth.

In his opening remarks at the Congress Working Committee meeting at the Indira Bhawan, Kharge also questioned the "silence" of Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the alleged theft of Ram temple donations and demanded that the PM apologise for it and answer to the people.

"Over the last 12 years, the Modi Government has devastated the future of the youth. Instead of new schools opening, 94,000 schools have closed in recent years. Driven by the race for privatisation,



higher education is becoming increasingly expensive and out of reach for ordinary families," Kharge said.

He alleged that educational institutions are increasingly being taken over by RSS people.

"Even after completing their education, when young people set out in search of jobs, they are confronted with paper leaks, recruitment exam scams, and delays in appointments. Children from poor and mar-

ginalised backgrounds suffer the most in this situation," he said.

"The anger that has arisen among the youth across the country is not a sudden or one-day phenomenon. This Government has never had the time to listen to them; instead, it has consistently sought temporary measures to sidestep the issues. Consequently, they have been forced to take to the streets," Kharge said. He said the Congress has incorporated

the concerns of the youth into its agenda. Rahul Gandhi has brought their voices to the national stage through the "Chhatron ki Goonj" programme, Kharge said.

"In Parliament, too, we strove for a comprehensive deliberation on issues concerning education and examinations-seeking a discussion on the injustices faced by students and demanding accountability. However, (Prime Minister Narendra) Modi ji and (Home Minister) Amit Shah ji evaded questions throughout the Monsoon Session. Now that they have started speaking, they are prioritising non-issues over the questions raised by the youth," Kharge said.

"With the objective of preparing for the future, the time has come for the Congress to prepare a clear, comprehensive, and time-bound 'Education-to-Employment Roadmap' for the youth," Kharge said.

Rahul backs tribals protesting Ken-Betwa project

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Expressing support for the tribals staging a 'satyagraha' against the Ken-Betwa river-linking project, former Congress chief Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday said he stands with them in this struggle and will visit the site to exert pressure on the Government.

The Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha shared on X a video of his recent meeting with a group of tribals affected by the project.

"The problems, demands, struggles, and personal ordeals of the tribal brothers and sisters who are carrying out a satyagraha against the Ken-Betwa project — their own account. For years, these residents of Bundelkhand have been enduring injustice and



oppression solely for their rights; they deserve respect and support," Gandhi said in his post.

"In this fight of our tribal brothers and sisters, the Congress and I stand with them," Gandhi said.

According to the representative, around 11,500 acres of land belonging to approximately 7,000 families would be lost to the project. They urged Rahul Gandhi to raise the issue of alleged harassment by the administration in Parliament and to join the movement.

In the video, Gandhi assured them that he would visit the site and pressure the Government.

The ₹44,605-crore Ken-Betwa Link Project is the country's first river-linking project under the National Perspective Plan. It aims to irrigate 1.062 million hectares of land, provide drinking water to about 6.2 million people and generate hydropower in the drought-prone Bundelkhand region spanning Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh.

Farmers suspend protest on Haryana-Punjab border



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Khanauri

Farmer outfits protesting on the Haryana-Punjab border announced the suspension of their agitation on Wednesday after Haryana officials offered them a meeting with Union Minister Manohar Lal on September 4 to discuss their demands.

The development came after a meeting between representatives of Samyukta Kisan Morcha (Non-Political), which is leading the protest, and Haryana Government officials.

The protesters have been sitting at the Khanauri-Data Singh Wala border point after Haryana Police prevented a group of 51 farmers from proceeding to Delhi as part of their 228-km "Kisan Bachao Padyatra" on August 16 against the proposed India-US trade deal and to press for a legal guarantee for procuring crops at the minimum support price (MSP).

During the meeting on Wednesday, the officials proposed a meeting between a delegation of farmers and Union Power Minister and former Haryana chief minister Manohar Lal in Delhi.

Speaking to reporters later, SKM (Non-Political) leader Abhimanyu Kohar said Union Minister Manohar Lal will meet the delegation of farmers and discuss their

issues on September 4. He also said that efforts were also on to fix a meeting of farmers with Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan.

Following the assurance, farmer leader Jagjit Singh Dallewal announced the suspension of the protest.

The Haryana police also began removing the multi-layer barricading it had put up to stop protesters from Punjab.

The SKM (Non-Political) had given a call for the "Kisan Bachao Padyatra" from Data Singh Wala village on the Haryana-Punjab border to Jantar Mantar in Delhi, culminating in a farmers' panchayat in the national Capital on August 29.

A total of 51 farmers from various parts of the country were to participate in the march and some SKM (Non-Political) volunteers and supporters would have accompanied them.

Earlier on Sunday, three rounds of talks between the two sides remained inconclusive.

Dallewal on Sunday rejected the Haryana officials' offer of a meeting with Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini and insisted on arranging an appointment with the Union agriculture minister to discuss their main issue — the proposed India-US trade deal.

NCERT reconstitutes textbook development team for class 11, 12 political science; 4 members have RSS links

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The NCERT has reconstituted the Textbook Development Team for class 11 and 12 political science with a mandate to integrate cultural rootedness, Indian knowledge systems and inclusion, with at least four of the members having direct or indirect links with the RSS.

The team has been asked to develop the class 11 textbook by November and the class 12 book by July next year.

The textbook team will be led by academic and political analyst Sandeep Shastri, vice president of Karnataka-based deemed university Nitte.

Among the members of the textbook development team are at least four academics and educationists with direct or indirect documented backgrounds in the RSS-affiliated Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) and the BJP.



Yadunath Deshpande, now a senior consultant with the Ministry of Education, has a longstanding organisational background in the ABVP. The organisation's own records identify him as its joint state organising secretary for Maharashtra in the past. He subsequently served as an organising secretary in the ABVP's Mumbai-Konkan structure. His LinkedIn profile also describes him as a political consultant for BJP.

Prashant Divekar has a longstanding association with Pune-based Jnana Prabodhini, an RSS-affiliated institution. It was founded in 1962 by Vinayak Vishwanath, an RSS member and pracharak. In his profile on the National Council for Teacher Education's National Mission for Mentoring portal, Divekar describes his approach as being "rooted in Bhartiya educational philosophy" and says he has con-

tributed to the National Curriculum Framework."

Vandana Mishra, professor at JNU's Centre for Political Studies, is a former national secretary of the ABVP.

Ravi Rameshchandra Shukla, Associate Professor at JNU's Centre for Comparative Politics and Political Theory, has been a member of the editorial board of the Indian Journal of Democratic Governance, published by the Indian Institute of Democratic Leadership-Rambhau Mhalgi Prabodhini, which is an RSS affiliate.

In 2021, Devendra Fadnis became its president. Shukla has also undertaken research centred on cultural and spiritual nationalism. He is the principal investigator of an ICSSR-funded JNU project titled "The Role of Fests in Shaping of Spiritual and Cultural Nationalism of Bharat: A Study of Kumbha and Magh Mela".

Education minister reviews implementation of PM Modi's free online coaching initiative

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Education Minister Pralhad Joshi on Wednesday held a meeting with senior officials to review implementation of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's initiative to provide free online coaching to youth preparing for competitive examinations. Modi had made the announcement during his Independence Day speech last Saturday.

Joshi said on X that the meeting with the officials of the Department of Higher Education focused on "building a robust national platform that makes high-quality learning content, expert guidance and structured preparation accessible to students across the country".

The prime minister had announced free online coaching for aspirants



Union Education Minister Pralhad Joshi holds a review meeting with senior officials on the implementation of the free online coaching initiative for competitive exams in New Delhi (PTI)

preparing for competitive exams to ease the financial burden on their families.

"Coaching classes burden the poor and the middle class. We will provide free online coaching for various exams," Modi said in his address to the nation on India's 80th Independence Day.

"Every parent feels that if they do not send their child

to a coaching class, they are not a prestigious family," he said.

The prime minister said he assures these families that they can save "thousands of crores of rupees" spent on coaching, be close to their children, and care for them.

"And therefore, we have decided to provide free online coaching for various examinations for the youth.

We have digital public infrastructure; we have excellent talent and teachers. By bringing these resources together, we are going to build a complete network to provide free coaching to the youth of the country," Modi said.

The country last month witnessed a strong mobilisation of youth over the NEET-UG paper leak and other education reforms, including ways to tackle the coaching menace.

The "Sanskad Chalo" (March to Parliament) campaign, led by BJP, on July 20 saw widespread protests, bringing the concerns of youth into sharper focus.

By the end of the days-long agitation, the Government was forced to concede the protesters' key demand, the resignation of then education minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

Railways, Assam forest department join hands to protect elephants

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

In a major bid to prevent wildlife casualties along railway tracks, the Northeast Frontier Railway (NFR), in close coordination with the Forest Department of Assam, has intensified proactive measures to ensure the safe passage of elephants crossing tracks across the State.

The effectiveness of these joint initiatives was demonstrated on Wednesday early morning when officials of the Assam Forest Department coordinated with railway authorities to facilitate the timely stoppage of Train No. 20503 (Dibrugarh-New Delhi) Rajdhani Express in the Lumding-Habaiapur section. The prompt action allowed a herd of wild elephants to cross the tracks without hindrance.

Similar instances of vigilance by frontline railway staff have been recorded over the past few days. On August



15, the alertness of a loco pilot driving Train No. 15665 (Guwahati-Mariani) Express averted a potential hazard, enabling a herd to safely traverse the tracks in the Lamsakhang-Patharkhola section. The following day, August 16, another loco pilot operating Train No. 15650 (Narangi-Agartala) Express took timely preventive action to ensure safe passage for elephants in the Habaiapur-Lamsakhang section.

According to NFR officials, a range of technology-driven and operational measures are being deployed in vulnerable corridors. Key among

these is the Artificial Intelligence-based Intrusion Detection System (IDS), utilising Distributed Acoustic System (DAS) technology, which provides real-time alerts on elephant movement near the railway tracks.

Additionally, the railway administration has implemented temporary nighttime speed restrictions based on elephant sightings, enhanced track patrolling, and regular clearing of roadside vegetation to improve visibility. Train crews are being routinely sensitised, and cautionary signage has been installed across identified corridors.

Disability rights groups flag gaps in Census 2027 enumeration

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A coalition of disability rights organisations and activists have raised concern over the manner of proposed enumeration of persons with disabilities in Census 2027, saying the nine categories in the form do not cover all 21 disabilities recognised under the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (RPwD) Act, 2016.

A statement, issued by the National Platform for the Rights of the Disabled (NPRD) and endorsed by 405 signatories, said the proposed classification could result in several groups being left out of official disability statistics.

According to the statement, the proposed Census framework has nine categories — seeing, hearing, speech, mobility, intellectual disability, mental illness, acid attack, chronic neurological disease and blood disorder.

The groups said the first six categories, barring the change in terminology from "Mental Retardation" to "Intellectual Disability", were



also part of the 2011 enumeration. Acid attack, chronic neurological diseases and blood disorders are proposed as additional categories, they said.

The RPwD Act, however, recognises 21 specified disabilities, including autism spectrum disorder, specific learning disabilities, cerebral palsy, muscular dystrophy, multiple sclerosis, Parkinson's disease, haemophilia, thalassemia, sickle-cell disease and multiple disabilities including deaf-

blindness.

The organisations said disabilities such as autism spectrum disorder, specific learning disabilities, dwarfism, leprosy-cured persons and multiple disabilities, including deafblindness, have not been distinctly provided for in the proposed categories.

They also questioned the grouping of cerebral palsy, muscular dystrophy, multiple sclerosis and Parkinson's disease under broader categories.

Thalassemia, haemophilia

and sickle-cell disease have been brought under the single category of "blood disorder", they said.

The groups warned that such a classification could affect not only the accuracy of the Census but also subsequent Government planning.

"Apart from leaving enumerators clueless, this exercise will produce inaccurate data and render entire groups of persons with disabilities invisible in official statistics," the statement said.

It said the impact would



extend to policy-making, programme design, budgetary allocations and accountability.

The groups also referred to an assurance given by Union Minister Ramdas Athawale that data on all 21 disabilities would be captured, saying the reported nine-category framework was contrary to that assurance.

The organisations have demanded that the Census 2027 disability questionnaire individually capture all 21 disabilities recognised under the RPwD Act.

"Census must reflect the progress made in disability rights law, not perpetuate outdated and inadequate classifications," the statement said.

The signatories include disability rights advocates, researchers and representatives of organisations such as Disability Rights Alliance, Sense International India, Action For Autism, Sruti Disability Rights Centre, Disability Rights Association of Goa and the National Association for the Blind.

TN CM gives cars, ₹1 lakh allowance to MLAs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Wednesday announced that MLAs in the State will get a Government vehicle and a monthly allowance of ₹1 lakh — all for transparent, good governance.

Among a series of announcements made on the floor of the Assembly, Vijay also increased the medical insurance cover to ₹25 lakh per annum from the current ₹5 lakh under the Chief Minister's Comprehensive Health Insurance Scheme. Medical and surgical treatment services for transgender individuals will be additionally provided at seven Government medical college hospitals, he said.

He also announced a hike in the procurement price of state-run 'Aavin' milk from ₹38 to ₹41 per litre, entailing an additional expenditure of ₹360 crore per annum



Tamil Nadu Assembly Speaker JCD Prabhakar looks on as Chief Minister Joseph Vijay speaks during the State Assembly session in Chennai

benefitting 3.16 lakh milk producers. On the announcement pertaining to MLAs, Vijay said that the string of perks would help the legislators to be not dependent on others for their official requirements and enable them to work —without making any compromises — in an independent and honest manner.

"I am happy to announce that the Government will provide vehicles to all MLAs,"

he said, adding it would assist newly elected legislators, as well as those serving without financial means, in addressing public grievances.

The CM announced ₹75,000 allowance per month for vehicle maintenance, fuel expenses and as expenditure on hiring a driver. Also, ₹25,000 will be provided to recruit an assistant.

He underscored that the announcement on perks for

MLAs is in alignment with the TVK regime's goal of corruption-free, transparent, good governance. Necessary amendments will be made to relevant laws to give effect to the perks, he said.

Vijay also underlined that the Government had received representations in this regard and Kattumannarkoil legislator LE Jothimani (VCK) also had made a request, and that she had pointed out about difficulties faced by legislators without "economic strength."

Even before winning polls, his party MLA-candidates had taken a pledge to be honest and they are functioning in accordance with that goal, he said.

Notably, the TVK Government, on the basis of the principle of governance for the people following the path of honesty, is functioning with the objective of delivering graft-free, honest, and transparent administration down to the grassroots level, the CM said.

Vijay's announcement on vehicle and allowances made the ruling TVK legislator K Sindhu break into a rapturous glee, singing a song in praise of the actor-turned-politician and thanking him for the gesture.

The CM turned to look at the "singer-legislator" and could not restrain himself from smiling at the musical expression when she sang a few lines of the song "Koduthathellam Koduthaan," from the 1964 movie "Padagotti," starring yesteryear icon and late CM MG Ramachandran (MGR).

The philosophical song on divine equality was sung by TM Soundararajan and penned by lyricist Vaali.

Further, the seven state-run facilities where the services for transpersons will be provided are Chennai Stanley, Tirunelveli, Thoothukudi, Chengalpattu, Thiruvapur, Dharmapuri, and Kanyakumari under the Chief Minister's Comprehensive Health Insurance Scheme.

Deliberate misinformation on Visakhapatnam data centres' water requirements: Lokesh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh IT Minister Nara Lokesh on Wednesday defended the state Government's decision to establish data centres in Visakhapatnam, and said deliberate misinformation was being spread over their environmental and water requirements.

Addressing the Assembly, the IT Minister said Google's decision to invest in Visakhapatnam had triggered wider interest from other IT companies in the city.

"Deliberate misinformation was being spread over their (data centres) environmental and water requirements," said Lokesh, replying to a question.

Lokesh said data centres are critical to the AI-driven digital economy and India's data sovereignty, particularly amid emerging geo-



Andhra Pradesh IT Minister Nara Lokesh

political challenges. He explained that once the proposed data-centre ecosystem reaches the targeted 6.5 GW capacity, it is estimated to require around 3 TMC (thousand million cubic ft) of water annually based on current technology.

However, he stressed that newer cooling technologies are expected to reduce water consumption further.

Lokesh said water for data

centres would come from the industrial allocation of Polavaram Project water, without diverting water meant for the port city's residents.

He noted that the Government is committed to supplying Visakhapatnam's urban water requirements through Polavaram Project with gravity-based supply expected within 18 months.

ECI revises Maharashtra SIR schedule

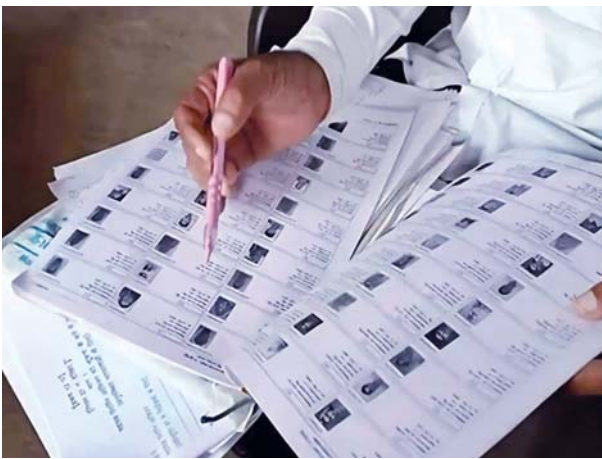
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Election Commission has revised the schedule for the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls in Maharashtra, including the extension of the deadline for filing claims and objections, pushing the publication of the final electoral roll by nearly a month to November 4.

The poll panel, in an order dated August 19, said the revised schedule was issued after considering a request from the Maharashtra Chief Electoral Officer.

Under the new schedule, rationalisation and rearrangement of polling stations will be completed by August 24, while the draft electoral roll will be published on August 31.

The document collection process in Maharashtra ended on August 17. The exercise involved house-to-house visits by Booth Level Officers (BLOs) and collection of enumeration forms from electors. The process had earlier been extended, with the Election Commission allow-



ing additional time to complete the exercise.

The revised schedule now provides voters with a period from August 31 to September 30 to file claims and objections against the draft electoral roll. This is 26 days later than the earlier schedule, under which the draft was to be published on August 5, and claims and objections could be filed until September 4.

The notice phase and disposal of claims and objections will also run from

August 31 to October 29. Under the original schedule, this process was to be carried out from August 5 to October 3.

The final electoral roll will be published on November 4, according to the revised schedule. The earlier deadline was October 7.

The revised dates also defer the rationalisation of polling stations. It was originally scheduled to be completed by July 29 but will now be completed by August 24.

Shah to chair meeting of southern CMs in TN

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Union Home Minister Amit Shah will chair the 31st meeting of the Southern Zonal Council on August 20 at Mamallapuram near here, and the chief ministers of southern States and UTs will take part, the Government said on Wednesday.

The Southern Zonal Council comprises the states of Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Telangana, and the Union Territories of Puducherry, Andaman and Nicobar Islands and Lakshadweep.

The council serves as an excellent forum for resolving issues and disputes between the Centre and the member States/Union Territories, the union Government said.

River water sharing disputes between Karnataka and Tamil Nadu, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu and Kerala are among the ongoing disputes. In an official release,



the Centre said that the council meetings also discuss broad issues of national importance.

Amit Shah is expected to arrive here by 7.45 pm on Wednesday and proceed to Kovalam near Mamallapuram on the city's outskirts where the meeting is scheduled to take place.

Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar has said he will be visiting Tamil Nadu on Thursday to attend the Southern Zonal Council meeting.

The national issues include Fast Track Special Courts for speedy investigation and

past few years, these Councils have proved to be an important factor in fostering healthy bond of mutual understanding and cooperation across various regions."

With the cooperation of all state Governments, Central ministries and departments, a total of 69 meetings of the various Zonal Councils and their Standing Committees have been held in the last approximately 12 years — since June 2014 till now.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi envisioned "Team Bharat," for the nation on the basis of cooperative federalism, and the Zonal Councils are making significant contributions in this direction.

These councils function on the conviction that strong states build a strong nation. They provide a structured mechanism for dialogue and discussion on issues affecting two or more states-or the Centre and the states-thereby serving as a platform to foster mutual cooperation.

Bhagwat opens three-day RSS coordination meeting in Visakhapatnam



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Visakhapatnam

RSS Sarsanghchalak Mohan Bhagwat on Wednesday inaugurated the three-day 'Akhil Bharatiya Samanvay Baithak' — All India Coordination Meeting — here in Andhra Pradesh.

The meeting commenced in the 'Vigyan Vihar' school in Gurulova, near Visakhapatnam, where Bhagwat paid floral tributes to the portrait of Bharat Mata.

"The All India Coordination Meeting of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh commenced at the 'Vigyan Vihar' school in Gurulova, near Visakhapatnam.

The meeting was inaugurated by respected Sarsanghchalak Mohan Bhagwat," RSS said in a post on X. Scheduled from August 19 to 21, the meeting will brainstorm on issues such as demographic imbalance, drug abuse affecting youth and several others.

Key functionaries from 32 Sangh (RSS)-inspired-organisations will take part in the event, including Bhagwat, Sarkaryavah Dattatreya Hosabale, Sah-Sarkaryavahs, and other central office-bearers.

Teaching job aspirants continue protests even after issuance of exam notification in Bihar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

The issuance of a notification for the fourth phase of the Teacher Recruitment Exam failed to quell teaching job aspirants' protest here, who say their demand for a single-tier test and action against those who got jobs through corrupt means remain unaddressed.

The Bihar Public Service Commission announced the schedule for Teachers' Recruitment Exams (TRE-4) on Tuesday, hours after students, holding a demonstration at Gardani Bagh, threatened to gherao the education minister if the exam schedule was not announced within 24 hours.



The notification has been issued for filling more than 32,000 posts.

However, student leader Dileep Kumar said, "Our demands for a single-tier examination in BPSC-TRE 4, librarian and sub-inspector recruitment exams, strict action against those who

got jobs through corrupt means, and ensuring transparency in BSSC recruitments remain unaddressed."

"We will continue with our protest," Kumar said, adding that he would talk with other protesters on Thursday and decide on starting an indefinite hunger strike.

Adjacent to the TRE-4 protestors' camp, guest faculty of various universities in Bihar and PhD-holders have been protesting for over a fortnight, with one, Kumud Patel, on an indefinite hunger strike for 16 days now.

Vibha Rani, a guest faculty at Babasaheb Bhimrao Ambedkar Bihar University of Muzaffarpur, said they would "not budge from the protest site unless all their demands were met."

BJD chief Patnaik appeals to people of Odisha to oppose new mining law

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

BJD president Naveen Patnaik on Wednesday said Odisha's economy was "in danger" and called upon people to come together to oppose the new mining legislation, which he alleged was aimed at harming the State.

In a lengthy video message addressed to the people, the Leader of Opposition in the state Assembly alleged that a "dangerous conspiracy" had been hatched against Odisha to weaken its economy and its people.



BJD president Naveen Patnaik

Patnaik was referring to the recently passed Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, in Parliament.

"This (new mining law) is going to harm the state and its people. But the central Government passed such an

important amendment bill without any discussion. Only the BJD MPs opposed it in the Rajya Sabha," Patnaik said.

He said he had written to Chief Minister Mohan Charan Mahi opposing the legislation and requested him to convene an all-party meeting and a special session of the Assembly to deliberate on the new mining law.

The ruling BJP, however, claimed that Odisha would not lose any revenue from the recently passed MMDR Amendment Bill, 2026, and would instead benefit from a more competitive mining market.

Flood situation grim in 6 districts in Odisha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

The flood situation in six Odisha districts remained grim on Wednesday, as water levels of most rivers were on the rising trend despite no heavy rainfall in the region in the past 24 hours, officials said.

Heavy rain in the upper catchment areas of the Subarnarekha in neighbouring Jharkhand have pushed up the river's water level, which crossed the danger mark of 10.36 metres at Rajghat in Odisha's Jaleswar, they said.

The water level was recorded at 10.40 metres at 9 am, leading to floodwaters entering three blocks — Jaleswar, Basta and Baliapal — in Balasore district, the officials said.

Similarly, the water level of the Jalaka river crossed the danger mark of 6.5 metres at Mathani in Basta. The reading



stood at 6.60 metres at 6 am.

The Budhabalanga river was flowing at 7.26 metres in Govindpur, just above its warning level, the officials said, adding that the entire Balasore district was reeling under the deluge, prompting the administration to expedite relief and rescue operations.

The situation in neighbouring Bhadrak and Jajpur districts was no different, with the Salandi river flowing at 17.10 metres against the danger mark of 17 metres at Rajghat.

Pakistani cleric claims Hafiz Saeed sent 10,000 terrorists to Kashmir

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Pakistani cleric Allama Naseer Madni sparked controversy on August 14 by claiming that Hafiz Saeed, founder of Lashkar-e-Tayyiba (LeT), sent 10,000 trained cadres to Kashmir. When speaking at an event associated with the banned group in Bahawalnagar, he described this action as an act of national sacrifice. He raised the question of why Saeed is in jail.

Earlier this summer, Madni was hospitalised after a serious heart problem during a Friday sermon, but he returned to speak on Pakistan's Independence Day. Addressing children and members of the Pakistan Markazi Muslim League, which is linked to LeT, he said Saeed remains in jail even though, according to him, there are no witnesses. "He is in jail today," Madni said, "but he should be the first prisoner in Pakistan," explaining that this was

because "he had offered 10,000 children for Kashmir, as a sacrifice of the motherland." Madni called these men "commandos" and compared their actions to ordinary crimes, saying Saeed had not damaged shops or cut trees, yet he was still jailed and remained silent.

The recording of Madni's claim quickly spread online, drawing attention for its scale and how it was shared. Lashkar-e-Tayyiba, founded by Saeed in the late 1980s, has long been accused by India and Western governments of organising cross-border terrorism in Jammu and Kashmir. The group was added to the United Nations sanctions list in 2005 for its ties to Al-Qaeda and the Taliban. In 2008, the United States named Saeed a global terrorist and offered a multi-million-dollar reward for him.

LeT has been linked to deadly attacks in India, especially the 2008 Mumbai attacks that killed 166



Pakistani cleric Allama Naseer Madni

people. Saeed is currently in prison in Pakistan, but this has raised international doubts because his imprisonment has sometimes been temporary. Indian investigators have repeatedly named him in major cases.

In July 2026, the National Investigation Agency (NIA) submitted a supplementary chargesheet in which it accused him in relation to the terror attack in Pahalgam



in April 2025. A Jammu court has issued a non-bailable warrant for him. Mumbai Police are also holding in absentia trials for Pakistani fugitives linked to the 26/11 attacks. Madni's public defence of Saeed as a man of sacrifice, not a terror mastermind, shows the ongoing gap between Pakistan's official position and the rhetoric still heard in the country.

Having connections with

banned networks should be stated so openly on a national holiday; it does raise wider questions about the environment that continues to support such narratives. For many decades, Indian security forces have had to deal with infiltration and violence in Jammu and Kashmir, which are attributable to groups based in Pakistan.

LeT and its associated groups have played a central role in that effort. By giving his speech, Madni successfully presented the case that LeT and related groups have played a major role in this ongoing conflict. In his speech, Madni framed the sending of thousands of fighters as a patriotic act, even though Pakistan faces pressure from the Financial Action Task Force and other international bodies to take real steps against terror financing and infrastructure.

His serious health scare shows that the organisations supporting him remain. Moreover, his com-

ments come at a time when India is making legal efforts to make Saeed accountable for the attacks which have cost hundreds of lives among civilians and members of the security forces. By treating imprisonment as an injustice rather than as a consequence, the cleric is reinforcing a narrative which is well known to those who have studied Pakistan's dual policy. The official denial of state sponsorship is coupled with the open glorification of those accused of directing violence across the border.

Madni's comments do not reveal any new operational information, but they do give a rare look at the ideology still present in some radical groups in Pakistan. The fact that someone can openly praise sending 10,000 operatives as a sacrifice for the "motherland" without facing criticism helps explain why India and much of the world remain sceptical of Pakistan's counter-terror promises.



Editor's

TAKE

BJP’s generational reset without changing the core

The BJP's new national team under president Nitin Nabin signals change, but not a departure from the party's established organisational architecture

The BJP's new national team is less a rupture than a carefully calibrated reset. Of the 65 office-bearers announced under party president Nitin Nabin, 51 are new faces. The list includes 13 vice-presidents, eight general secretaries, 16 secretaries and a reworked media and social-media apparatus. Yet the retention of BL Santhosh as general secretary (organisation) – one of the party's most powerful posts–makes clear that continuity remains as important as change.

With crucial Assembly contests approaching and the 2029 Lok Sabha election already shaping organisational calculations, the BJP needs a team capable of managing states, social coalitions and campaign narratives simultaneously. Uttar Pradesh receives particular attention, while experienced leaders such as Vasundhara Raje Scindia, Piyush Goyal and Ram Madhav provide political weight. Smriti Irani's return as a general secretary adds a forceful communicator with a strong public profile.

But the most important backdrop is not merely electoral. It is the widespread youth anger expressed through recent protests over examination irregularities, paper leaks, unemployment and institutional accountability. The protests demonstrated that the new generation is not politically aligned with the BJP by default. Online reach, nationalism and welfare delivery may mobilise support, but they cannot substitute for credibility on jobs, education and opportunity.

The change in the social-media leadership – Deepak Mhaskey replacing Amit Malviya, who had occupied the post since 2015–is therefore significant. The BJP appears to recognise that its digital strategy cannot remain focused only on message amplification and partisan combat. The creation of additional social-media positions suggests an effort to make the party's digital communication more distributed and responsive.

The message to the new generation is unmistakable: the BJP wants to look younger, more diverse and more technologically alert. The new team includes six members below 40 and 15 between 40 and 49, along with a notable presence of women and minority-community leaders. These numbers are intended to convey mobility within the organisation and to reassure younger voters that the party is not closed to generational change. The BJP has changed its personnel, its communication structure and, to some extent, its social signalling. What has not changed is the centralised decision-making model, the continuing influence of the RSS network and the reliance on a familiar ideological vocabulary. Santhosh's retention confirms that the organisational core remains intact.

The new team, then, is an attempt to refresh the vehicle without changing its engine. Whether it succeeds will depend not on how many new names appear on the list, but on whether the party can convert generational anxiety into genuine political dialogue. The protests have shown that India's youth are not merely an audience to be addressed. They are a constituency demanding to be heard. And the political party seeking their support must listen to them.

Gelephu: Bhutan's bet, India's gain

Bhutan's ambitious Gelephu Mindfulness City is emerging as a strategic bridge between the Himalayan kingdom, India and the wider Asian economy. For New Delhi, the 2,600-sq-km project offers an opportunity to deepen connectivity, trade and energy ties with Bhutan while countering China's growing footprint along the Himalayan frontier



PARUL CHANDRA

Announced in December 2023 by King Jigme Khesar Namgyel Wangchuck, the mega Gelephu Mindfulness City (GMC) project is aimed at creating a transformative economic hub in southern Bhutan. For India, GMC is far more than a neighbouring infrastructure project. Situated close to the border with Assam, the initiative directly intersects with India's regional integration goals, security calculations, and economic ties in the Eastern Himalayas.

This project, under which an autonomous special administrative region (SAR) has been created, is spread over a vast area of 2,600 square km. Its primary objective is to develop the region as an economic hub and forge strong linkages with the global economy while taking care to preserve Bhutan's environment and cultural ethos. India strongly supports the initiative, recognising substantial strategic gains while countering growing Chinese influence in the region. Earlier this month, when the Bhutanese king went for a visit to Gelephu along with Prime Minister Tshering Tobgay and Royal Bhutan Army's chief operations officer, Lieutenant General Batoo Tshering, to review the ongoing work, Indian ambassador Sandeep Arya accompanied the delegation.

Key representatives from Indian agencies assisting Bhutan were also present, including the IMTRAT (Indian Military Training Team) commandant and the chief engineer of Dantak – the overseas arm of India's Border Roads Organisation, which is executing crucial infrastructure projects in Bhutan. For India, the GMC project will enhance physical connectivity with its close neighbour, deepen economic linkages, and boost energy security through hydropower projects expected to come up there. Crucially, it also signals to the world, especially China, how deeply intertwined India and Bhutan's strategic and economic interests remain.

This comes as China continues to press Bhutan, with whom it shares a 477-km-long border, to develop bilateral ties. While Bhutan does not have formal diplomatic relations with China, it frequently faces Beijing's strong-arm tactics on boundary issues, including attempts to grab territory. While Bhutan and China have been holding negotiations since 1984 to settle their boundary dispute, there has been no resolution yet. The Bhutan-China boundary dispute obviously has strategic and security implications for India. China, for instance, lays claim to Bhutan's Doklam plateau, which overlooks India's vulnerable Siliguri corridor connecting its northeast to the



THE GMC PROJECT REPRESENTS A TRANSFORMATIVE CONVERGENCE OF BHUTAN'S SOCIO-ECONOMIC ASPIRATIONS AND INDIA'S CORE STRATEGIC IMPERATIVES. FOR BHUTAN, IT OFFERS A VITAL PATH TO STEM YOUTH MIGRATION, MODERNISE ITS ECONOMY, AND INTEGRATE INTO GLOBAL SUPPLY CHAINS WITHOUT COMPROMISING ITS DISTINCT CULTURAL IDENTITY

The writer is a policy analyst and writes on national and international issues

mainland. The 73-day military standoff at Doklam in 2017 occurred when Indian troops stepped in to block the People's Liberation Army from extending a motorable track towards the strategic Jampheeri Ridge there.

With Bhutan remaining mindful of India's strategic interests, deep cooperation on the Gelephu project is a vital element of its outreach to Thimphu. The initiative will also help further consolidate India's linkages with the Himalayan kingdom that's been gradually working to shed its isolationist past. While India remains its closest partner, Thimphu has been engaging with many more countries in an attempt to broad-base its foreign relations.

Bhutan's past isolation stemmed not just from its rugged, landlocked mountainous terrain but also from a deliberate desire to preserve its culture, environment and sovereignty. However, modern economic realities in a globalised world and the aspirations of its people, especially the youth, are driving deeper engagement with the outside world. Bhutan now has diplomatic relations with approximately 60 countries, though it remains wary of establishing formal diplomatic ties with the P5 countries. This shift marks a major evolution for a nation that transitioned from an absolute monarchy to a democratic constitutional monarchy only in 2008. While there is an elected government in Bhutan now, the Druk Gyalpo (Dragon King) commands immense respect and authority, making his personal backing of the GMC project pivotal.

Bhutan also hopes that the economic growth which will come with the project will create job opportunities for its educated youth, who have been exposed to the outside world via social media, and arrest their migration to other countries. Educated Bhutanese youth and skilled professionals have been migrating abroad in huge numbers, with Australia being a favoured destination. Many have also moved to the

Middle East. For a country with a small population, this large-scale migration threatens long-term demographic stability.

For Bhutan, the project is a huge gamble. If it takes off, the project can be a catalyst for its economic growth, trade and physical connectivity not just with India but even beyond to the Southeast Asian region. It needs India and other countries to help develop it and invest in it. To encourage private businesses to be part of the project, Bhutan has chosen to use Singapore's laws for corporate and commercial matters and Abu Dhabi Global Market regulations for financial services in GMC. Reflecting this broader economic opening, Bhutan also resumed negotiations in July this year to join the World Trade Organisation (WTO) after an 18-year hiatus.

With connectivity being important, an international airport is also on the anvil in Gelephu, which will be Bhutan's second such airport after the one in Paro. Simultaneously, India has also already promised assistance to Bhutan for two vital rail links. One will be the 69-km rail link from Gelephu to Kokrajhar in Assam. This is expected to help Bhutan access Indian ports. Signalling its strong backing for the Gelephu project, India has declared this link a special railway project. The other 17-km rail link will be between Samtse in Bhutan, which is being developed as an industrial hub, and Banarhat in West Bengal.

Ultimately, the GMC project represents a transformative convergence of Bhutan's socio-economic aspirations and India's core strategic imperatives. For Bhutan, it offers a vital path to stem youth migration, modernise its economy, and integrate into global supply chains without compromising its distinct cultural identity. For India, it secures a crucial buffer against growing Chinese influence along the Himalayan frontier while cementing a high-stakes geopolitical alliance rooted in shared growth and regional stability.

PIC TALK



A flock of Baya Weaver birds feeds on grains, in Nadia district, West Bengal, PHOTO: PTI



AJIT KUMAR BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

I habitually look out of my window to soak in the surrounding greenery. Recently, I noticed a gate of the house opposite mine being painted. To my surprise, this exercise took more than a week. I wondered what was going on in the mind of the owner all this time, with television, newspapers, the internet, etc. spewing negative news on a continuous basis. Yes, all kinds of dirt are finding a place in our mind all the time. Why is it so harmful will become clear as you read this article.

We, souls, have material bodies. Additionally, we also have a subtle body, comprising three faculties, which are mind, intelligence and 'ahankar' (ego). The faculty of mind has three functions, which are thinking, feeling and willing. The feeling part is very crucial. Whatever



emotion we have at any particular time is felt through the mind only. For example, if something nice happens, we will feel happy, unless the mind is already disturbed due to a serious problem. What does this tell us? That the mind must always be peaceful to have a normal reaction/life.

It may sound startling, but the mind is the real home of a soul; I am referring to us. A brick-and-mortar home is for our material body. Don't we remain in this real home wherever we go? For example, one is sitting in a beautiful park but is lost in thoughts. Does he enjoy the beauty of the park? Similarly, all the comforts and facilities of a house mean nothing if the mind is

obsessed with some problem. It gets worse in old age when one has fewer physical engagements. The enforced loneliness hurts more if the mind is allowed to harbour harmful emotions like greed, anger, lust and hate. Peace is lost, and depression, fears, worries and anxieties dominate the mind. A lovely, well-painted house does not help in getting sound sleep.

All is not lost, though. God can help, and only God can help. This is another reality. The mind is very powerful, as pointed out by Arjuna in verse 6.34 of the Bhagavad-Gita, and confirmed by Lord Krishna in the next verse. Being self-sufficient has limits; this excellent quality does not extend to the control of the mind. It has been tried unsuccessfully over the ages.

Therefore, let us drop our ahankara and take shelter of God and remain there. This means that we must find some ways to connect with God. What better way is there than chanting God's names? Aren't we already used to chanting, yes, our own name by 'mein, mein, mein' (I, I, I)? We just have to switch to the name of God like Krishna, Rama and Shiva. The cleansing of the mind will begin. Gradually, the mind will become peaceful. Surely, one would thank God and be very grateful from the heart for this great mercy of granting the rare peace. Our real home will become very beautiful, better than a well-painted gate.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a columnist

HUMANITARIANISM NEEDS PROTECTION, FUNDING AND GRASSROOTS ACTION

The editorial, 'The Courage That Refuses to Look Away' (19 Aug), rightly reminds us that humanitarian workers need not only protection but also predictable funding rather than ceremonial applause.

Whether a catastrophe is man-made, such as war, or caused by nature, suffering invariably extends beyond the capacity of the State. Governments can mobilise resources and institutions can coordinate relief, but ordinary citizens, voluntary organisations, local responders and philanthropists often reach suffering people with food, medicines, shelter and compassion.

In war zones, humanitarian workers must be protected under international law, and attacks on them must not be tolerated. We must build a genuine humanitarian movement sustained by empathy,

voluntary service and responsible giving. Indian scriptures have long emphasised the importance of service in our lives.

Such a movement can create trained community volunteers and local relief networks. Deprived sections also need support during peacetime. In India's colleges, NSS and NCC students should receive humanitarian training, supported through CSR funding, as government resources are limited. A culture of service can strengthen society's ability to respond to crises. Beyond emergency relief, it can foster compassion, responsibility and community participation. Humanitarianism should therefore become a shared social responsibility rather than remaining limited to moments of catastrophe.

BRIJ BHUSHAN GOYAL | LUDHIANA

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

India’s election system inspires

Apropos "Trump praises India's polls as Congress takes a swipe at CEC", the Election Commission of India (ECI) manages the world's largest elections. Conducting free and fair polls for such a vast population is a complex task that deserves international recognition.

This transformation gained momentum under former Chief Election Commissioner TN Seshan, who introduced strict reforms that made the electoral process cleaner, more transparent and organised.

Today, several nations have sought India's assistance and voting technology. Bhutan was among the first countries to use Indian Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs). Namibia procured Indian EVMs and later incorporated voter-verified paper audit trail (VVPAT) units. Nepal tested customised machines with ECI support, while countries such as Indonesia and the United States have shown interest in India's electoral system.

Political parties may raise concerns about EVMs and voter lists, but India's electoral system remains a remarkable achievement. Its use of technology and institutional reforms demonstrates how democracy can be strengthened while managing elections on an enormous scale.

N. SADHASIVA REDDY | BENGALURU

UPI fees could burden consumers

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Finance has recommended the gradual introduction of a Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on high-value merchant transactions, citing the rising cost of processing UPI payments.

Financial institutions reportedly incur around ₹20,700 crore in costs for processing UPI transactions, while the government has allocated only ₹2,000 crore to compensate for losses under the zero-MDR regime. If this gap continues, financial pressure on the UPI ecosystem could increase. While small shopkeepers and merchants may be exempted, larger merchants and high-value transactions could attract a fee. However, crucial questions remain: What should constitute a high-value transaction, and which categories of payments will be charged? More importantly, merchants may pass the additional cost to consumers, increasing their burden. UPI has become essential for everyday transactions because of its convenience and accessibility. If charges are introduced without adequate safeguards, consumers may reconsider digital payments and return to cash, bringing back concerns about carrying money and associated risks. Any policy change should therefore protect consumers while ensuring the financial sustainability of the UPI ecosystem.

DATTAPRASAD SHIRODKAR | MUMBAI

Protect captive elephants

AproposThe Supreme Court's recent directions for the welfare of captive elephants deserve serious attention and strict implementation. Mandating specialised elephant clinics, periodic health check-ups and individual medical records for every captive elephant is a significant step towards ensuring humane treatment.

These measures are particularly relevant to Kerala, where elephants are routinely used in temple festivals, religious processions and public functions. Prolonged captivity, arduous travel, excessive work, inadequate rest, poor nutrition and unsuitable living conditions can seriously affect their physical and psychological health. Regular medical examinations can help detect injuries, infections, malnutrition and stress-related ailments at an early stage.

Specialised clinics and detailed health records can ensure timely care and accountability. However, these directions will work only with strict enforcement, regular inspections and penalties for violations.

Traditional practices and public celebrations cannot come at the expense of animal welfare. Proper implementation of these directions can ensure that captive elephants receive the care, dignity and protection they deserve.

VINEETH KUMAR | KERALA

India’s widening strategic front

The emerging Saudi-Turkey-Pakistan defence alignment in West Asia and Bangladesh’s ongoing political transition present very different challenges, but both have implications for New Delhi’s security calculus. India will need to combine credible deterrence with diplomatic agility to meet the challenge



KRIPA NAUIYAL

India’s strategic calculus in August 2026 is being tested on two increasingly important fronts: a new defence architecture taking shape in West Asia and a rapidly evolving political and strategic environment in Bangladesh on its eastern flank. Neither development warrants alarmism. But together they point to a more fluid regional order in which India will need strategic patience, credible deterrence and sustained diplomatic engagement. The first question is whether the Mecca Pact is symbolism or substance. On August 7, Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Pakistan signed the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement, declaring that an armed attack on one signatory would be treated as an attack on all – language clearly reminiscent of NATO’s Article 5. The agreement builds on the Saudi-Pakistan Strategic Mutual Defence Agreement of September 2025, but its significance lies in bringing Turkey, with its substantial military and defence-industrial capabilities, into the arrangement. Initial assessments understandably differed. The agreement’s collective-defence clause does not publicly specify the circumstances or mechanisms through which members would be obliged to respond.

This has led some analysts to view it as more a political signal than a fully operational military alliance. Saudi officials have also resisted portraying it as a formal “military axis”. That assessment, however, needs updating. Turkey has now indicated that the three countries intend to establish high-level political and military coordination mechanisms, conduct joint exercises across land, sea, air and cyber domains, and cooperate in unmanned systems, electronic warfare and artificial intelligence. The agreement also envisages joint defence development, production and technology transfer.

These provisions give the pact a degree of institutional and technological substance beyond symbolism. Yet it would still be premature to call it a NATO equivalent. The three countries have different strategic priorities, military systems and threat perceptions. Saudi Arabia’s principal security concerns remain centred on the Gulf and Iran; Turkey has its own ambitions and obligations as a NATO member; and Pakistan’s strategic focus remains heavily influenced by India. The durability of the arrangement will therefore depend on whether the three can translate political convergence into sustained military interoperability. Lt Gen Syed Ata Hasnain has offered a useful caution against exaggerated threat perception.

The psychological boost to Pakistan is undoubtedly significant, but external strategic alignments are rarely permanent. The priorities of Riyadh, Ankara, Washington and Beijing can shift rapidly, while Pakistan’s own tendency towards strategic overreach has historically carried costs. There is nevertheless a genuine Indian concern. Pakistan now potentially combines its nuclear capability and military experience with Turkish defence technology and Saudi financial and strategic weight. Turkey’s expanding defence cooperation with Pakistan, particularly in drones and advanced military technologies, deserves close monitoring. The emerging arrangement could strengthen Pakistan’s military modernisation even if the collective-defence clause is never tested. The pact also has an economic dimension.

Turkey’s exclusion from the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC), combined with its interest in alternative connectivity routes, could complicate India’s ambitions for regional connectivity. India should therefore continue strengthening its relationships with Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Israel and Qatar while maintaining pragmatic engagement with Ankara. Shashi Tharoor, writing recently on the pact, has similarly argued for a response combining deterrence, innovation and deeper Gulf engagement rather than panic. That broad approach is sensible. But India’s strategic challenge extends beyond the Mecca Pact itself. It lies also to the east. The description of Bangladesh as “another Pakistan” was recently advanced by Sajeeb Wazed Joy, son of former Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina. Speaking from the United States to the Foreign Correspondents’ Club in New Delhi, Joy alleged that Pakistan’s ISI now has an “open hand” in Bangladesh, that convicted militants have been released and that banned Islamist groups such as Hizb ut-Tahrir are operating more openly. He warned that Bangladesh could become a source of future terrorist recruitment and described it as another Pakistan on India’s eastern frontier. These are serious allegations, but they need to be viewed in context. Joy is a deeply interested participant



TURKEY’S EXCLUSION FROM THE INDIA-MIDDLE EAST-EUROPE ECONOMIC CORRIDOR (IMEC), COMBINED WITH ITS INTEREST IN ALTERNATIVE CONNECTIVITY ROUTES, COULD COMPLICATE INDIA’S AMBITIONS FOR REGIONAL CONNECTIVITY. INDIA SHOULD THEREFORE CONTINUE STRENGTHENING ITS RELATIONSHIPS WITH SAUDI ARABIA, THE UAE, ISRAEL AND QATAR WHILE MAINTAINING PRAGMATIC ENGAGEMENT WITH ANKARA

The author is a retired Additional Director General of the Indian Coast Guard

in Bangladesh’s internal political struggle, and his assertions cannot by themselves constitute an objective assessment of the country’s strategic direction. Pakistan has also denied the allegations concerning ISI interference. Yet dismissing the concerns would be equally unwise. India’s Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs has already identified the growing influence of China and Pakistan in Bangladesh, along with the resurgence of Islamist forces, as significant strategic concerns. The committee has described the changing situation as one of India’s most serious challenges in Bangladesh since 1971. Bangladesh is undergoing a profound political transition, with warmer ties with Pakistan, substantial Chinese influence and concerns over Islamist mobilisation. Yet it cannot simply be equated with Pakistan. India’s priority should be to protect its interests whatever political direction Dhaka takes.

That means strengthening border management, monitoring extremist and intelligence networks, watching Chinese and Pakistani strategic activity, and maintaining channels of communication with all major political constituencies. Taken together, the developments in West Asia and Bangladesh reveal a broader strategic challenge. On India’s western flank, Pakistan is seeking to embed itself within a network involving Saudi Arabia and Turkey. On the eastern flank, Bangladesh’s political transition is creating greater space for China and Pakistan. The two theatres are geographically separate, but their implications for India’s security calculus could increasingly intersect. India should therefore resist the temptation to see every new alignment as an emerging anti-India bloc. Saudi Arabia has substantial economic and strategic interests in India, and Turkey’s relationship with Pakistan does not automatically translate into a unified strategic front against New Delhi. Similarly, Bangladesh’s current political transition does not predetermine its long-term strategic orientation. What India does need is preparedness for the possibility that these relationships could reinforce one another during a future crisis. Pakistan’s diplomatic and military leverage could increase if it successfully converts bilateral partnerships into a broader strategic network. Turkish defence cooperation could enhance Pakistan’s technological capabilities, while Chinese influence in Bangladesh could add pressure on India’s eastern security environment.

The appropriate Indian response is therefore a combination of deterrence, diplomacy and strategic diversification. India must retain credible military preparedness on both its western and eastern fronts while simultaneously investing in economic partnerships, regional connectivity and political engagement. Its relationships with Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Israel and Qatar acquire added significance in this environment. Equally important is preserving India’s long-standing economic, cultural and people-to-people links with Bangladesh across political transitions. The emerging regional order should not be viewed through a binary lens of friends and adversaries. The Mecca Pact may evolve into a significant security arrangement, or its ambitions may ultimately be constrained by the divergent interests of its members. Bangladesh may move closer to China and Pakistan, or eventually seek a more balanced external posture. The outcome will depend less on today’s declarations than on how these relationships develop over time.

India’s strategic advantage lies in retaining the freedom to engage all sides while firmly protecting its national interests. The answer to a widening strategic front is not to widen the definition of the threat, but to sharpen the quality of India’s assessment and response. The region is entering a period in which old alignments are being reshaped and new ones are being tested. India’s response must therefore be neither alarmist nor complacent. It must combine credible deterrence with active diplomacy, economic statecraft with technological preparedness, and vigilance with strategic patience. In an increasingly multipolar neighbourhood, India’s greatest strength may ultimately be its ability to hedge without hesitating, engage without depending, and deter without overreacting.

The Monsoon Session adjourned without adieu



DEVENDER SINGH ASWAL

Sabha is more elaborate and full of nostalgic speeches. Ananthasayanam Ayyangar, the Speaker of the first Lok Sabha, in his valedictory address on 28th March 1957, profusely thanked the MPs for their industry, hard work and cooperation, the legislation passed, and appreciated all the secretarial officers and staff for their strenuous services.

A valedictory address by the Speaker is a parliamentary convention. It’s not a mandatory constitutional or statutory requirement. Of course, it’s another matter that the constitutionally binding direction to elect a Deputy Speaker has not been implemented as yet from the 17th Lok Sabha and as yet in the 18th Lok Sabha. In the absence of a constitutional provision, the Speaker can declare the House adjourned sine die without delivering a valedictory address or making remarks of farewell. However, the practice of making valedictory remarks has been in vogue right from the Constituent Assembly.

Dr Rajendra Prasad, in his address in the last sitting of the Constituent Assembly on 26th November 1949, gave vital information about the work of the CA and apprised the Members about the salient features of the Constitution, the labour of love involved and the expenditure incurred (₹63,96,729).

It is interesting to recall that the 16th Lok Sabha, with 17 sessions, had invariably valedictory addresses. So was it during the 17th Lok Sabha, which had 15 sessions. In case the Speaker is not available, the valedictory reference is made by



the occupant of the Chair. As the 17th Lok Sabha did not choose a Deputy Speaker, the address was made by a member of the panel of Chairmen. This only reinforces the view that it is customary to follow parliamentary conventions and precedents to make a valedictory reference or address.

Therefore, it is quite unusual for the Speaker not to make a valedictory reference on the last day of the Session. However, there is an exception. The last Budget Session was adjourned sine die on 18th April 2026 after singing of the National Song without the customary valedictory speech. Since there is no constitutional provision or Rule, the absence of a valedictory address does not invalidate the adjournment or the session. The Monsoon Session ran from 20th July to 13th August 2026, with 19 sittings by each House. The Session had constant disruptions, though the Government managed to pass as many as 11 Amendment Bills by voice vote amid din and uproar, without discussion. Both the Houses faced constant sloganeering and logjams. Even the Question Hour, considered the most potent parliamentary device to secure accountability of the Executive, was disrupted.

The Question Hour in the Lok Sabha functioned barely for 1 per cent, while in the Rajya Sabha it was 12 per cent. Taken as a whole, the Lok Sabha utilised 15 per cent and the Rajya Sabha 33 per cent of their time. Of the 11 Bills passed by the Lok Sabha, nine were passed without the participation of any member. The Minister in charge introduced the motions for introduction of the Bills, for consideration and passing, and the Bills were passed by voice vote. Only the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, witnessed participation by 48 MPs in the Lok Sabha and by 35 MPs in the Rajya Sabha. Unfortunately, the Session was marred by logjams and protests within the precincts of Parliament.

Not only the MPs of the principal Opposition parties but even the MPs on the Treasury benches held protests. The Opposition demanded a statement by the Home Minister, and the members of the Treasury benches wanted the resignation of the Leader of Opposition. Another memorable feature was that both the Prime Minister and the Home Minister made appearances in the Lok Sabha on 20th July, when the National Anthem – ‘Jana Gana Mana’ – was sung, and on 13th August, when the National Song – ‘Vande Mataram’ – was sung immediately before adjournment sine die.

It is considered befitting to make some courteous valedictory references to the Session that is coming to an end. Such a reference helps remove the sense of discomfiture or acrimony between the Treasury and the benches opposite. The omission of a valedictory speech by the Speaker is probably reflective of the prevailing state of lack of trust, anguish and despair. Be that as it may, the conspicuous departure from the well-settled and salutary practice does not bode well for our competitive parliamentary democracy, claimed to be the Mother of Democracy.

The author is former Additional Secretary, Lok Sabha

UP-Japan Investment Summit: Yogi’s push to put UP on the fast track



ADVAITA KALA

foreign trip in the last year of his second term. The preceding years had been spent preparing the foundation for what was to come.

And in August, it arrived. More than 200 Japanese CEOs, industrialists, investors and policymakers are participating in the UP-Japan Investment Summit, a five-day engagement spanning Delhi, Lucknow, Agra, Greater Noida and Varanasi.

The delegation is led by Yamanashi Governor Kotaro Nagasaki. Yamanashi, the prefecture to the west of Tokyo, is known traditionally as the home of Mount Fuji but has developed a modern, almost futuristic character as an important centre for precision manufacturing, fuel-cell research and green hydrogen technology.

Green hydrogen technology is, in particular, very useful to an emerging manufacturing hub like Uttar Pradesh. Green hydrogen is produced by using renewable energy to split water and is seen as a way to decarbonize industries that

cannot be easily electrified. It has potential applications as diverse as steel, chemicals and fertilizer production. An agrarian state like UP has a high dependence on the ammonia used in fertilisers; green hydrogen offers the possibility of reducing dependence on fossil fuels. The emphasis on green hydrogen indicates that the interaction is not simply about attracting Japanese investment but also the technology that a future-facing Uttar Pradesh will need to expand its industrial capability.

There is an understated cultural motive as well. Yamanashi has demonstrated how a region can preserve cultural provenance while also developing technological and manufacturing capabilities. This aligns with Yogi’s emphasis on cultural preservation and continuity, without succumbing to a model of progress that creates distance from cultural inheritance in the name of modernity.

Encouragingly, the interaction seeks to become institutional as opposed to episodic. Governor Nagasaki has been an advocate for direct cooperation between Japanese prefectures and Indian states, creating an interna-

l economic corridor based on an exchange of strengths.

It would be easy to dismiss the headlines as another economic summit, but the story is deeper than the headlines suggest. Yogi’s economic vision for UP is entering its next phase, after years spent laying the foundations necessary to position the once-BIMARU state as a reliable business partner. Domestic interest grew as his policies began to bear fruit on the ground. Japanese interest is the interna-



outreach produced MOUs of around ₹11,000 crore on the first day itself. But MOUs are promises on paper; what matters is what follows.

The arrival of such a significant and diverse Japanese delegation just six months later suggests that the conversation has moved beyond ceremony. Japanese executives are now evaluating specific opportunities, while projects involving Escorts Kubota and Minda Corporation, representing an investment of

tional dividend accrued after years of sustained effort to pull UP out of the margins of the India story.

And at the heart of this is Yogi’s audacious goal of making UP a trillion-dollar economy.

For a state that was once central to conversations about developmental deficits and lawlessness, this aspiration signals a striking reversal: the Chief Minister, and by extension the state, is seeking to define itself by its possibilities rather than its problems.

This means Uttar Pradesh has to look outwards rather than inwards. Yogi’s Japan initiative is a bold bet. It is a bet on the first day itself. But MOUs are promises on paper; what matters is what follows. The arrival of such a significant and diverse Japanese delegation just six months later suggests that the conversation has moved beyond ceremony. Japanese executives are now evaluating specific opportunities, while projects involving Escorts Kubota and Minda Corporation, representing an investment of

nearly ₹3,200 crore, with the possibility of creating 10,000 new jobs, are moving to the ground-breaking stage.

This is bricks and mortar stuff, not paperwork.

Yogi’s vision seems to divide UP’s transformation into two seasons. The first was about constructing the foundations: law and order, expressways, airports, power supply, industrial corridors and administrative reform. The next is about setting the table, and the seats are filling up fast.

Those roads must now bring supplies and workforce to the factories; those new airports must connect UP to markets and expertise across the country and abroad. Industrial corridors must buzz with the turning of global supply chains. The trillion-dollar goal means UP’s Chief Minister must sell UP not only in Mumbai and Bangalore but also in Singapore and Tokyo. Uttar Pradesh is now not only about change but about being competitive.

The trillion-dollar target is not simply a large number attached to a government presentation; it is an organizing principle. Will it move Uttar Pradesh from being primarily viewed through the scale of its problems to being understood for the scale of its economic potential? Yogi Adityanath has seen the possibility. Increasingly, so has the country. Will the world? Stay tuned. This is just the beginning of a new season.

The writer is an Indian author, screenwriter and columnist



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Order Order

Delhi HC to hear *India Kanoon* plea on Sep 2 against right to be forgotten order



The Delhi High Court on Wednesday set down for hearing on September 2 appeals by legal database platform *India Kanoon* against a single judge order directing it to de-index and disable its “name-based search functionality” for certain judicial orders based on “right to be forgotten”.

A bench of Justices C Hari Shankar and Vinod Kumar orally observed that public interest favoured “access”, and asked why one should not be permitted to have access to any judicial record based on a party’s name.

“There is a judgement of the high court and the Supreme Court on Harshad Mehta. Why should I not be able to search for Harshad Mehta?” the bench asked.

“(To say that) without the writ petition number, case details, you will never be able to access any judgement... If the single judge says that one of the considerations which can balance is public interest, public interest is in favour of access to this... No one knows this (writ number),” the bench added. On May 29, the single-judge bench recognised an individual’s “right to be forgotten” and directed India Kanoon and Google to de-index and disable name-based searches.

(PTI)

SC issues notice to Govt on DNA, biometric ID for missing, rescued kids



The Supreme Court on Wednesday sought responses from the Centre and the NCPCR on a PIL seeking the establishment of a national DNA and biometric identification system for missing and rescued children to facilitate scientific identification, tracing and reunification with their families.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana issued notices to the Union Ministry of Home Affairs and the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR) after taking note of the petition filed by Reepak Kansal.

The petition, filed through advocate-on-record Pravir Choudhary, sought directions to the Centre and all the states and union territories (UTs) to create a centralised system, backed by statutory safeguards, for DNA and biometric identification of missing and rescued children.

“Issue an appropriate writ, order or direction directing the Union of India and all States/Union Territories to establish a national DNA, and biometric identification system for missing and rescued children, with proper statutory safeguards, to enable scientific matching and restoration of identity,” the plea said. It also sought a direction to the authorities to conduct mandatory DNA sampling, subject to due safeguards and consent protocols, of all unidentified rescued children and willing biological parents and guardians of missing children for the purpose of reunification and identity confirmation.

(PTI)

Graham Staines murder case: SC asks Odisha to take decision on convict Dara Singh’s remission plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday pulled up the Odisha Government for not taking a decision on the remission plea of Ravindra Pal alias Dara Singh, who is serving life sentence for the murder of Australian missionary Graham Stuart Staines and his two minor sons in 1999.

“You take a decision whatever you want to. Otherwise we will take our own. If you don’t take a decision, we will,” a bench of Justices Manoj Misra and Vijay Bishnoi told the counsel appearing for the state.

“We can’t tolerate this avoiding taking a decision,” the bench observed.

It noted that the matter has been adjourned time and again to enable the authority to take a decision on the plea of remission of sentence given to Singh, who has been incarcerated for a period exceeding 26 years.

The bench observed that when the matter was adjourned on July 14, the State Sentence Review Board was in the process of taking a decision on Singh’s plea.

It said the counsel representing the state has now placed before it a letter



of the Directorate of Prisons and Correctional Services addressed to the lawyer and stating that a report from the Keonjhar district jail is yet to be received. “We are not informed about the decision of the Sentence Review Board,” the top court said.

While posting the matter for September 2, the bench said the board should take a decision and apprise the court. “We are not concerned about how you are communicating, to what authority you are communicating. You just take a decision,” the bench observed.

The bench said, “But don’t try and dodge us by giving us the letter... How

SC seeks Govt’s update on implementation of Radhakrishnan panel recommendations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Observing that there is a need to institutionalise the reforms in the National Testing Agency, the Supreme Court on Wednesday directed the Centre to inform it about the steps taken to implement recommendations of the Radhakrishnan panel and the Nandan Nilekani committee.

A bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe said reforms in the National Testing Agency (NTA) must be institutionalised and technological changes are needed for conduct of smooth entrance examinations. The seven-member Radhakrishnan Committee was set up by the Ministry of Education in the wake of the NEET-UG paper leak to make recommendations on reforms in the examination process, improvement in data security protocols and the structure and functioning of the NTA.

The Government had also set up a high powered task force led by Infosys co-founder Nilekani for structural reforms in competitive examinations.

“The Radhakrishnan Committee has correctly said it is a systemic problem which needs institutionalisation, which is the most important part of it. This process on paper everything



is good. But then one exam happens and by the time the second exam happens it is a new picture all together,” the bench said.

The top court said the NTA should be equipped with all necessary infrastructure, manpower and other technological capabilities.

“We are informed that the committee which has been constituted has considered various recommendations for reforms, focusing on leveraging advance technology like AI and blockchain to strengthen the security and integrity of the examination.

“We direct the Secretary to file an affidavit indicating and detailing the steps that have been taken to implement the suggestions made by the Radhakrishnan committee as reflected and nuanced by the Nandan Nilekani committee. Affidavit

separate identified printers under CCTV cameras and surveillance of the CISF.

He submitted that the question papers are transported under police escort and GPS tracking and stored in separate bank strong rooms.

Mehta said on the day of examination, one set of question paper is selected, transported to examination centres under security and opened in the presence of officials and students, with the process being video-graphed.

At this juncture, the apex court pointed out that the safeguards being described by Mehta had already been considered by the Radhakrishnan Committee.

The court stressed that there was a need to ensure that the NTA functions as a vibrant institution.

“Our duty is to ensure that there is a vibrant institution that the country can be proud of. If you don’t institutionalise, experienced people get transferred and the entire experience is lost. There are a lot of technological changes that have to be brought about,” the bench said.

The bench also cited the example of the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) to explain how an examination-conducting body develops institutional expertise over time.

UGC-NET June 2026 exam to be conducted again in September: Centre to Delhi HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre on Wednesday informed the Delhi High Court that a retest is being conducted for three subjects, including Sociology, of the UGC-NET June 2026 examination following complaints of some errors in the questionnaires.

Taking note of the submission of Solicitor General (SG) Tushar Mehta, representing the Centre, Justice Jasmeet Singh disposed of a plea filed by a candidate, who appeared for the Sociology

paper on June 30, seeking a stay on the declaration of results pending an independent probe and re-conduct of the exam following allegations of paper leak.

While the English and Commerce papers will be held on September 9, the Sociology paper will be held on September 10, the SG told the high court. He said nothing survived in the petition as the authorities have decided to re-conduct the test.

Justice Jasmeet Singh recorded the statement of the law officer and said: “In view of the statement of the



Solicitor General, the prayer in the petition does not survive and the petition is disposed of”. The National

Testing Agency (NTA) conducted the UGC-NET June 2026 examination from June 22 to 30 across 87 subjects for

SC slams ICG for denying permanent commission to female officer

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday came down heavily on the Indian Coast Guard (ICG) for not granting permanent commission to a female officer, saying “we will not allow women officers to be humiliated”.

Terming the policy released by the Indian Coast Guard on Tuesday as “vague” and “arbitrary”, a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana gave two weeks to the ICG to take a call on the induction of officer Priyanka Tyagi as a permanent commission officer or the court would pass orders for her absorption.

“The policy is vague and appears to be arbitrary. The entire effort is to reject. Tomorrow you will say height is not correct and weight is not appropriate,” the bench said.

It said hyper-technical objections will not work.

“If you can give permanent commission to males, then why not to women officers? We will not allow the women officers to be humiliated in this fashion,” the bench said.

It told Attorney General R Venkataramani, appearing for the ICG, that the court is giving two weeks to it to take a decision and then it will pass an appropriate order.

“If you can do it in two weeks, fine; or we will pass



orders for her absorption,” the bench said as it reserved its decision on the plea of Tyagi for consideration as permanent commission officer.

CJI Kant said, “Show some sportsmanship. Take a decision in two weeks.”

Tyagi, a Short Service Appointee (SSA) officer having completed more than

14 years in service, approached the court for grant of permanent commission after being denied by the authorities and instead was directed to be released from service.

The top court in 2024 directed the ICG to reinstate the officer, who was part of the first-ever all-women crew on a Dornier

No OMR tampering in NEET-UG retest: SG Mehta tells Delhi HC



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta told the Delhi High Court on Wednesday that there was no tampering with the OMR sheets of candidates of the NEET-UG re-test.

Appearing in a PIL on the issue, Mehta said that “loose kind of drafting and arguments” alleging “large-scale tampering” in the re-test ought not be allowed as they would set a “narrative”.

“There is no tampering in any OMR sheet. None of this has happened. Don’t sensationalise,” he submitted before a bench of Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia.

The bench was hearing the PIL by two NEET-UG candidates seeking additional marks for themselves, as well as “similarly affected candidates” for certain

dropped questions, and scrapping of the National Testing Agency (NTA). One of the petitioners also alleged that her OMR sheet had been tampered with. The PIL sought the constitution of an expert committee to look into the concerns over irregularities in the examination raised by the petitioners.

Mehta stated that the petitioner’s case appeared to be of a mismatch between her “rough work” on the question paper and the answer marked on the OMR sheet, and there was no manipulation.

“They say there is tampering with the OMR sheet. Who will tamper,” Mehta asked.

The counsel for the petitioners submitted that the issues raised in the plea, including that of tampering with OMR sheets and non-award of marks for dropped questions, concerned thousands of candidates.

award of Junior Research Fellowship (JRF), eligibility for assistant professor and admission to PhD programmes.

The SG made the statement at the outset of the hearing on the petition, which sought a stay of declaration of results pending an independent probe and to re-conduct the examination for the subjects if the leak is confirmed.

Petitioner Aman Singh Yadav, the candidate who appeared for the Sociology paper on June 30, sought interim protection against declaration of results pending

an independent investigation into the allegations that the question paper was leaked and commercially circulated hours before the examination.

The plea said the petitioner has already given representation to the NTA regarding serious errors in the paper and also on the leak, but no response has been received yet.

It also sought a direction for an independent CBI or SIT probe into the alleged leak of the question papers. The CBI was represented by standing counsel Premtosh Mishra.

Coal scam cases: SC asks Delhi HC not to stay trials, dispose of appeals in four weeks



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday asked the Delhi High Court not to grant any stay on trials in coal block allocation scam cases and decide pending appeals of accused within four weeks to ensure their rights are not adversely affected.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana passed the orders after it was pointed out that in some coal scam cases the accused have moved the high court for relief while in some cases they have moved the top court.

“No interim stay can be granted by the Delhi High Court. However, keeping in view the fact that non-stay of the trial may prejudice the rights of the accused, the high court is directed to decide such petitions preferably in four weeks,” the bench ordered.

The bench said it has not expressed any opinion on the merit of any case.

Last month, the top court, while relaxing its nearly 12-year-old order mandating appeals arising from the orders of special court in coal block allocation scam cases to be filed in the top court, the bench had said the prosecution and accused can move the Delhi High Court challenging acquittals or convictions recorded by the special judge.

Delhi court acquits husband, in-laws in dowry death case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Wednesday acquitted a man and his parents of charges of subjecting his wife to cruelty and causing her dowry death, saying that the prosecution failed to prove the allegations beyond reasonable doubt.

Additional Sessions Judge Pooja Talwar acquitted Rohit Kumar, and his parents Sunita and Vijay Kumar in the 2016 death of Lalita, who had died by suicide within seven months of her marriage.

In an order, the court said, “As per the prosecution story, the deceased was out of her matrimonial home from September 24, 2016 and she committed suicide on October 17, 2016. In the intervening period, she was neither in touch with her husband nor with her in-laws.



“Hence, she was not under the influence of any of the accused persons for almost a month before she took the drastic step of ending her life.”

The court said the prosecution failed to establish that Lalita was subjected to cruelty or harassment by the accused in connection with dowry demands, which was essential to sustain the charges under the law.

According to the prosecution, Lalita married Rohit on

March 11, 2016. Her father had alleged that the family demanded a Honda City car and gold ring before the marriage and later made further dowry demands.

Lalita returned to her parental home on September 24, 2016, and committed suicide by hanging herself from a ceiling fan on October 17, 2016. A suicide note was recovered from her clothes and her mobile phone containing voice recordings was also seized.

However, during the trial, the parents and sister of the deceased did not support the prosecution’s allegations of dowry harassment and cruelty.

The court noted that Lalita’s father had stated that she never complained to him about any dowry demand and it was possible she had returned home because of differences with her husband.

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KKR to acquire minority stake in BookMyShow



Global investment firm KKR on Wednesday said it has signed definitive agreements to acquire a minority stake in Indian ticketing and live entertainment platform BookMyShow. While the financial details of the transaction were not disclosed, the investment is aimed at supporting BookMyShow's growth as it scales its live entertainment business and deepens its full-stack offering across India, the companies said in a joint statement. "BookMyShow has been a pioneer in delivering high-quality entertainment experiences in India. We believe BookMyShow will play an important role in advancing India's ambition to become a global entertainment hub and a premier destination for leading artists and acts from around the world," said Akshay Tanna, Partner and Head of India Private Equity at KKR. Established in 2007 and owned by Bigtree Entertainment Pvt Ltd, BookMyShow has evolved from a purely online movie ticketing platform to an end-to-end management of live entertainment events, including music concerts, live performances, theatricals, and sports.

IDFC First Bank raises \$500 m in maiden international bond



IDFC First Bank on Wednesday said it has raised \$500 million in debt, with global investors like BlackRock, Capital Group, and AllianceBernstein anchoring its maiden international bond issuance. The bank, through its IFSC Banking Unit at GIFT City, issued the bonds with a tenure of three years and a fixed coupon of 5.625 per cent. The notes were placed with investors outside the US in Regulation S format, IDFC First Bank said in a statement. This is the bank's first international bond issuance and marks its entry into the global debt capital markets. S&P Global Ratings has assigned a 'BBB-' long-term issuer credit rating with a stable outlook to the bond issuance. "The transaction was anchored by marquee global institutional investors, including BlackRock, Capital Group, AllianceBernstein, etc. Their participation reflects strong investor confidence in the bank's financial strength, growing franchise, prudent risk management and long-term prospects," it said. The successful placement of the notes broadens the bank's funding base and establishes an important new avenue for accessing international capital.

Amway India, Emami, Bonn Biscuits, three other firms withdraw false claims on product labels, ads: FSSAI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Food regulator FSSAI on Wednesday said that Amway India, Emami, Bonn Biscuits and three other companies have withdrawn misleading '100 per cent' claims from their product labelling and advertisements, following its enforcement actions against these firms. In a social media post, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) informed that it has initiated action against food business operators (FBOs) to discontinue the use of the term "100 percent" on labels, packaging & promotional or advertising materials. Following FSSAI's intervention, five FBOs have taken corrective action & withdrawn "100 percent" claims from their products and advertisements. In the case of Bonn Biscuits Pvt Ltd, the FSSAI said that the company was using the "100 percent" claim in the advertisement for Bonn Cummin Flavour Jeera Bite Biscuits, 76 gm. Now, the company has removed the "100 percent" claim from the website. On Emami Ltd, the FSSAI said that the company was using a 100 per cent claim for its product Zhandu Honey. Emami has complied with the FSSAI advisory and took corrective action with respect to



the claim, it added. Apis India has also removed similar claims from its honey products. In the case of Amway India Enterprises Pvt Ltd, the FSSAI said that the company was using the "100 percent Pure Coconut Oil" claim in one of its products. Following regulatory intervention, Amway India submitted a compliance response, confirming voluntary removal of the term "100 percent" from product packaging and promotional materials. Amway also informed the regulator that old stock has been discontinued from sales channels. Similarly, Juza Foods, Kerala, has removed 100 per cent claims from its various baby food products. Masterchow

UP hosts Japan investment meet, unveils Japanese City in YEIDA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Government of Uttar Pradesh organised the U.P.-Japan Investment Meet 2026 at Taj Palace, New Delhi, on Wednesday, bringing together more than 200 Japanese CEOs, Managing Directors, Country Heads and senior industry representatives to strengthen economic, industrial and technological cooperation between Uttar Pradesh and Japan. The event was addressed by Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, Union Minister for Agriculture & Farmers' Welfare Shivraj Singh Chouhan, Union Minister for Railways, Electronics & Information Technology Ashwini Vaishnaw, and Uttar Pradesh Finance & Parliamentary Affairs Minister Suresh Kumar Khanna. In their addresses, the speakers highlighted Uttar Pradesh's transformation over the past few years, emphasising improved law and order, rapid industrialisation, world-class infrastructure, investor-friendly policies and proactive governance. They said these developments have positioned the state as one of India's attractive destinations for global investment and strengthened its contribution to the country's economic growth.



Welcoming the Japanese delegation, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath underlined Uttar Pradesh's emergence as a major investment hub, supported by an extensive network of expressways, airports, industrial corridors, logistics infrastructure and seamless connectivity. He invited Japanese companies to become active partners in Uttar Pradesh's growth story and contribute to India's journey towards becoming a developed nation. The Chief Minister also announced the development of a dedicated "Japanese City" over approximately 500 acres in Sector-5A of the

Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA). The proposed township will offer an integrated industrial, commercial and residential ecosystem for Japanese companies and citizens. Yogi Adityanath invited Japanese investors to establish their presence in the proposed Japanese City and explore investment opportunities across Uttar Pradesh. Groundbreaking ceremonies for major industrial projects A key highlight of the event was the Virtual Groundbreaking Ceremony (GBC) for two major industrial projects in the

YEIDA region. For Escorts Kubota Limited, a virtual groundbreaking ceremony was held for its manufacturing facility in Sector-10, YEIDA. The company has been allotted 154 acres of land for the project, which involves an investment of approximately ₹2,029 crore and is expected to generate around 4,000 employment opportunities. The facility will manufacture approximately 60,000 tractors annually, along with a wide range of tractor and agricultural machinery components. The project is expected to further strengthen Uttar Pradesh's position as a hub for agricul-

tural machinery and engineering manufacturing. The event also featured the Virtual Groundbreaking Ceremony for Spark Minda Group's manufacturing projects in Sectors 10 and 24 of YEIDA. The projects involve a combined investment of approximately ₹1,166 crore and are expected to generate around 6,440 employment opportunities. The facilities will manufacture nearly 2 million units annually, including electronic switches, sensors, USB chargers and other automotive electronic components. The investment is expected to strengthen Uttar

Pradesh's automotive and electronics manufacturing ecosystem. Focus on emerging sectors During his address, the Chief Minister identified Green Hydrogen, Solar Energy, Electronics, Medical Devices, Automotive Manufacturing, Semiconductors and Advanced Manufacturing as key sectors for future India-Japan collaboration. He reiterated the Uttar Pradesh government's commitment to providing world-class infrastructure, skilled manpower and a business-friendly environment to investors. The event was attended by Deepak Kumar, Infrastructure and Industrial Development Commissioner (IIDC), Government of Uttar Pradesh; Alok Kumar, Chairman, YEIDA; Rakesh Kumar Singh, Chief Executive Officer, YEIDA; and Shailendra Kumar Bhatia, Additional Chief Executive Officer and Nodal Officer, Investment Cell, YEIDA, along with senior government officials and representatives of leading Indian and Japanese companies. The U.P.-Japan Investment Meet 2026 marked another milestone in strengthening India-Japan economic relations and further reinforced Uttar Pradesh's position as a preferred destination for global manufacturing and industrial investment.

Gadkari warns of action against faulty project reports

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Consultants involved in preparing defective detailed project reports (DPRs) are "culprits" behind accidents and deaths on highways, Union minister Nitin Gadkari said on Wednesday, and warned contractors of black-listing and other consequences for compromising on construction quality. The minister's warning has come amid reports that his ministry is preparing tunnel tenders worth ₹2 lakh crore to ₹2.5 lakh crore. Addressing industry body FICCI's 4th Edition of Tunnels & Bridges Conference 2026 in the national capital, the road, transport and highways minister termed the makers of defective DPRs as "culprits" and alleged that consultants prepare these documents with the help of Google, causing loss of life and property. "Such poor-quality DPRs mean that today on roads, 5 lakh accidents occur, and 1.8 lakh deaths, and all have the problem of defective DPRs," Gadkari said. The minister also cautioned contractors against

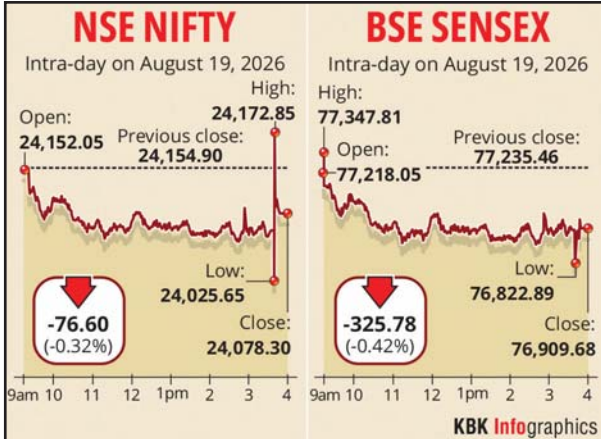


Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari speaks during the 4th Edition of Tunnels and Bridges Conference at FICCI Federation House in New Delhi

compromising on construction quality after bagging an infrastructure project. There will be a performance audit besides a financial audit, and based on the results, the contractors will be punished and black-listed, he said. Due to all this, economic loss happens, and people are losing lives in road accidents, he said. Gadkari further said that ratings will be given to contractors and DPR consultants based on which it will

be decided whether to allow them to participate in future bids or not. The minister further said that his ministry would review the existing provisions governing sub-contracting of highway works to ensure that contractual requirements are strictly adhered to and that responsibility for quality and timely execution remains clearly with the principal contractor. According to FICCI, the Union Road Transport &

Highways is preparing tunnel tenders worth ₹2 lakh crore to ₹2.5 lakh crore. Gadkari encouraged the industry to lead on domestic manufacture of tunnel boring machines, whose capital cost he identified as a binding constraint, and to convene a technical session on ultra-high performance concrete, FICCI said. In his address, S Paramasivan, Chair, FICCI Committee on Roads & Highways, placed four industry concerns before the Minister. Paramasivan, who is also the Managing Director, Afcons Infrastructure, said the predominant use of L1, or lowest-bid, award was producing tenders 20 per cent or more below estimated cost, putting commercial viability and execution quality under pressure. "Provisions for quality-cum-cost based selection already exist at the finance ministry and MoRTH but see little use, he said, urging their adoption as the preferred method for complex projects and those above ₹1,000 crore, with technical parameters weighted at 70 to 80 per cent," he said.



Markets fall as rising crude oil prices unnerve investors

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

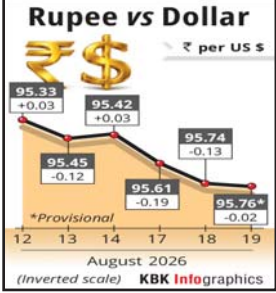
Benchmark equity indices Sensex and Nifty closed lower on Wednesday as elevated crude oil prices amid a lack of a diplomatic resolution following the end of the US-Iran ceasefire dented investor sentiment. The expiry of the temporary 60-day US-Iran ceasefire without any meaningful diplomatic breakthrough has renewed concerns over a prolonged disruption to energy supplies, driving crude oil prices

higher, an expert said. The 30-share BSE Sensex was down 325.78 points, or 0.42 per cent, to settle at 76,909.68, registering its fourth day of decline. During the day, it dropped 412.57 points, or 0.53 per cent, to 76,822.89. In the last four days, the benchmark has lost 1,170.28 points, or 1.49 per cent. Extending its losses to the seventh day, the 50-share NSE Nifty declined 76.60 points, or 0.32 per cent, to end at 24,078.30. It has tumbled 505.5 points, or 2 per cent, in the last seven sessions.

Rupee falls 2 paise to settle at 95.76 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

The rupee fell 2 paise to close at 95.76 (provisional) against the US dollar on Wednesday as a sharp rise in global crude oil prices amid heightened tensions in West Asia kept markets on edge. A sharp decline in domestic equity markets put further pressure on the local unit, while RBI intervention and foreign fund inflows lent support, according to forex traders. At the interbank foreign



exchange, the rupee opened at 95.72 and traded in a very narrow range of 95.72-95.76. It eventually settled at 95.76 (provisional), down 2 paise from its previous close.

Grid, storage readiness to drive next phase of RE growth: ICRA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Electricity grid and energy storage readiness will drive the next phase of renewable energy growth while the aggressive BESS bidding will keep a tab on project economics, rating agency ICRA said on Wednesday. ICRA projects the share of generation from renewable energy (RE) capacity, including large hydro, to cross 35 per cent by 2029-30 from 22 per cent in 2024-25. While the bidding activity



has witnessed a slowdown amid challenges in the signing of the power purchase agreements (PPA) and power sale agreements (PSA), as well as delays in ramp-up of the

transmission capacity, the renewable power pipeline remains healthy with more than 150 GW of projects under construction as on June 30, 2026, which are likely to drive the capacity additions in the near-to-medium term, an ICRA statement said. As the transmission infrastructure has lagged | the growth in generation capacity, there have been issues pertaining to curtailments, especially for projects running on temporary general network access (T-GNA).

Lower gold prices fuel demand, raise festive season expectations: WGC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

Gold demand conditions are improving in the country as consumers responded to lower and more stable prices, which has raised expectations of a stronger festive season, according to the World Gold Council. Demand conditions are improving, raising expectations of a stronger festive season, stated the World Gold Council's latest India Gold Market Update. However, elevated gold prices might continue to influence jewellery purchases, it added. According to WGC, jewellery demand has reportedly strengthened, as consumers viewed recent price action as a buying opportunity. Consumers responded to lower and more stable prices, which cor-



rected in June after a period of stability in July and recovered in August, leading retailers and manufacturers to replenish inventories

ahead of the festive season. Industry feedback revealed that deferred purchases have returned to the market, resulting in higher foot-

fall and a recovery in demand beyond essential wedding-related purchases. Manufacturers have reportedly begun receiving higher order flows, and inventory replenishment by jewellers has picked up ahead of the festive season, suggesting growing confidence in seasonal demand. Old gold exchange remains elevated and continues to play an important role in facilitating purchases. Physical investment demand, while moderating from earlier highs, remained supportive during the period of price correction. Lower prices continued to attract investors seeking strategic exposure to gold, while the recent rebound appears to have revived interest.

Zelenskyy fires senior aide amid probe as ex-minister calls for poll

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kyiv

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy fired one of his most senior officials on Wednesday as corruption investigators named a deputy head of the presidential office among the suspects in a money-laundering case.

The stunning developments came a day after Ukraine's recently fired defense minister demanded national elections, despite Russia's more than 4-year-old invasion. Although Zelenskyy was not implicated in the graft investigation, it threatened to pull him into another political crisis and provide another test of his resilience.

Investigators gave few details of the probe. It has identified a group of people alleged to have laundered 150 million hryvnias (\$3.4 million) to pay bail for a defendant in a major graft case last year, the National Anti-Corruption Bureau said.

That case, involving the state-owned nuclear power company, brought the resignations of Ukraine's justice and energy ministers.

The latest suspects include a former lawmaker, the chairperson of a state bank's board and the head of the bank's supervisory board, as well as a deputy head of the presidential office, the agency said.

Zelenskyy made no public comment on the investigation but issued a decree dismissing Iryna Mudra as



deputy head of the Office of the President. Investigators have not named her as a suspect. Investigators searched Mudra's office Wednesday, said lawmaker Oleksii Honcharenko.

Zelenskyy remains dogged by high-level graft investigations, although he has never been named as a suspect even as the probes have engulfed officials close to him. Last year, his chief of staff Andriy Yermak resigned and later was named as a suspect in a major graft probe involving a luxury construction project in the biggest threat to Zelenskyy's government since Russia's 2022 invasion. The European Union has identified deep-seated corruption as one of the major hurdles to Ukraine's desired membership in the bloc.

Zelenskyy is already under pressure over his firing last month of Defense Minister Mykhailo Fedorov, one of the longest-standing members of his team and a close ally

since helping him win the 2019 presidential election.

Zelenskyy, seeking to reconcile tensions between the Defense Ministry's young and tech-savvy innovators and Ukraine's seasoned, Soviet-trained battlefield leaders, risked angering both sides by reshuffling his wartime leadership. He ousted both Fedorov, whose changes to military procurement aimed to stamp out corruption, and commander-in-chief Gen. Oleksandr Syrskyi.

That sparked street protests supporting Fedorov. For Zelenskyy, it was the second time in a year that a move triggered a strong public backlash, after he tried to curb the powers of anti-corruption agencies in 2025.

Fedorov, in an address posted to YouTube late Tuesday, called for elections - appearing to directly confront Zelenskyy, whose term expired in 2024. Ukraine's constitution prohibits such a vote under martial law.

"We must find a legal, safe and realistic mechanism that will allow Ukraine to restore a full democratic process even amid a prolonged war," Fedorov said.

He said Ukraine faces a crisis in how it is governed, arguing the current system is oriented toward protecting itself and resisting change. He also condemned corruption among officials without naming anyone, saying it had weakened Ukraine's ability to fight. Zelenskyy's office did not immediately comment on Fedorov's address. It was not immediately clear whether Fedorov's appeal would resonate with Ukrainians.

Also on Wednesday, lawmakers approved Zelenskyy's candidate, Maj Gen Yevhenii Khmara, as the new defense minister, a move that effectively closes the door to Fedorov's return to the post, which he has sought, anytime soon. Lawmakers also gave their consent for Andrii Sybiha to stay on as foreign minister after serving in an interim role.

The political disarray follows recent successes for Ukraine in the war. Using innovative drone technology, it has repeatedly hit Russian oil facilities, causing fuel shortages. It has also shocked the Russian public by striking warehouses of Wildberries, the country's biggest online retailer, and stalled front-line advances by Moscow's bigger army.

PM Modi wants Rahman's visit to be memorable, says Indian envoy

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Dhaka

Prime Minister Narendra Modi wants his Bangladeshi counterpart Tarique Rahman's proposed visit to India to be "memorable", Indian High Commissioner Dinesh Trivedi has said, stressing that closer ties between the two leaders would ultimately benefit people and businesses in both countries.

The envoy's remarks on Tuesday came as uncertainty looms over Rahman's proposed visit to New Delhi for the BRICS summit on September 12-13 amid fresh strains in bilateral ties over Dhaka's demand for the extradition of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina.

Speaking at a reception hosted by the Indian High Commission here on Tuesday for leading Bangladeshi business leaders and a visiting delegation of the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII), Trivedi said Modi had conveyed that the two leaders needed to meet and assured that Rahman would receive an appropriate welcome during his visit to India, news portal tbsnews.net reported.

"Prime Minister Modi just mentioned one thing. We need to meet. And you can tell them on my behalf that you have the prime minister of India's assurance that when the honourable



prime minister of Bangladesh visits India, he will have such an honourable reception as he deserves," he said. Trivedi said Modi wanted Rahman's visit to be "memorable", underlining that stronger engagement between the two leaders would benefit both the neighbours.

"Ultimately, the benefit will go to people and businesses. Business people all over the world have a big role to play in bridging this gap," he said. Trivedi said the two countries should address past differences while looking ahead. "I am not telling that you forget the past, but keep the past and sort out the differences of the past. But move on. Don't get stagnant," he said.

He said differences are natural between "vibrant democracies" and could be addressed through dialogue and engagement.

"We deeply understand the concerns of brothers and sisters of Bangladesh. Definitely, there are concerns. But this is a partner-

ship of equals," Trivedi said. He stressed that mutual trust would be essential for a durable relationship.

"The foundation of any long-lasting relation is mutual and unconditional trust," the envoy said.

Highlighting India's "Neighbourhood First" policy, Trivedi said the two countries had gone through "hiccups" but should not allow differences to undermine their broader relationship. "We have shared history, we have shared culture, and this is where we need to foster," he said.

Referring to the younger generation in Bangladesh, Trivedi said India wanted to work with the "new Bangladesh" to create greater opportunities for its youth. "This is a new Bangladesh. And this new Bangladesh has the youth. And youth has also gone through a lot of struggles and a lot of sacrifice. So, our objective obviously [is] to have peace and prosperity and the youth must get that opportunity," he said.

Bangladesh to seek guarantee clause in renewed Ganga Water Treaty



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Dhaka

Bangladesh will seek a "guarantee clause" in the renewed Ganges Water Treaty with India and is ready to approach international forums to protect its water rights, according to media reports.

Water Resources Minister Shahiduddin Chowdhury Anee made the remarks at a seminar titled "Ganges Water Treaty: Issues for Renegotiation" organised by the Bangladesh Institute of Law and International Affairs in Dhaka. The remarks came as the India-Bangladesh Ganges Water Treaty, signed in 1996 to govern dry-season sharing of the river's waters, is due to expire in December.

Anee said Dhaka remained committed to renegotiating the treaty and hoped that PM Rahman would make a strong case for Bangladesh at the UN, the BSS report said.

STATE BANK OF INDIA

Home Loan Centre (HLC) C-59
Community Centre, Naraina Industrial
Area Phase - 1, New Delhi-110028

DEMAND
NOTICE

NOTICE UNDER SECTION 13(2) OF THE SECURITIZATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 (No. 3 of 2002).

A notice is hereby given that the below mentioned Borrower/s have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest of the loans facility obtained by them from the Bank and the loans have been classified as Non - Performing Assets (NPA). The notices were issued to them under Section 13(2) of Securitization and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 on their last known addresses, but they have been returned unserved and as such they are hereby informed by way of this public notice.

DESCRIPTION OF HYPOTHECATION OF MOVABLE ASSETS				
Sl. No.	Name & Address of the Borrower	Description of the Property Mortgaged / Charged	Date of Demand Notice	Amount Outstanding (as on the date of notice)
1.	MR. RAJVEER SINGH S/O MR. SIPATTAR SINGH, H. No.9/2113, 1st Floor, Gali No.7, Kailash Nagar, Near Yamuna Bartaan Bhandar, East Delhi-110031 Car Loan A/c. No.: 45074678849 Also At: RS International, 9/1822 A, Gali No.2, Kailash Nagar, Block- Top/Floor, Near Mahavir Swami Park, Gandhi Nagar, New Delhi-110031. Also At: R S International, 17/10, Mandir Marg, Geeta Colony, New Delhi-110031. Also At: H. No.582, Hanuman Colony, Near PDM Public School, Vinay Nagar, Part-3, Tilpat Faridabad, Haryana-121003.	Make & Model: MAHINDRA THAR ROXX AX7L D AT RWD Vehicle No.: HR 51CX 5270 Engine No.: KYS4148497 Chassis No.: MA1UN2KY7T2A10345	07/08/2026 Date of N.P.A. 06/08/2026	Rs.19,53,916/- (Rupees Nineteen Lakh Fifty Three Thousand Nine Hundred Sixteen Only) as on 07/08/2026 with further interest and incidental expenses, costs and charges etc. thereon

We invite your attention to the provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act which speaks about the time available to the borrower/guarantor to redeem the secured assets.

The steps are being taken for substituted service of notice. The above Borrower(s) and/or their Guarantor(s) (whenever applicable) are hereby called upon to make payment of outstanding amount within 60 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which further steps will be taken after expiry of 60 days from the date of this notice under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

"This notice is without prejudice to the Bank's right to initiate such other actions or legal proceedings, as it deems necessary under any other applicable provisions of Law".

Date: 19.08.2026
Place: New Delhi

Sd/- Authorized Officer & (Chief Manager)
State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, Naraina New Delhi

NORTHERN RAILWAY (E-Auction Notice)

The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager/ G, Northern Railway, Delhi Division, New Delhi invites e-Auction through IREPS (https://ireps.gov.in/) for allotment of contracts of General Minor Units (GMUs) for Catering Units at following railway stations/locations:

SN	Auction Catalogue No.	Date & Time for e-Auction	Railway Station	Lot No.	Type of Unit
1	CTG-AUG-01-26	07.09.2026 at 11:00 Hrs	Modinagar	Catg-DLI-MDNR-GMU-125-25-1	General Minor Unit (GMU)
2			Garhi Harsaru	Catg-DLI-GHHZ-GMU-99-25-1	
3			Mansa	Catg-DLI-MSZ-GMU-140-25-1	
4				Catg-DLI-MSZ-GMU-138-25-1	
5			Behta Hajipur	Catg-DLI-BHHZ-GMU-157-25-1	
6				Catg-DLI-BHHZ-GMU-90-25-1	
7			Khekra	Catg-DLI-KEX-GMU-105-25-1	
8			Ganaur	Catg-DLI-GNU-GMU-146-25-1	
9				Catg-DLI-GNU-GMU-133-25-1	
10			Khatauli	Catg-DLI-KAT-GMU-103-25-1	
11				Catg-DLI-KAT-GMU-129-25-1	
12			Mangolpuri	Catg-DLI-MGLP-GMU-108-25-1	
13			Julana	Catg-DLI-JNA-GMU-98-25-1	
14			Asaoli	Catg-DLI-AST-GMU-148-25-1	
15				Catg-DLI-AST-GMU-100-25-1	
16			Budhlada	Catg-DLI-BLZ-GMU-171-25-1	
17			Holambai Kalan	Catg-DLI-HUK-GMU-114-25-1	
18			Bareilly	Catg-DLI-BRZ-GMU-88-25-1	
19			Fakharpur	Catg-DLI-FAP-GMU-95-25-1	
20			Maur	Catg-DLI-MAUR-GMU-151-25-1	
21			Gotra Halt	Catg-DLI-GTRA-GMU-158-25-1	
22			Gharaunda	Catg-DLI-GRA-GMU-97-25-1	

Website particulars where complete details of E-Auction can be seen | <https://ireps.gov.in/> (E-Auction-Leasing)

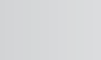
All contractors who intend to participate in the e-auctions conducted through E-Auction Leasing module of IREPS should fulfil following mandatory requirements before they can submit their bids:

- Registration on IREPS for E-Auction Leasing module - Active IREPS User Account for E-Auction Leasing Module.
- Payment of One Time Registration Fee; Current Account in State Bank of India; Integration of SBI Bank Account with IREPS Account; Lien Marking of Funds; Updation of Turnover Details.
- A new mechanism namely Virtual Account Number (VAN) has been introduced now for E-Auction Leasing module, which can be used by the bidders as an alternative to Lien Marking Mechanism.
- The bidders are free to switch between Lien Marking Mechanism (if activated) and VAN mechanism at any point of time, before entering the bidding room. VAN mechanism does not require the bidder to have a current account in State Bank of India. The users are free to transfer money from any of their existing bank accounts in any bank to their VAN account, which enables them to participate in IREPS E-Auctions.
- Contractors who do not have IREPS account for any module of IREPS can submit their online request for registration by clicking on New Vendors / Contractors (E-Tender /E-Auction Leasing) link on IREPS Home page.

Railway Authority to contact, in
Divisional Railway Manager's Office, Commercial Branch, State Entry Road, New Delhi 110055, Email: catering.delhidivision@gmail.com, Tel: 011-23743084.

No. 23 AC/Ctg./e-Auction/GMU & SMU/2026 Dated: 19.08.2026 2892/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

STATE BANK OF INDIA

Home Loan Centre (HLC) C-59
Community Centre, Naraina Industrial
Area Phase - 1, New Delhi-110028

DEMAND
NOTICE

NOTICE UNDER SECTION 13(2) OF THE SECURITIZATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 (No. 3 of 2002).

A notice is hereby given that the below mentioned Borrower/s have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest of the loans facility obtained by them from the Bank and the loans have been classified as Non - Performing Assets (NPA). The notices were issued to them under Section 13(2) of Securitization and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 on their last known addresses, but they have been returned unserved and as such they are hereby informed by way of this public notice.

DESCRIPTION OF HYPOTHECATION OF MOVABLE ASSETS				
Sl. No.	Name & Address of the Borrower	Description of the Property Mortgaged / Charged	Date of Demand Notice	Amount Outstanding (as on the date of notice)
1.	MRS. SEEMA ARORA W/O MR. SANJIV ARORA M-32, Gali No.2, Hari Nagar, Maya Puri, S.O., Delhi-110064. Car Loan A/c. No.: 43354091383 MRS. SEEMA ARORA W/O MR. SANJIV ARORA C/o Seema Enterprises, M-32, Hari Nagar, Maya Puri, S.O., Delhi-110064.	Make & Model: MARUTI FRONX DELTA + AGS Vehicle No.: DL 9CBF 9792 Engine No.: K12NP7471081 Chassis No.: MBHKWD13SRC243218	05/08/2026 Date of N.P.A. 16/07/2026	Rs.7,13,027/- (Rupees Seven Lakh Thirteen Thousand Twenty Seven Only) as on 05/08/2026 with further interest and incidental expenses, costs and charges etc. thereon

We invite your attention to the provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act which speaks about the time available to the borrower/guarantor to redeem the secured assets.

The steps are being taken for substituted service of notice. The above Borrower(s) and/or their Guarantor(s) (whenever applicable) are hereby called upon to make payment of outstanding amount within 60 days from the date of publication of this notice, failing which further steps will be taken after expiry of 60 days from the date of this notice under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

"This notice is without prejudice to the Bank's right to initiate such other actions or legal proceedings, as it deems necessary under any other applicable provisions of Law".

Date: 19.08.2026
Place: New Delhi

Sd/- Authorized Officer & (Chief Manager)
State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, Naraina New Delhi

STATE BANK OF INDIA

HOME LOAN CENTRE-1, NOIDA (14702) C -03B, SECTOR-55,
DISTRICT - GAUTAM BUDDH NAGAR, U.P., NOIDA-201301

SALE NOTICE
Appendix - IV-A

NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY ON 25.09.2026

Appendix - IV-A [See Proviso to Rule 8(6)]
E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described movable property hypothecated /charged to the Secured Creditor, the Physical Possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer State Bank of India, the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is Where is", "As is What is" and Whatever there is" on 25.09.2026, for recovery of below mentioned amounts due to the secured creditor from the below mentioned Borrowers.

Date / Time Of E-auction On 25.09.2026 From 11:00 AM To 04:00 PM With Unlimited Extn. of 10 Minutes Each

S. No.	Name of Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s)	Total Dues	Reserve Price EMD		Details of Immovable Property	Name of the Contact Person for Site Visit
			Bid Increment Amount			
1.	MR. GAURAV AGRAWAL S/O SH. PRABHU DAYAL AGRAWAL Flat No. L-302, Stellar Jeevan, Plot GH-03, Sector-1, P.O: Birsakh, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh – 201306	Rs.13,64,764/- Plus Future interest at the contractual rate with effect from 08.10.2025 and said amount together with incidental expenses, costs, charges etc.	Rs.84,99,000.00	Rs.8,50,000.00 Rs.1,00,000.00	Property Bearing Flat No.L-302, Stellar Jeevan, Plot - GH-03, Sector-1, P.O.: Birsakh, Greater Noida-201306, Uttar Pradesh.	Mr. Chandra Bhusan Dubey (Resolution Agent) Mobile: 9289074371

Date and Time of Inspection is 24th September 2026 of the Immovable secured assets to be sold and intending bidders should satisfy themselves about the Assets and their specification. Last Date of EMD Deposit: 24.09.2026 upto 4:00 P.M.

Account/ Wallet in which EMD to be remitted : Bidder's own wallet Registered with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT/RETS. EMD of Reserve Price to be transferred by bidders by means of challan generated on his/her/his bidder account maintained with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT from his /her/his bank. For any assistance, please call please call BAANKNET HELPDESH: +91 8291220220, support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com and/or Authorized Officer. For official enquiry please contact: Ms. Amrita Sengupta Mobile: 8527931765 and Mr. Satish Singh, Mobile: 9953842577.

TERMS AND CONDITIONS OF THE E-AUCTION ARE AS UNDER:

- E-Auction is being held on "As is where is", "as is what is basis" and "whatever there is basis" and will be conducted "On Line". The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider BAANKNET at their web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing>
- Interested bidder may deposit Pre-Bid EMD with BAANKNET before the close of e-Auction. Credit of Pre-Bid EMD shall be given to the bidder only after receipt of payment in BAANKNET's Bank Account and up-dation of such information in the e-auction website. This may take some time as per banking and hence bidders, in their own interest, are advised to submitted the pre-bid EMD amount well in advance to avoid any last minute problem.
- To the best of knowledge and information of Authorized Officer there is no encumbrance on the property/ies. However the intending bidder should make their own independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of the property/ies put on auction and claims/rights/dues/affecting the property prior to submitting their bid. The e-Auction Advertisement does not constitute any commitment or any representation of the Bank. The property is being sold with all the existing and future encumbrances whether known or unknown to the bank. The Authorized Officer shall not be responsible in any way for any third party claims/rights/dues.
- The Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of the successful bidder shall be retained towards part sale consideration and the EMD of the unsuccessful bidders shall be refunded. The Earnest Money Deposit shall not bear any interest. The successful bidder shall have to deposit 25% of the sale price, immediately on acceptance of bid price by the Authorized Officer and the balance of the sale price on or before 15th day of the sale. Default in deposit of amount by the successful bidder would entail forfeiture of the whole money already deposited and property shall be put to the e-auction and the defaulting bidder shall have no claim/right in respect of property / amount.
- For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link at the Bank's Service Provider's web portal: <https://BAANKNET.com> and State Bank of India, the secured Creditor website: www.sbi.bank.in

Date: 19.08.2026
Place: NOIDA

Sd/- Authorized Officer, State Bank of India,
Home Loan Centre-1, (14702) Sector-55, Noida

Camilla opens up about King Charles cancer diagnosis



ADITI KHANNA ■ London

Britain's Queen Camilla on Wednesday opened up about her feelings around her husband King Charles III's cancer over two years ago, saying she was "longing to let out" the news of the "difficult" diagnosis. Charles, 77, revealed on February 5, 2024, that he was being treated for an undisclosed form of cancer and has since shared important milestones in his treatment journey.

His wife has now revealed that the family knew about the diagnosis days before the monarch chose to go public with the news, in a break from royal tradition around health-related matters being treated as private.

"I remember coming to see a Maggie's just after the King being diagnosed. Nobody could say anything at the time. That was quite difficult," Camilla told Dame Laura Lee, CEO of Maggie's cancer charity, in a video released by Buckingham Palace.

The Queen filmed the conversation with Lee at her Clarence House residence to mark the 30th anniversary of the cancer support charity, a unit of which she opened at the Royal Free Hospital in London in 2024 as its president. "I almost said something [at the time] but, you know, I felt that it wasn't the time to say. I looked at everybody who was suffering, and all the relations and I think it made me realise even more how important these places were. I was just longing to let it out but obviously I couldn't," she shared.

The 79-year-old senior royal said that unlike her other visits to such health-care centres, she felt it was "much more deep" during that particular opening.

On the King's decision to resume public-facing royal duties just months after the diagnosis in April 2024, Camilla said: "Look at my husband. Nothing stopped him. He just said, 'This is my way. I'm going to cope with it,'" she said.

"It had never really come back to roost at home, and suddenly your husband is diagnosed, and you think 'Goodness I've been talking to all these people and now I'm the one with some relation, who's got to help to look after my poor husband and try and understand it all,'" Queen Camilla said.

The seven-minute film has been released to highlight the support Maggie's offers cancer patients, and to promote the services they provide for relatives. The charity has 27 centres across the UK, built in the grounds of major National Health Service (NHS) cancer hospitals, and the Queen has called on every hospital to have a Maggie's centre.

While the palace has not disclosed the type of cancer the King has, the monarch has engaged widely with those treating and supporting cancer patients in the country.

Maggie's says Charles' public announcement prompted a 12 per cent increase in men contacting them with a cancer diagnosis. "The King's openness about his diagnosis has undoubtedly helped others to be more open themselves, and to now hear the Queen's completely understandable and natural response as a wife shines a light on why it is so important that family and friends also get the support they need," said Lee.

More than two years later, the King continues with his cancer treatment, with Buckingham Palace saying his health is moving in a "positive direction".

United Arab Emirates suspends trade with Iran

DAVID RISING ■ Dubai

The United Arab Emirates suspended all trade with Iran on Wednesday after it said it had come under renewed fire from the country - a move that will further isolate the Islamic Republic, which is suffering under US sanctions and a blockade.

Incoming ballistic missile fire triggered nationwide warnings Tuesday night for UAE residents to seek shelter, the first time in weeks such an alarm had sounded.

Early in the conflict, the UAE regularly came under intense fire from Iran, and most trade between the countries, which had once been important trading partners, ground to a halt. In late June, as hostilities eased, some maritime trade resumed, Iran's state-run IRNA news agency reported.

More time and data are needed to evaluate the full



effect of the war on Iran-UAE trade, but the UAE is clearly a critical partner for Iran, said Mohammad Farzanegan, a professor of Middle Eastern economics at

Germany's University of Marburg.

Beyond the trade in domestically produced goods, "the UAE has been very important for Iran as a

re-export hub and has helped the country absorb some of the shocks caused by sanctions," he said.

"Iran therefore depends heavily on the UAE not

because the UAE itself produces one-third of Iran's imports, but because it serves as a major gateway for Iran to access third-country goods and commercial infrastructure." Following the news that two ballistic missiles had been fired toward the UAE, both of which splashed down in the Persian Gulf late Tuesday, the Foreign Ministry said that while it remained committed to "dialogue, cooperation and regional integration," it had decided to impose the punitive measures.

"In light of regional escalations that undermine regional and international peace and security, all trade, commercial exchanges and financial transactions with Iran have been halted until further notice," the ministry said in a statement.

The UAE's Defence Ministry said assessments showed that the missiles targeted

maritime traffic. It was not clear whether they targeted Emirati ships or the country's territorial waters.

Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei denied that Iran had launched any missiles toward the UAE.

As part of Iran's efforts to maintain a stranglehold over the Strait of Hormuz, it has regularly attacked ships attempting to use the waterway, including four tankers owned by Abu Dhabi's state-owned ADNOC oil and gas company over the past two weeks. None of the attacks caused injuries, but they brought harsh condemnation from the UAE and others, including Kuwait and Bahrain.

Since the beginning of the conflict, nearly 20 ADNOC vessels have been attacked by missiles and drones in the Strait of Hormuz, killing one person and wounding another 20. (AP)

Members of banned outfit arrested in Pakistan's Sindh



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Karachi

Three men belonging to banned separatist group Sindhudesh Revolutionary Army were arrested in Pakistan's Sindh province for killing a civilian during Independence Day celebrations, police said. According to the Counter Terrorism Department (CTD), the incident occurred on August 12 in Karachi, the capital city of Sindh, when three men opened fire at an Independence Day stall.

"A stall selling national flags and badges was fired at in Defence Housing Authority Phase 2 near Sunset Boulevard at around 11:30 pm," the CTD said in a statement on Tuesday. It said that the stall owner was seriously wounded

in the incident and later succumbed to his injuries.

The individuals involved in the attack were arrested in a joint operation conducted with the federal intelligence agency near Korangi Causeway in the port city, it said. The statement added that the arrested individuals confessed to being tasked with targeting Independence Day stalls in Karachi.

The accused persons received directions from a member of the Sindhudesh Revolutionary Army (SRA) residing outside Pakistan, identified as Arsalan Shah, the statement said. The interior ministry had banned the SRA in 2020, along with Jeay Sindh Qaumi Mahaz-Aresar Group and Sindhudesh Liberation Army under the Anti-Terrorism Act.

Israel probes killing of Hind Rajab, Palestinian Paramedics



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Jerusalem

Israel's military on Wednesday announced its first criminal investigations into troop conduct in the war in Gaza, focusing on the killings of 5-year-old Hind Rajab and her family and of 15 Palestinian paramedics.

The military said it would not launch criminal investigations into three other attacks that killed aid workers from World Central Kitchen and Doctors Without Borders. Its statement said it had completed reviews of 150 incidents of troop conduct in Gaza and made decisions on the five cases.

The military statement did not mention the many other high-profile killings that Israel has pledged to investigate throughout the war. It did not mention the Israeli strikes on a hospital in southern Gaza that killed five journalists in August 2025, including Mariam Dagga, a visual journalist who freelanced for the AP and other news organisations.

Both the killing of Rajab and her family, trapped in a vehicle and pleading for help by phone in February 2024, and the killing of 15 medics in May 2025 drew international outcry. Rajab's grandmother, also named Hind Rajab, told The Associated Press by phone that the Israeli inves-

tigation is not enough, and called for an international probe into the killing of her granddaughter and all of the hundreds of children killed in Gaza during the war. "An international investigation is required to uncover the truth and hold all those responsible accountable," she said. "We call for justice, not only for Hind, but for all Gaza children."

The military's statement comes nearly three years after the war began. Israeli strikes continue in Gaza despite a fragile ceasefire. The military admitted to firing at the family car carrying Rajab, four of her cousins and her aunt and uncle as they fled an Israeli invasion of Gaza City. As gunfire sprayed around them, Rajab's cousin, 15-year-old Layan Hamada, called the Palestinian Red Crescent paramedic centre, telling them that a tank was approaching and her family had been killed. Seconds later, more gunshots were heard, and Layan's screaming stopped, according to the Red Crescent recording of the call.

Palestinian paramedics dispatched an ambulance to rescue Rajab, the sole survivor, and stayed on the line until contact was lost. Rajab, her five relatives and two medics from the ambulance were found dead 12 days later.

India to build hospital in Palestine, says Ambassador Abu Shawesh

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

India and Palestine have finalised the paperwork for the construction of a new hospital in the West Bank, with the project expected to move into implementation soon, the Ambassador of Palestine to India Abdullah M Abu Shawesh said in an interview with The Pioneer.

Speaking about the outcome of a recent visit by Indian diplomat S. Ranganathan, Secretary (CPV & OIA) in the Ministry of External Affairs, the ambassador described the development as significant at a time when Palestine's healthcare system is facing severe pressure.

"The health sector in Palestine is on the brink of collapse," the ambassador said, adding that India had been approached for assistance, particularly in the health and education sectors. According to the envoy, the paperwork for the hospital was finalised between India and Palestine a day before the interview.

He expressed confidence that construction would begin soon, stressing that the project was moving beyond discussions and towards practical implementation.

The ambassador clarified that the hospital would be fully funded by the government, with no private ownership involved. India to Support Artificial Limbs for Gaza. The ambassador also



Ambassador of Palestine to India Abdullah M Abu Shawesh

highlighted India's potential assistance to Palestinians who have lost limbs during the conflict in Gaza. He said he had already discussed the issue of artificial limbs with India's External Affairs Minister and his Indian counterpart.

According to initial statistics cited by the ambassador, more than 5,000 people in Gaza have undergone amputations and require artificial limbs and other forms of assistance.

"India's position is very clear. In principle, India is ready to implement this project," he said, while stressing that the assistance would need to reach Gaza, where the requirement exists. The ambassador said he expected India to support Palestine in Gaza after the war and expressed confidence that the country would stand with Palestinians in reconstruction efforts. Medicines and Medical Equipment

establishment of a vocational training centre, which he hoped would begin soon and benefit Palestinians.

The ambassador linked these initiatives to the broader challenges facing Palestine's education and health sectors, both of which he described as being under enormous strain.

While discussing assistance from India, the ambassador also emphasised that the relationship could involve cooperation in which Palestine shares its own expertise with India.

The ambassador's remarks place the proposed West Bank hospital at the centre of a wider Indian effort to support Palestine's healthcare and humanitarian needs. Alongside the Government-funded hospital, the proposed artificial-limb assistance for Gaza, medical supplies and equipment, and the planned vocational training centre represent areas in which the ambassador said India could make a practical contribution.

For Palestine, the focus is on turning diplomatic support into projects on the ground at a time when the country's health and education systems are facing extraordinary challenges. The ambassador expressed hope that India's assistance would continue and expand, particularly in Gaza, where the need for medical and rehabilitation support remains acute.

Israeli strike hits Syria base after Turkish delegation visit



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Damascus

A Turkish delegation had visited an air base in northern Syria the day before it was hit by Israeli airstrikes, Syrian officials said.

The Israeli strikes hit the Abu Duhur base early Tuesday, hours after the delegation had left, causing damage but no casualties.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's office said in a statement that Israel had attacked the base because Syria was "on the verge of breaching" an agreed-upon "status quo in security matters" by allowing Turkish troops to deploy

there. Two Syrian officials who spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to comment publicly said the Turkish delegation had visited the air base in the northwestern province of Idlib on Monday to review rehabilitation work underway at the facility.

It was the first confirmation of a Turkish presence at the Abu Duhur base.

Turkish and Syrian officials have not publicly commented on Turkey's role there but have condemned the attack, as did Tom Barrack, the US ambassador to Turkey who also serves as special envoy to Syria, and a number of Arab countries.

FORM G

INVITATION FOR EXPRESSION OF INTEREST

M/S CREDITSAVVY TECHNOLOGIES PRIVATE LIMITED

Operating In software designing & development.

(Under Regulation 36A (1) of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (Insolvency Resolution Process for Corporate Persons) Regulations, 2016)

RELEVANT PARTICULARS

1. Name of the corporate debtor along with PAN/ CIN/ LLP No.

2. Address of the registered office

3. URL of website

4. Details of place where majority of fixed assets are located

5. Installed capacity of main products/ services

6. Quantity and value of main products/ services sold in last financial year

7. Number of employees/ workmen

8. Further details including last available financial statements (with schedules) of two years, lists of creditors, relevant dates for subsequent events of the process are available at:

9. Eligibility for resolution applicants under section 25(2)(h) of the Code is available at:

10. Last date for receipt of expression of interest:

11. Date of issue of provisional list of prospective resolution applicants:

12. Last date for submission of objections to provisional list:

13. Date of issue of final list of prospective resolution applicants:

14. Date of issue of information memorandum, evaluation matrix and request for resolution plans to prospective resolution applicants:

15. Last date for submission of resolution plans:

16. Process email id to submit EOI

17. Details of the corporate debtor's registration status as MSME

M/S CREDITSAVVY TECHNOLOGIES PRIVATE LIMITED

CIN: U62099UP2023PTC184092

As per the details available on the MCA Master Data Office No-2414, The Corentium, Sector 62, Noida Gautam Buddha Nagar, Noida Uttar Pradesh, India, 201301

www.digisarkaar.ai

NA

The CD operates a recharge and bill payment API aggregation business. The products & services of the CD are as follows: • Mobile prepaid recharge (all major telecom operators) • DTH/Direct-to-Home recharge (multiple DTH providers) • Utility bill payments (electricity, gas, water, broadband, etc.) • API integration and technical support for client onboarding • Real-time transaction reconciliation, reporting, and dashboard access • Waallet/floating management for both vendor and client sides

Rs. 3,73,32,87,284.60 (As per the last audited Financial Statement of the Corporate Debtor of Financial Year 2024-25)

NIL (The CD is non-operative)

Detail can be sought by emailing to: crip.creditsavvy@gmail.com

Detail can be sought by emailing to: crip.creditsavvy@gmail.com

09.09.2026

19.09.2026

24.09.2026

04.10.2026

09.10.2026

16.11.2026

crip.creditsavvy@gmail.com

Registration Number: UDYAM-JP-28-0076090

Classification Year: 2023-24

Enterprise Type: Micro

Classification Date: 26/06/2023

Sd/- (Bhavna Bansal)

IBBI Reg. No. IBBI/IPA-001/IP-P-02716/2022-2023/14150

Resolution Professional for M/s Creditsavvy Technologies Private Limited

Address: E-9/23, LGF, Vasant Vihar, New Delhi-110057.

E-mail Id: bhavnabansal@yahoo.com

Date: 20.08.2026

Case Specific Email Id: crip.creditsavvy@gmail.com

Place: New Delhi

Mobile No: +91-9212016744

Arcil

Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Ltd. (Arcil)

Acting in its capacity as Trustee of various Arcil Trusts

Arcil office: The Ruby, 10th floor, 29, Senapati Bapat Marg, Dadar (West) Mumbai-400 028

Website: <https://XpertAuction.com>; CIN-U65999MH2002PLC134884

PUBLIC NOTICE FOR SALE THROUGH ONLINE E-AUCTION IN EXERCISE OF THE POWERS UNDER THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 (SARFAESI ACT) READ WITH RULES 6, 8 & 9 OF SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and to the Borrower (s) / Guarantor (s) / Mortgagee (s), in particular, that the below described immovable properties mortgaged/charged to the Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Limited, acting in its capacity as Trustee of various Arcil Trusts ("ARCIL") (pursuant to the assignment of financial asset vide registered Assignment Agreements), will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is", "Whatever there is" and "Without recourse basis" by way of online e-auction, for recovery of outstanding dues of together with further interest, charges and costs etc., as detailed below in terms of the provisions of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 ("Act") read with Rules 6, 8 and 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 ("Rules").

Name of the Borrower / Co-Borrowers / Guarantor/s / Mortgagee/s	LAN No. & Selling Bank	Trust Name	Outstanding amount as per SARFAESI Notice dated 19/Jul/2023	Possession type and date	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)
				Date of Inspection	Reserve Price
				Type of Property and Area	Date & Time of E-Auction
Borrower: Mahender Partap Chauhan Co-Borrower: Priti Chauhan Guarantor : Moolchand Chauhan	HL0000000029359 Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Limited (VHFC)	Arcil-Trust-2025-018	Rs. 52,49,113/- as on 13/Jul/2023 + further Interest thereon + Legal Expenses.	Physical on 26/Oct/2023 Will be arranged on request admeasuring area measuring 185.2 sq. yds. i.e. 154.84 sq mtr.	Rs. 810000/- (Rupees Eight Lakh Ten Thousand only) Rs. 8100000/- (Rupees Eighty One Lakh only) 21-09-2026 at 11:00 AM

Description of the Secured Asset being auctioned:

House No 459 admeasuring area measuring 185.2 sq. yds. i.e. 154.84 sq mtr. Out of Khaska No. 159, Khata No 00060, situated in Villahae Sarfabad, Tehsil Dadar/ Gautam Buddh Nagar, Noida, Uttar Pradesh- 201002 On East Side: * Plot of Mahavir On West Side: * Road 12 Foot On North Side: * Plot of Nathu On South Side: * Gali 4 Foot

Pending Litigations known to ARCIL	Nil	Encumbrances/Dues known to ARCIL	Nil
Last Date for submission of Bid	Same day 2 hours before Auction	Bid Increment amount:	As mentioned in the Bid document

Demand Draft to be made in name of:	Arcil-Trust-2025-018	Payable at Par
RTGS details	Arcil-Trust-2025-018, Trust Account No: 57500001745590, HDFC Bank Limited, Branch: Kamla Mill Extn Ctr, Mumbai, IFSC Code: HDFC0000542	
Name of Contact person & number	Arpit Choudhary arpit.choudhary@vastuhfc.com; 73573 75589, Santosh Tiwari - 99204 90126, Shekhar Sharma - 86557 96116, Navneet Singh - 99991 05933	

Terms and Conditions:

1. The Auction Sale is being conducted through e-auction through the website <https://XpertAuction.com> and as per the Terms and Conditions of the Bid Document, and as per the procedure set out therein.
2. The Authorised Officer ("AO") ARCIL shall not be held responsible for internet connectivity, network problems, system crash down, power failure etc.
3. At any stage of the auction, the AO may accept/reject/modify/cancel the bid/offered or post-pone the Auction without assigning any reason thereof and without any prior notice.
4. The successful purchaser/bidder shall bear any statutory dues, taxes, fees payable, applicable GST on the purchase consideration, stamp duty, registration fees, etc. that is required to be paid in order to get the secured asset conveyed/delivered in his/her/favour as per the applicable law.
5. The intending bidders should make their own independent enquiries/ due diligence regarding encumbrances, title of secured asset and claims/rights/dues affecting the secured assets, including statutory dues, etc., prior to submitting their bid. The auction advertisement does not constitute and will not constitute any commitment or any representation of ARCIL. The Authorized Officer of ARCIL shall not be responsible in any way for any third-party claims/rights/dues.
6. The particulars specified in the auction notice published in the newspaper have been stated to the best of the information of the undersigned, however undersigned shall not be responsible /liable for any error, misstatement or omission.
7. The Borrower/ Guarantors/ Mortgagees, who are liable for the said outstanding dues, shall treat this Sale Notice as a notice under Rules 8 and 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, about the holding of the above mentioned auction sale.
8. In the event, the auction scheduled hereinabove fails for any reason whatsoever, ARCIL has the right to sell the secured asset by any other methods under the provisions of Rule 8(5) of the Rules and the Act.

Place: Noida

Date: 20.08.2026

Sd/-

Authorized Officer

Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Ltd.

Arcil

Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Ltd. (Arcil)

Acting in its capacity as Trustee of various Arcil Trusts

Arcil office: The Ruby, 10th floor, 29, Senapati Bapat Marg, Dadar (West) Mumbai-400 028

Website: <https://XpertAuction.com>; CIN-U65999MH2002PLC134884

PUBLIC NOTICE FOR SALE THROUGH ONLINE E-AUCTION IN EXERCISE OF THE POWERS UNDER THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 (SARFAESI ACT) READ WITH RULES 6, 8 & 9 OF SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002

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Name of the Borrower / Co-Borrowers / Guarantor/s / Mortgagee/s	LAN No. & Selling Bank	Trust Name	Outstanding amount as per SARFAESI Notice dated 19/Apr/2022	Possession type and date	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)
				Date of Inspection	Reserve Price
				Type of Property and Area	Date & Time of E-Auction
Borrower: Sanjay Yadav Co-Borrower: Babita Devi	HL0000000029242 LP0000000046118 Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Limited (VHFC)	Arcil-Trust-2025-018	Rs. 4,55,48,80.94/- & Rs. 5,37,45,81/- as on 5/Apr/2022 + further Interest thereon + Legal Expenses.	Physical on 30/Nov/2022 Will be arranged on request area measuring 100 sq. yds	Rs. 387800/- (Rupees Three Lakh Eighty Seven Thousand Eight Hundred only) Rs. 3878000/- (Rupees Thirty Eight Lakh Seventy Eight Thousand only) 28-09-2026 at 11:00 AM

Description of the Secured Asset being auctioned:

Built up property bearing no. Rz-d/14, old plot no. 12, area measuring 100 sq. yds., out of khaska no. 76/4, Situated in the revenue Estate of east village palam, colony known as Mahavir Enclave, New Delhi Boundaries as follows: North - Road 20ft South - Plot No.RZ-11 East - Gali 20 Ft West - Other's Property

Pending Litigations known to ARCIL	Nil	Encumbrances/Dues known to ARCIL	Nil
Last Date for submission of Bid	Same day 2 hours before Auction	Bid Increment amount:	As mentioned in the Bid document

Demand Draft to be made in name of:	Arcil-Trust-2025-018	Payable at Par
RTGS details	Arcil-Trust-2025-018, Trust Account No: 57500001745590, HDFC Bank Limited, Branch: Kamla Mill Extn Ctr, Mumbai, IFSC Code: HDFC0000542	
Name of Contact person & number	Arpit Choudhary arpit.choudhary@vastuhfc.com; 73573 75589, Santosh Tiwari - 99204 90126, Shekhar Sharma - 86557 96116, Navneet Singh - 99991 05933	

Terms and Conditions:

1. The Auction Sale is being conducted through e-auction through the website <https://XpertAuction.com> and as per the Terms and Conditions of the Bid Document, and as per the procedure set out therein.
2. The Authorised Officer ("AO") ARCIL shall not be held responsible for internet connectivity, network problems, system crash down, power failure etc.
3. At any stage of the auction, the AO may accept/reject/modify/cancel the bid/offered or post-pone the Auction without assigning any reason thereof and without any prior notice.
4. The successful purchaser/bidder shall bear any statutory dues, taxes, fees payable, applicable GST on the purchase consideration, stamp duty, registration fees, etc. that is required to be paid in order to get the secured asset conveyed/delivered in his/her/favour as per the applicable law.
5. The intending bidders should make their own independent enquiries/ due diligence regarding encumbrances, title of secured asset and claims/rights/dues affecting the secured assets, including statutory dues, etc., prior to submitting their bid. The auction advertisement does not constitute and will not constitute any commitment or any representation of ARCIL. The Authorized Officer of ARCIL shall not be responsible in any way for any third-party claims/rights/dues.
6. The particulars specified in the auction notice published in the newspaper have been stated to the best of the information of the undersigned, however undersigned shall not be responsible /liable for any error, misstatement or omission.
7. The Borrower/ Guarantors/ Mortgagees, who are liable for the said outstanding dues, shall treat this Sale Notice as a notice under Rules 8 and 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, about the holding of the above mentioned auction sale.
8. In the event, the auction scheduled hereinabove fails for any reason whatsoever, ARCIL has the right to sell the secured asset by any other methods under the provisions of Rule 8(5) of the Rules and the Act.

Place: New Delhi

Date: 20.08.2026

Sd/-

Authorized Officer

Asset Reconstruction Company (India) Ltd.

PROSPECT

Galgotias University shines in Times BBA Education Ranking 2026



Around 95% of power consumers in Delhi pay electricity bills digitally, says discoms

India's coconut sector powers rural livelihoods, exports

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

tem of value-added industries. In India, coconut cultivation has a well-documented history spanning nearly three millennia and remains a critical driver of rural employment and economic resilience.

About 30 million people, including 10 million farmers, depend on the coconut sector, making it vital to rural livelihoods. Predominantly cultivated by small and marginal farmers, coconut aligns closely with inclusive growth and the strengthening of farm-based economies.

One such example of its growing significance can be seen in Chhattisgarh, where farmers have begun adopting

Assam NCC programme promotes national security

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Guwahati

A group of police officers in khaki uniforms are standing in formation in front of a building. Some officers are wearing red berets, while others are wearing white caps. They are standing in a line, facing the camera. The building in the background has a sign that reads "POLICE" and "CHANDIGARH". There are trees and a fence in the background.

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

people have to visit government offices, they should be able to get their issues resolved readily.

"We are working with a holistic approach to develop district commissioner offices in all 35 districts as people-centric ventures to deliver services promptly," he said.

Referring to PM Modi's call for "minimum government, maximum governance," Sharma said that soon after becoming chief minister in 2021, he had commissioned a study to ascertain how many people visited the state secretariat and the reasons for their visits. The study found that around 5,000 to 6,000 people visited Janata Bhawan daily, he said.

Hazarika reviews agriculture, irrigation schemes in Diphu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Guwahati

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

SOLUTION (19.8.26)

No SS2220 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
THURSDAY | AUGUST 20, 2026

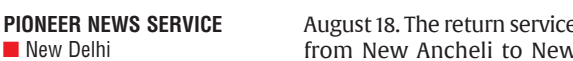
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SOLUTION (19.8.26)

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 18 Wrongly blamed for not having hurried
 20 Stick to good quality glass (5)
 21 It's driven on many a second-class road
 22 No rousing start is negative (3)
 23 A soldier in a foreign city can be French
 25 You won't find hers in the British Isles
 28 Choose to take some of the leaders to
 court (5)
 30 Badger, nominally (5)
 31 On yours, certainly not! (5)
 32 Departed after a time (4)
 33 Can they make a captain more seedy
 than a subaltern? (4)

DFCCIL starts JPP-RCS on Western Dedicated Freight Corridor



August 18. The return service from New Ancheli to New Dadri will commence on August 20, with the service operating daily.

The service is designed to cater to e-commerce, FMCG, retail cargo, courier and logistics aggregators, transporters and other bulk parcel customers.

The service will cover approximately 1,200 km one way, connecting major logistics and industrial centres across the northern and western regions of the country. New Motidau will serve as an intermediate loading and unloading point, providing greater flexibility for parcel operators and customers. The service will operate as a scheduled end-to-end service with a composition of 15 LVPH and one SLR, with a scheduled transit time of approximately 23 hours.

The JPP-RCS brings together the strengths of the Dedicated Freight Corridor and the Indian Railways JPP-RCS framework, and it is being patronised by Amazon and Harsh Logistics and is based on indents placed through the FBD portal, alongside other major e-commerce and supply chain partners.

Renovated Central Bank of India premises opened

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

emphasised that a good infrastructure and positive ambience at the workplace enhance efficiency, productivity and learning. Therefore, we should strive to make our workplace a happy, positive and inspiring place to work and learn, where employees feel motivated and customers experience a welcoming environment.

The event marked an important milestone in strengthening the bank's presence and enhancing customer service in the region.

Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar
Advertisement No.12/2026

Online applications are invited for Non-Teaching post in the University. Online registration of application for the post will start w.e.f. **20-08-2026** and end on **11-09-2026**. Last date for submitting Hard Copy of the Online submitted application is **21-09-2026**. For further details visit University Website: <https://digital.gndu.ac.in>.
Amritsar **Registrar**
19-08-2026
2426/12/2026-27/14421 Dated CHD :- 19/08/2026

कार्यालय नगर निगम, देहरादून

नगर निगम, देहरादून में विभिन्न पदों पर कार्मिक उपलब्ध कराने के लिए फर्म का चयन हेतु **GeM Portal** पर निविदा आमंत्रित की जानी है तथा निविदा से सम्बन्धित समस्त विवरण **GeM Portal** से प्राप्त किये जा सकते हैं।

क्रम संख्या	कार्य का विवरण
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Khera Khurampur, PO:
Farrukh Nagar, Gurugram,
Haryana 122506 have
changed my name as Ruby.

Suthar's 10-wicket haul powers India to 165-run win over Sri Lanka

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Galle

The exceptionally gifted Manav Suthar gave India temporary deliverance from their red-ball turmoil, leading the 165-run dismantling of Sri Lanka in the first Test with a match haul of 10 wickets on the fifth and final day here on Wednesday.

The visitors now lead the two-match series 1-0 and it became all the more special as it was India's 600th Test match.

Once Suthar got his 10th scalp of Test, Shubman Gill must have heaved a sigh of relief as there was a heavy downpour within five minutes after the end of the game.

This victory at a tradition-

ally spin-ruled venue like Galle will give India oodles of confidence after their struggles against New Zealand and South Africa at home on rather similar pitches.

Starting the final day from 84 for four needing a further 288 to cross an improbable line, Sri Lanka delayed the inevitable for a session and a bit but eventually folded for 206, succumbing to the guiles of the young Indian left-arm spinner.

Suthar (6/55) ran through the Lankan late order in a destructive spell, and it was his second successive fifer after achieving the feat in his maiden Test against Afghanistan recently. This was after a four wicket haul in the first innings.

The home side started the

post-lunch session at 175 for six, and managed to reach 199 without further loss.

But Suthar's reintroduction changed the course of the game as the left-arm spinner jettisoned Sonal Dinusha (84), Prabath Jayasuriya and Lahiru Kumara in the space of six balls in the 76th over, reducing SL to 199 for nine.

Suthar, who generated ample turn and bounce, fittingly applied the coup de grace on the proceedings, casting Keshara Nuwantha.

However, India had to wait a tad longer than expected to reach the destination victory.

It was primarily because of a stonewalling alliance between Dinusha and skipper Dhananjaya de Silva. Dinusha and De Silva (59 off



151 balls), the two overnight batters, added 95 runs off 202 balls to deny the Indians success for well over an hour

into the opening session of the day. Just like the Indian batters, sweep too was the Lankan pair's preferred way

to tackle the spinners. Jadeja looked easily the best Indian spinner on the day, putting his body behind the ball and getting a good amount of purchase from the surface.

Manav Suthar did not bowl too many overs but looked sharp but left-arm wrist spinner Kuldeep Yadav was quite flat, failing to get much out of an abrasive deck and he will surely want to improve upon this effort.

It was quite astounding to watch him go through the motions rather than trying to buy some assistance from the track. Operating from around the wicket also snuffed out the leg before option for him.

But amid the mighty push from other Indian bowlers, De Silva reached his fifty in

125 balls and a little later Dinusha, who made a 100 in the first innings, too joined his captain.

However, he brought up the landmark with more flourish, a slog-swept six off Kuldeep.

But Jadeja found a way past the defence of De Silva. The veteran left-arm spinner managed to eke out a bit more bounce and De Silva's top-edged sweep ended in the hands of Suthar at short fine leg.

Niroshan Dickwella, who played a sensible innings in Sri Lanka's first dig, appeared to be in a hurry to knock off the remaining runs.

There were a couple of desperate slog sweeps against Kuldeep and Jadeja

before eventually succumb-

ing to pacer Prasadh Krishna. Dickwella tried to manufacture a shot over covers while giving himself some room off Prasadh, but all he managed was a healthy edge to Rishabh Pant behind the stumps.

But Dinusha and Nuwantha managed to see off the next 30 minutes with pluck and luck, as Lankans hoped to fight till weather possibly turned hostile.

However, once Suthar came back to attack, the Lankan defence withered in a little over 30 minutes into the middle session, just a few minutes before skies opened up. The second Test will start at the Sinhalese Sports Club, Colombo, from August 23. (PTI)

Suthar bowled magnificently, will play for India for long time: Gill

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Galle



The "magnificent" Manav Suthar has already shown a lot of promise and will serve Indian cricket for a long time, skipper Shubman Gill said after the young left-arm spinner's 10-wicket match haul headlined his team's 165-run victory over Sri Lanka in the first Test.

Suthar, who took 6 for 55 in the second innings, finished with a match haul of 10 for 126. This was his second successive five-for in as many games.

"He has been bowling magnificently. Looks like a very promising guy and someone who can play for India for a long time," Gill said at the post-match presentation ceremony.

He was all praise for Devdutt Padikkal, who got the player of the match award for his knock of 167 in the first innings. Padikkal was drafted in as No. 3 after

Sai Sudharsan failed to recover from his big toe injury.

"He has magnificent to watch. Important to get hundreds but even after getting a hundred. He got a big one. Being in a competitive match and in a comfortable position...the way he batted and dominated in the second innings, was great to watch," Gill said.

The skipper was happy that the victory released a bit

of pressure even though India remain fifth in the World Test Championship with 53.33 percentage points. Australia (77.78), South Africa (75) and Bangladesh (66.67), fresh from their historic triumph over the Aussies, are placed ahead of India.

"That (WTC final) is the ultimate goal. Test wins do not come easy and this one is delightful," he said. Just after India won the game, the heavens opened up and the

team seemed relieved that the weather gods didn't play spoilsport.

"It is a very satisfying win for us. We were in a comfortable position, but were not sure if the match would go on (because of the weather), but the team responded well."

Gill wasn't really perturbed that India were bowled out for 193 in their second innings at Galle, in their bid to score quick runs.

"Not really (bothered). We wanted to get (a lead) around 400 in the third innings. Wicket was not easy to score runs at will, so were looking to play more aggressively. We were unsure as to how many overs we would be able to bowl on days four and five. In that process, we lost a few wickets but we were still in a comfortable position."

Padikkal, one of India's heroes, felt that negotiating Sri Lankan left-arm spinners wasn't a problem as there wasn't a lot of bite off the surface.

"It was a bit of a slowish wicket, was not providing a lot of bite, so left-handed batters were able to negate the left-arm spinners. In the end, it was all about who came out on top with their skillset," Padikkal said after being adjudged player of the match for his aggregate of 211 runs (167 and 44).

"The wicket had its natural wear and tear, was a good Test wicket. Turned a lot more from the third day onwards."

Sri Lanka skipper Dhananjaya de Silva was of the opinion that toss played a huge role as India opted to bat first and made best use of the conditions.

"They won the toss, get the runs on the board, and with our batting, we lost wickets and it went downhill from there. I thought from the second day onwards, we were in the game. Boys fought hard, even in the fourth innings. It is not easy (batting last in Galle)," De Silva said.

Knew big shower was coming, we had to push for result: KL Rahul

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Galle



India vice-captain KL Rahul said the visitors were determined to push for a result against Sri Lanka because they knew a big shower was coming, with the rain arriving just five minutes after their 165-run victory in Galle. Rahul, who scored 82 in India's first innings, said the team did not want to waste time by delaying the game.

Speaking to broadcaster SonyLiv, Rahul said the weather played a part in India's approach on the final day. "We knew one big shower was going to come and we didn't want to delay the game," Rahul said. "Just relieved honestly."

Sri Lanka had threatened to extend the contest with a big partnership, but India were confident that one breakthrough would open the door to more wickets.

"They had one big partnership but we knew if we could break that, we could get into their tail," he said. "It was a great Test match."

Rahul felt the Galle pitch remained good throughout the five days, offering something to both spinners and batters who were prepared to apply themselves.

"The wicket played really well all five days. There was something in it for the spinners, obviously," he said.

"But batters who applied themselves did well," Rahul added, highlighting Sonal's commitment to his sweep shot. The vice-captain also praised the fast bowlers and said India had kept the new ball in mind as another opportunity to take wickets. "Fast bowlers took wickets too," he said.

"We knew the new ball was going to come and if we couldn't get wickets, we knew the new ball was our chance."

Robinson storms back for England by ripping through Pakistan at Headingley

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Leeds (England)



Seamer Ollie Robinson made another dramatic return for England as he hammered the Pakistan top order on the first day of the test series on Wednesday at Headingley. Pakistan was collapsing at 150-7 at tea after an extended three-hour session due to the morning cut short by rain.

Robinson took out four of the top five batters - all bowled or unassisted - including a wicket with the first ball of the three-match series, a first in England, which has been hosting tests since 1880.

He had 4-39 from 16 overs in his first test since June at Lord's, where he took a match-winning 7-77 against New Zealand in his first test in two years. A knee injury and doubts about his fitness prevented his return in that series that England lost.

The other three wickets were grabbed by Josh Tongue, who broke Pakistan's biggest partnership then, right on tea, dismissed interim captain Salman Agha and Ali Usman in consecutive deliveries. Tea was immediately called, delaying Tongue's hat trick ball.

Featuring in a four-prong

pace attack, Robinson made a sensational start when he pinned Azan Awais first ball with a nip-backer from around the wicket. Then he went over the wicket and trapped Shan Masood trying to drive. Only 9.4 overs into the game, rain forced a delay of two hours.

Abdullah Shafiq and Imam, together from 6-2, endured a cautious return in the afternoon and gradually became comfortable enough to push the run rate.

But after 91 runs together, Imam drove at a wide ball by Tongue and nicked to second slip. Walking off with 42, Imam castized himself.

From 97-2, Pakistan lost five wickets for 53 runs.

After Shafique brought up his 13th fifty-plus score from 82 balls, Saud Shakeel was given out lbw to Robinson by umpire Allahuddien Paleker, who took his time. Shakeel also took his time to review the decision and was timed out by umpire Chris Gaffaney. Video showed the ball missing the top of leg stump.

Shafique departed soon after, for 61, bowled by Robinson, who by then had wicketkeeper Jamie Smith standing up to the stumps for added pressure. In the last five minutes before tea, Tongue bowled Agha and Usman and exposed Pakistan's tail with Moham mad Rizwan on 12.

Sinquefield Cup: Praggnanandhaa beats Vachier-Lagrave to rise to joint lead

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ St Louis (USA)



Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa outplayed Maxime Vachier-Lagrave of France to jump to joint lead alongside American Wesley So after the end of the eighth and penultimate round of the Sinquefield Cup here.

The victory took Praggnanandhaa to five points out of a possible eight and the Indian is now assured of a place in the Grand finale scheduled later this year.

On a day when Wesley played another draw with compatriot Sevan Samuels, Javokhir Sindarov won his

third game on the trot to be within striking distance of the leaders on 4.5 points. On the receiving end was Jordan van Foreest of Holland who continues to trail the field. In another big result of

the day, German Vincent Keymer put it across top seed Fabiano Caruana of the United States to join Sindarov in third spot. In other game of the day, Dutchman Anish Giri drew with Levon Aronian

of the United States.

Being his last white game of the day, Maxime Vachier-Lagrave took all the risks against Praggnanandhaa but the tactic boomeranged. The Ruy Lopez was met with another Moller variation by Pragg and an early piece sacrifice by the Frenchman was only optically good.

Praggnanandhaa lost three pawns in exchange for the piece but relocated his forces well to win in just 28 moves.

Vincent Keymer played his own brand of chess to outwit Caruana with white pieces. It was an irregular queen pawn game wherein the players reached a dynamic mid-

dlegame wherein Keymer's tactical skills proved superior on this day. As it happened the German knocked down a couple of pawns before forcing resignation in 76 moves.

After an indifferent start world championship contender Sindarov seems to be have gotten in the groove when it matters the most. The Uzbek was at his best in a technical endgame arising out of a Petrosian variation of the Queen's Indian defense.

After an early pawn sacrifice, Sindarov won a rook for a minor piece and then kept pushing till Foreest could no longer sustain.

Tanisha and Dhruv grow together in mixed doubles

AMIT KUMAR DAS ■ New Delhi



Dhruv Kapila's favourite match-day drink is matcha. Tanisha Crasto's verdict on it is brutally simple: "It tastes like grass." They may disagree on what belongs in a cup, but on badminton court the Indian mixed doubles pair have spent the last two years learning precisely where each of them belongs.

"Last two years has been good. The first year we were progressing, like what we have to do and how we need to achieve. But since last year we learnt a lot and this year it's going well now," Dhruv, who alongwith Tanisha reached the semifinals at Singapore Super 750, said to a PTI query. "There are days when we are not at the best but still we

are trying to figure it out. How do we have to become more stable and keep performing well in the matches."

On Wednesday, the duo, who had finished at the quarterfinal stage at the 2025 World Championships, advanced to the pre-quarterfinals with a commanding 21-11 21-11 win over Macau's Leong Lok Chong and Ng Weng Chi.

It was another step forward for a partnership that has steadily developed since the pair came together, primarily after the Paris Olympics.

They were playing with different partners. Dhruv had previously partnered MR Arjun, while Tanisha qualified for the Paris Olympics with veteran Ashwini Ponnappa. Tanisha's territory is the front court, where she is expected to move forward, attack and create opportunities.

Dhruv takes responsibility for the space behind her, covering the court and creating the time and room for his partner to do her job. The arrival of Malaysian doubles coach Tan Kim Her back in Indian setup brought a huge change to their game. (PTI)

Iyer promises massive talent hunt as India eye rich medal haul in 2036 Olympics

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi



With the country's ambitious target of winning 30-40 medals at the 2036 Olympics putting the spotlight on the need for a robust talent pipeline, Indian Olympic Association CEO Raghuram Iyer on Wednesday said a massive nationwide hunt will be undertaken to identify and nurture athletes from a young age.

Former Asian Games gold medalist Ronjan Sodhi recently sounded a note of caution, saying India was running short of time to identify potential medalists for the 2036

Games and needed to urgently address gaps in infrastructure, facilities and talent scouting.

"Absolutely, I think he (Ronjan Sodhi) is right. There will be a massive talent hunt across all districts of India, targeting the 5 to 15 years age category, because those are the people who will be competing in 2036. That process has already begun," Iyer told PTI here on Wednesday.

"The Sports Authority of India is actively working on this (formulating the plans) along with the National Sports Federations (NSFs). IOA will ensure the NSFs have the

necessary support. There are various other aspects of developing an athlete, which is where the IOA's role comes into play," he added.

The IOA CEO, however, admitted that targeting 30 to 40 medals at the 2036 Olympics, for which India is preparing to bid, has placed tremendous pressure on the apex body of Indian sport.

"I think pressure has increased, definitely, but pressure is a privilege. I think we're all in a privileged position to have this pressure, and that pressure comes from India's massive aspiration.

"We're all fortunate to be living in this time when the entire sporting ecosystem is supported by the honourable PM and the honourable sports minister," he said.

He also pointed out that both the public and private sectors have come together to significantly support sports, particularly with the Olympics in mind.

"You would have just seen the capital inflow coming into sport, whether from the government or the private sector, has increased tremendously. Overall, there is a sense of positivity regarding the sports industry. (PTI)



All that changes with the revamped 2028 schedule, including the format.

But what makes sense where to play? "Playing in the Southeast once would be good," Louisiana's Sam Burns said. (AP)